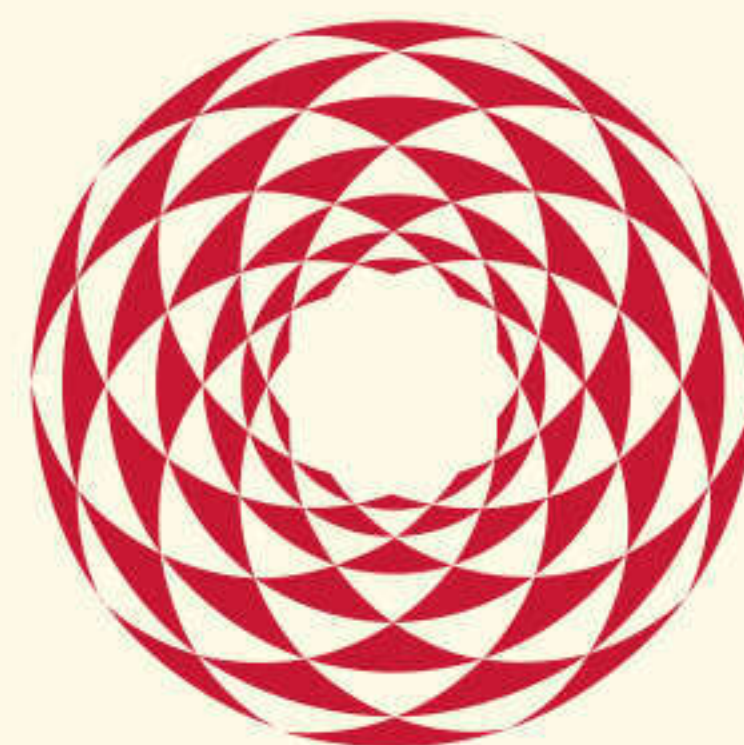




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U.S. THREATS ‘COGNITIVE WARFARE’: IRAN

Trump halts Iran strikes, subject to a ‘rapid’ deal



A US helicopter aboard the USS Michael Murphy, a warship being used by the US in its naval blockade against Iran, Saturday. CENTCOM

Talks between Iran and Oman over Hormuz in final stages: Araghchi

Yasmine Ghania & Menna Alaeldin
Cairo, August 2

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump has said the US will hold off on a fresh attack on Iran as long as a deal can be reached quickly to halt the Islamic nation's nuclear ambitions and reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

Trump said late on Saturday on his Truth Social platform that Iran and other West Asian countries had asked for time to complete a deal that would lead to “the immediate, Complete and Total” reopening of the vital strait and “an end to Iran's nuclear threat”.

He did not name the countries in the post, which followed a call with Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman of Saudi Arabia, a US ally.

“Based on this request, I have agreed, for the future benefit of the WORLD and, likewise, the survival of a successful and prosperous Iran, to cancel the attack, subject to being able to rapidly make a DEAL,” Trump wrote.

E. EXPLAINED

Israel and Iran endorsement key

This latest ‘edition’ of de-escalation comes after President Trump’s meeting with Israeli PM Netanyahu and a phone call with the Saudi Crown Prince — giving it a little more ‘meat’ than the earlier ones. Whether it leads to a concrete peace deal depends on Israel coming on board, Iran responding positively and an arrangement ensuring safe navigation through Strait of Hormuz.

cel the attack, subject to being able to rapidly make a DEAL,” Trump wrote.

Israel “joins me in this commitment”, he said.

Meanwhile, Iran’s Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said on Sunday that negotiations between Iran and Oman over the Strait of Hormuz are in their final stages.

(AP adds: Iran’s Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei said on Sunday that

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EXPRESS special

3.9 lakh cases pending, Centre tells states to set up special courts for drug crimes

Punjab, with 60,000 cases pending, has no special NDPS court; Kerala, with a backlog of 50,000 cases, has just two

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, August 2

INSIDE PAGE 5 PM ASKS YOUTH TO TAKE PLEDGE AGAINST SUBSTANCE ABUSE

WITH ABOUT 3.96 lakh cases under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act pending across the country, the Ministry of Home Affairs has asked all states and Union Territories to set up ex-

clusive courts for narcotics-related cases. The direction came after the MHA was informed in

• States with most pending NDPS cases

States	Pending cases	Special courts	Proposed courts
Punjab	60,000	0	5
Kerala	50,000	2	9
Odisha	17,000	8	0
Tamil Nadu	15,000	5	6
Karnataka	15,000	3	8

SOURCE: MHA MEETING HELD IN JULY

a meeting that 22 states are yet to set up special NDPS courts.

In the last six months, the Union Home Ministry has held

multiple meetings with chief secretaries and home secretaries of states and UTs on the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

After terror attack, J&K plans to move migrant workers to clusters

Decision taken at meeting chaired by L-G Sinha

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, August 2

STEPPING UP surveillance, area domination exercises and night patrolling, and relocating migrants to specific clusters — these are among the measures that Jammu and Kashmir Police has decided to implement a day after two brick kiln workers from Chhattisgarh were shot dead by terrorists in



Security personnel keep vigil on the Jammu-Srinagar National Highway, in south Kashmir's Anantnag district, Sunday. PTI

South Kashmir's Kulgam district.

The decision, taken at a high-

level security review chaired by Lieutenant Governor

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Business as Usual

By EP UNNY



NATION



TASLIMA BACKS UCC IN INDIA, SAYS IT IS NEEDED IN PAK, BANGLADESH TOO
PAGE 7

Happening today

• **RESULTS OF** the by-elections in three Assembly seats — Bankipur (Bihar), Manjapur (Gujarat) and Datia (Madhya Pradesh) — will be declared. All eyes will be on Bankipur, a BJP stronghold, where Jan Suraj Party founder Prashant Kishor made his electoral debut.

• **MONSOON SESSION** of the UP Assembly begins. The Opposition is set to target the state government over issues including the alleged donation theft at the Ram temple in Ayodhya.

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Tech investor Rajan Anandan, Sarvam AI's Pratyush Kumar at Adda today

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 2

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE is redefining industries, economies and geopolitics at an unprecedented pace. As nations compete to build frontier AI capabilities, debates around technological sovereignty, open versus closed-source models, compute infrastructure and the future of large language models are taking centre stage. For India, this is a defining moment — not only to harness AI at scale, but also to build globally competitive AI platforms that reflect



Rajan Anandan; Pratyush Kumar

the country's unique strengths, languages and ambitions.

Few people are better placed to explore these questions than Rajan Anandan, Managing Director at Peak XV Partners, and Pratyush Kumar, Co-founder and CEO of Sarvam



AI, who will be guests at the Express Adda on Monday. They will be in conversation with

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

• ONLY WEIGHTLIFTING LEAVES INDIA WITH MORE QUESTIONS THAN ANSWERS

String of firsts, line of new stars: Glasgow serves hope, Asiad will give reality check

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, August 2

INDIA TRAVELLED to Glasgow with expectations suitably calibrated.

These were, after all, the Commonwealth Games in a scaled-down format. The programme had been trimmed, leaving India with fewer medal prospects. Six of the 12 sports in which India won a medal at the 2022 edition, accounting for 30 of its 61 medals, had been axed. For many athletes, the competition was never meant to be the peak of the season. With the Asian Games looming

• India finish fourth with 39 medals at CWG

Sport	G	S	B	Total
Athletics and Para Athletics	3	7	6	16
Boxing	7	3	0	10
Judo	2	1	1	4
Para Powerlifting	0	0	1	1
Weightlifting	1	6	1	8

next month, Glasgow was seen more as a checkpoint than a destination.

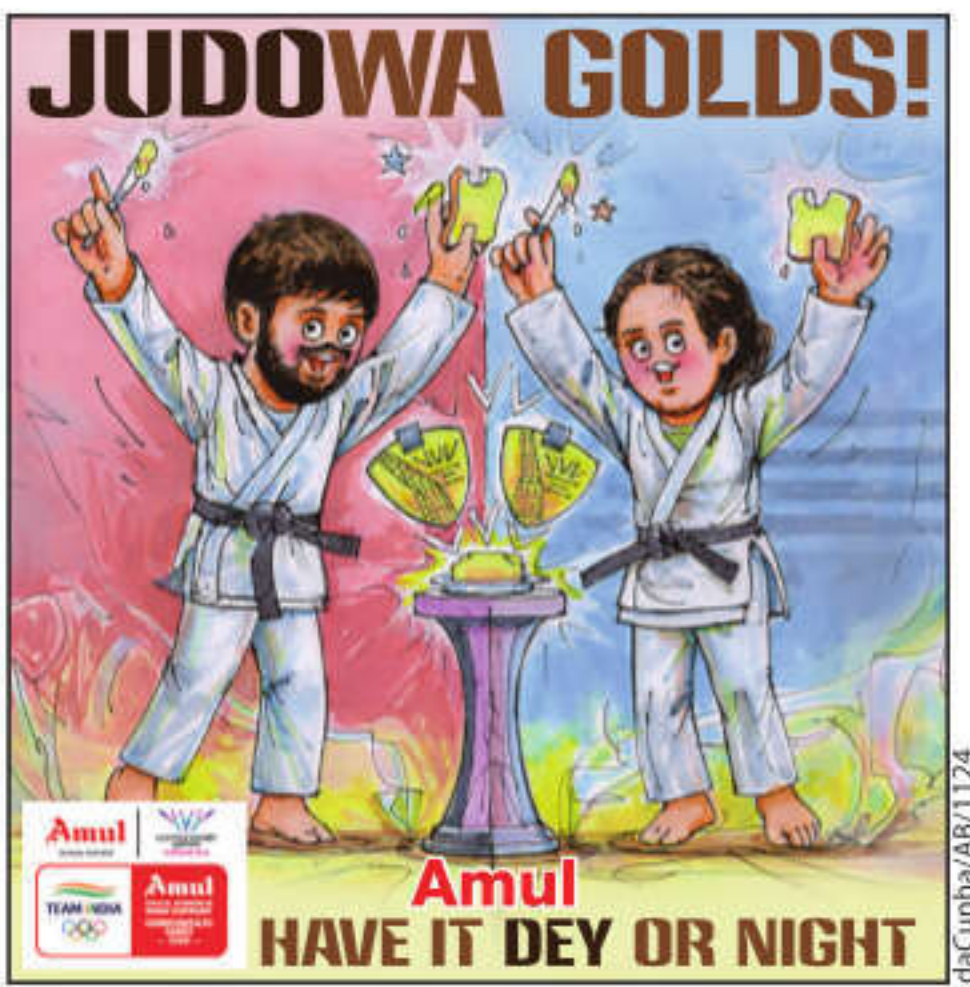
Yet, by the time the curtains came down on Sunday, India's

campaign had become one of its most memorable in recent CWG history — not merely because of the medal tally, with India surpassing expectations to finish

fourth overall with 39 medals, including 13 gold, 17 silver and nine bronze, but because of the number of barriers broken.

It was a Games of firsts. Seven boxing gold medals, India's best-ever return at the Commonwealth Games; Mirabai Chanu becoming the first weightlifter to win three consecutive CWG gold medals; a maiden decathlon medal through Tejaswin Shankar; Gulveer Singh becoming the first Indian to win medals in the men's 5,000m and 10,000m, and the first track and field athlete from the country to win

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



MAHARASHTRA

Probe: After Teachers Eligibility Test, exam for asst professors was target of paper leak gang

Mohamed Thaver
Mumbai, August 2

IF THEIR plan to leak the exam paper for school teachers had succeeded, the next target was the test for recruiting assistant professors in colleges and universities.

This is what Bijendra Gupta, the alleged mastermind in the Teachers Eligibility Test (TET) 2026 question paper leak case in Maharashtra, has allegedly told investigators of the Thane City police, *The Indian Express*

has learnt.

Gupta and other arrested accused also allegedly told police how such gangs leak papers, both offline and online — from staking out printing presses and cultivating junior staff to registering specific computer centres for exams and helping candidates with answers, officers said.

According to police, Gupta's gang was busted two days before the TET exam, for which nearly 6 lakh teachers were due

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



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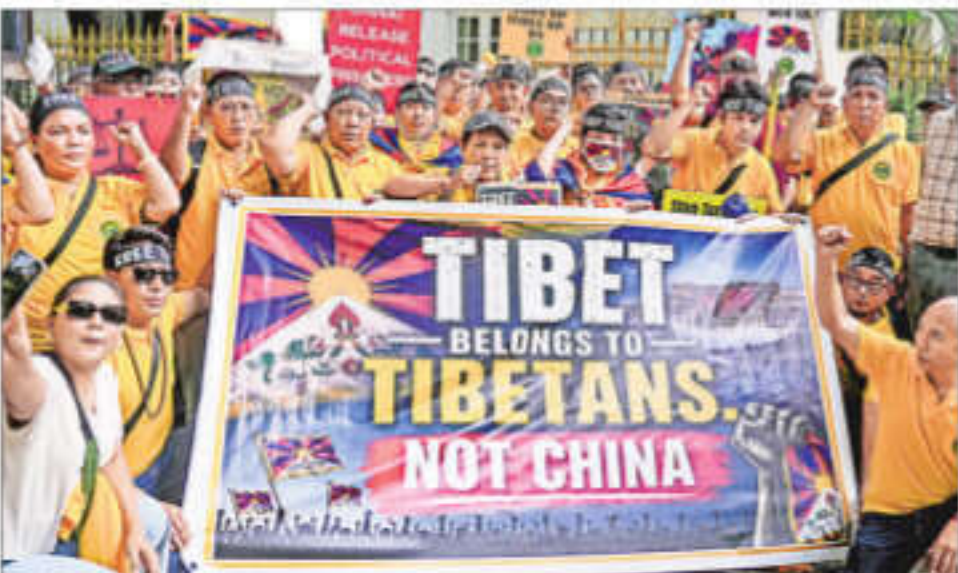
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Protest against China law

Tibetan refugees protest against China's new "Law on Promoting Ethnic Unity and Progress", in Mumbai on Sunday PTI

7 UP cops booked for extorting money from dairy owner

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, August 2

SEVEN UTTAR Pradesh Police personnel, including the station house officer of a police station in Bulandshahr, have been booked for allegedly detaining a businessman, extorting money from him, and threatening to falsely implicate him in a criminal case and shoot him in the leg in a staged police encounter if he failed to comply. Although the alleged incident occurred in April, an FIR was registered only on Friday at the Sikandrabad police station in Bulandshahr. Deepak Kumar, Circle Officer, Bulandshahr, said the case was filed after an inquiry. He said all the police personnel named in the case are under suspension. The FIR has been filed against Sub Inspector Arun Kumar, then SHO Neeraj Malik, Constable Yogesh, and four unidentified police personnel. According to police, Sal-man, who runs a dairy busi-

ness, alleged that he was intercepted by police personnel at a toll plaza on April 30 and forcibly taken to the Sikandrabad police station. Police said Salman alleged that when he repeatedly asked why he had been detained, the accused policemen demanded Rs 20 lakh. He alleged that he was beaten, abused and subjected to intense physical and psychological torture while in custody. Under the alleged coercion, he claimed to have arranged and given Rs 6 lakh to the accused, which his family brought to the police station, after which he was released. The complainant also stated that before letting him go, the policemen allegedly threatened to kill him and falsely implicate both him and his family in fabricated criminal cases if he spoke about the episode. The charges in the case related to voluntarily causing hurt, extortion, wrongful confinement, intentional insult with intent to provoke breach of peace, and criminal intimidation.

CORRECTION

OPINION, 02.08.2026

● In the column History Headline, titled "Santiago to Shopian and Delhi — pellet guns in crowd control", the killing of militant Burhan Wani was stated as having taken place on July 8 last year. Burhan Wani was killed on July 8, 2016. The error is regretted.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Trump halts Iran strikes, subject to ‘rapid’ deal

the Strait of Hormuz “will in no way return to the status it was before February 28th.”) Trump’s apparent de-escalation after days of threats of new attacks from each side was the latest twist in the war the US and Israel launched five months ago. Attacks have spread across the Gulf to the Red Sea and even a Mediterranean facility in Egypt. Eli Cohen, Israel’s energy minister and a member of Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu’s security cabinet, said there was close security and intelligence coordination between Israel and the US on everything happening in the region. But he added: “With or without an agreement, and regardless of any external commitments, if Iran attempts to Renew its nuclear programme or advance its ballistic missile industries, we will be there. We will take action, and we will strike.” Trump and Netanyahu met on Tuesday in Washington, with an Israeli official saying they had explored all possible paths to curb Iran’s nuclear programme, including diplomacy, economic pressure and force. Tehran denies seeking a nuclear weapon. Iran’s acting defence minister, Brigadier General Majid Ebn Al-Reza, said Tehran viewed recent US threats as “psychological and cognitive warfare” but was treating them seriously, adding that Iran would boost preparedness and deterrence rather than be caught off guard or remain passive, *Press TV* re-Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RG9mIjMzgl

ported. In his call with Trump, the Saudi Crown Prince stressed the “necessity of prioritising dialogue to de-escalate tensions” in West Asia, according to Saudi Arabia’s state news agency. A White House official told Reuters that the two had spoken but did not provide details. At a cabinet meeting on Friday, Trump said he believed US negotiators, including his son-in-law Jared Kushner, Special Envoy Steve Witkoff and Secretary of State Marco Rubio, could reach a deal with Iran. Trump has argued that his stated goal of keeping Iran from gaining nuclear weapons justifies higher fuel costs in the near term, but the economic pain has put political pressure on him to find a way to end the war. Adding to the energy industry’s concerns, Iran’s Houthi allies in Yemen in recent days began threatening the Bab el-Mandeb, the strait at the other end of the Red Sea from the Suez Canal, another export route for Saudi crude. The United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations said on Saturday it had received reports of two maritime incidents off Oman. In one, an unknown projectile struck a tanker, damaging the engine room. In the other, the master of a tanker reported seeing a large splash and an explosion close to the vessel, though no damage was reported.

-Reuters

Centre to states: Set up special NDPS courts

establishment of special NDPS courts to tackle the heavy pendency of cases. In a meeting held last month, it was found that Punjab has about 60,000 pending NDPS cases, yet no exclusive special court. “It was suggested by the MHA that five special NDPS courts be set up in Ludhiana, Jalandhar, Amritsar, Tarn Taran and Sangrur,” a source said. “Kerala was said to have about 50,000 pending cases and only two special courts against a suggested nine courts. Officials from Odisha, which has about 17,000 pending cases, said at the meeting that eight special courts would be established this year and seven during 2027-28,” the source said. At the meeting, the Narcotics Control Bureau made a presentation on special NDPS courts and on steps needed to fast-track NDPS Act trials. “The NCB informed that only 65 special courts were currently functioning across India to exclusively deal with matters relating to the NDPS Act,” the source said. In the meeting, it was mentioned that the Supreme Court Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029V/an2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

before the Supreme Court where timelines are fixed and parties are asked to adhere to those,” the source said. Between 2004 and 2014, there were 1,73,000 narco cases in which 1,95,000 arrests were made. “From 2014 to 2026, cases registered climbed up to 8,75,000 and 10,97,000 people were arrested,” an official said. State-wise, the pendency numbers are steep. Tamil Nadu was found to have about 15,000 pending cases and just five special courts. Officials from the state said that six more special NDPS courts have been proposed. Karnataka, with about 15,000 pending cases and three special courts, was advised to set up more special courts, while Madhya Pradesh, with about 14,000 pending cases and no special court, was asked to urgently establish six NDPS courts (in Indore, Bhopal, Neemuch, Mandasaur, Rewa and Singrauli), the source said. West Bengal, with about 11,000 pending cases, doesn’t have a single exclusive court for narcotics matters. It was suggested that six special courts be set up in areas like Kolkata, Howrah, East Bardhaman, Bارات and Berhampore. In Himachal Pradesh, there are around 11,000 pending cases and yet no special court. “State officials said that there was a proposal for setting up five special courts, but it was not accepted by the high court yet. The MHA asked them to send the proposal to the high court again,” the source added. During the 10th apex-level meeting of the Narco-Coordination Centre in June, Union Home Minister Amit Shah had said, “We are geographically situated between the Death Triangle and the Death Crescent. Drug-traffickers have made our fight even more challenging by adopting advanced methods. Along with drug-trafficking, organised crime, narco-terror financing and the funding of cross-border terrorist networks, this problem has also evolved into an evolving narco-terrorism ecosystem. For the internal security of our country, the protection of our economy, and the future of our youth generation, we must achieve complete victory over this menace.”

Tech investor, Sarvam AI CEO at Adda today

Anant Goenka, Executive Director, Indian Express Group, and Soumyarendra Barik, Assistant Editor, *The Indian Express*. One of India’s most influential technology investors, Rajan has spent over two decades shaping the country’s digital ecosystem — from leading Google India and Southeast Asia, and Microsoft India, to backing the next generation of AI and emerging technology startups through Peak XV’s Surge programme. He is a leading voice on India’s AI opportunity, arguing that the country’s success will depend on building affordable, indigenous AI capabilities and a strong innovation ecosystem. Pratyush is among the key architects of India’s sovereign AI movement. Before founding Sarvam AI, he helped build AI4Bharat, one of the country’s most significant open-source initiatives for Indian language AI. Under his leadership, Sarvam has rapidly emerged as a frontrunner in India’s effort to develop homegrown foundation models and full-stack AI infrastructure, with a vision of building AI that is developed, deployed and governed in India for population-scale use cases. Sarvam recently said that it was building a trillion-plus-par-

ameter foundation model from scratch in India, aimed at tasks including coding, cybersecurity, scientific research and simulation. It is pitching its models as a significantly cheaper alternative for enterprise and voice-AI deployments, compared to its American counterparts. The company also announced speech recognition support across all 22 scheduled Indian languages, models to parse through bulk records, and collaborations for sovereign AI in government and regulated sectors. It showcased use cases for its smart glasses, introduced multilingual voice-led commerce, and plans to run India-built AI models aboard an orbital data-centre satellite. The Express Adda is a series of informal interactions organised by The Indian Express Group and features those at the centre of change. Previous guests include Union Ministers S Jaishankar, Mansukh Mandaviya and Hardeep Singh Puri; Nobel Laureate Amartya Sen; Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran; His Holiness the Dalai Lama; cricket icons Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma; chess legend Viswanathan Anand; Olympic gold medalist javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra; and, motivational strategist Gaur Gopal Das.

Congress leader Patole’s feet washed with milk, BJP slams act

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 2

A VIDEO purportedly showing former Maharashtra Assembly Speaker and senior Congress leader Nana Patole having his feet washed with milk by party workers on the occasion of Guru Purnima has gone viral, drawing sharp criticism from the BJP. In the video, Patole is seen seated on a chair, looking at his mobile phone, while two Congress workers wash his feet with milk. They later shower flower petals on him amid prayers and chants. After the brief ceremony, Patole is seen acknowledging the gesture by blessing them. BJP minister Chandrashekar Bawankule said, “This is the state of Congress karyakartas. The workers were washing the feet of leader Nana Patole, who was busy using his phone.” Patole refused to comment on the matter. Several senior Congress leaders and party spokespersons also declined to respond. A Congress leader, requesting anonymity, said, “This is not Congress culture. If the video is genuine, it is very embarrassing. The party leadership will certainly take note of it and take appropriate action.”

Glasgow serves hope

two medals at the same Games; ten track and field medals, led by the para-athletes, who won three golds. This marked India’s best athletics haul outside a home Commonwealth Games. Judo, too, produced golden moments that suggested the sport may finally be ready to move beyond sporadic success. That’s not all. Across sports, new names stepped forward and seized their opportunities. In the boxing ring, Sakshi Chaudhary, who got the nod ahead of former world champion Nikhat Zareen in the women’s 51kg category, announced herself by winning gold. Her fearlessness and swagger illustrated both the competition for places within Indian boxing and the depth in the division. On the track, Gulveer broke new ground, while Tejashvin finally earned a Commonwealth decathlon medal after years of near-misses and interrupted campaigns. Their breakthroughs, along with judo’s emergence, meant Glasgow was less about established names extending their dominance and more about new stories taking shape. The feel-good factor, however, comes with an asterisk. The bigger test will be at the Asian Games, from September 19 to October 4. Take boxing, for instance. The seven gold medals deserve to be celebrated, particularly

given the churn the sport has experienced over the last couple of Olympic cycles. Yet the competitive landscape changes dramatically once Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, China, Japan and other Asian powers enter the fray. Glasgow demonstrated India’s strength within the Commonwealth; Aichi-Nagoya, which hosts the Asiad in Japan, will reveal where it stands in Asia, which in turn will offer a clearer indication of its standing globally. Athletics presents an equally intriguing, though very different, picture. If Glasgow highlighted India’s progress, it also served as a reminder that some of its traditional strengths can no longer be taken for granted. Javelin, transformed over the last decade by Neeraj Chopra, is becoming increasingly competitive across the continent. Pakistan’s Arshad Nadeem had already altered the regional equation; now Sri Lanka’s Rumesh Pathirage has emerged as another genuine challenger. What has long been viewed as India’s signature athletics event could become one of its fiercest battlegrounds at the Asian Games. India’s depth in the event, though, was evident once again as the relatively unknown Yash Vir Singh threw a personal best 85.41m to ensure two Indians finished on the podium.

Paper leak target

to appear across 1,028 centres in the state on June 28 — the test was postponed following the police action. The State Eligibility Test (SET) for assistant professors, meanwhile, was to be held on July 26 but was postponed to September following requests from candidates on a popular pilgrimage in the state and to prevent a clash with the Maharashtra State Public Commission (MPSC) exams. “During interrogation, Bijendra Gupta told us that Sanjay Kumar Sharma, a former employee at the Agra-based printing press from where the TET paper was leaked, had promised to get him the SET paper as well, which was to be printed and dispatched in July,” a police officer said. The officer said they are verifying Gupta’s claims and will ascertain if the SET papers too were printed at the Mahim Patran Pvt Ltd press from where the TET papers were leaked. Authorities at the printing press did not respond to an emailed request for comment from *The Indian Express*. “Gupta has also claimed that Sharma has been in touch with gangs linked to leaking papers across the country and would promise to get them papers in advance in exchange for money,” the officer said. Gupta was arrested on July 25, and Sharma, along with the two employees of the printing press, was held on July 4. Their interrogation also provided a wider picture of how such gangs operate, officers said. “On the offline side, gang members travel across the country to identify which printing presses are involved in printing question papers, stake them out and cultivate junior-level employees who are lured into handing over papers,” said an officer, pointing to the Bihar Public Service Commission leak in 2024 involving a Kolkata press. “Strict checking at printing presses, including removal of belts and shoes, has led accused persons to hide papers below the insole of a shoe to smuggle them out. Another offline route is to cultivate those involved in the paper-setting process itself, as was done during the NEET 2026 papers,” the officer said. On the online side, the accused allegedly told the police that gangs get permission to run computer centres where candidates appear for exams, then let have come along with their families. These kilns are scattered across villages. What we plan to do is move them and their families to a single location in the same village for the night, so that it is easier to secure them. But our overall focus is to create an environment where everyone feels safe,” he said. Field officers have also been asked to increase the security presence through surveillance, night patrolling and area domination in areas inhabited by non-local workers, sources said. As a precautionary measure, some police officers have also asked non-local workers to restrict their movements, especially during the night. To ensure the safety of workers and tourists, police have set up checkpoints on roads that lead to major tourist destinations and intensified vehicle checks and passenger frisking. On Friday evening, two brick kiln workers from Chhattisgarh were killed in a terror attack at Kilam village in South Kashmir’s Kulgam. Police sources say a man entered a brick kiln at Kilam, struck up a conversation with the labourers and shot them dead at point-blank range. They say around 250 non-local workers were present near the site at the time of the attack. The attack, the first on non-local workers since 2024 and the second terror attack in 10 days, has sent the security agencies into a tizzy. The killing of the two migrant workers from Chhattisgarh was the first attack on seasonal migrant workers since October 2024. Police are yet to establish who carried out the attack, but are investigating the anonymous social media posts in which The Resistance Front (TRF), which police say is a shadow group of the Lashkar-e-Toiba, has claimed the attack.

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Skywatch



Forecast: August 3, 2026

Generally cloudy sky. Very light to light rain.

MAX: 31-33

1.4°C below normal

MIN: 23-25

2.1°C below normal

Sunrise: 5:45 AM (August 4)

Sunset: 7:11 PM (August 3)

Moonrise: 9:51 PM (August 3)

Moonset: 10:53 AM (August 4)

AQI Tracker

IGNOU

Good

AQI: 46

Dwarka

Satisfactory

AQI: 76

Alipur

Moderate

AQI: 111

Vivek Vihar

Satisfactory

AQI: 63

● Good (0-50)

● Satisfactory (51-100)

● Moderate (101-200)

● Poor (201-300)

● Very Poor (301-400)

● Severe (401-500)

Air pollution in Capital accelerating Humayun’s Tomb decay: IIT study

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 2

AIR POLLUTION is accelerating the decay of Humayun’s Tomb in Delhi by driving the formation of pollutant-rich black crusts on its sandstone surfaces, according to a joint study by IIT Kanpur and IIT Roorkee of the UNESCO World Heritage Site.

The study, according to the researchers, “provides a multi-analytical evidence base to inform preventive conservation strategies and the prioritisation of cleaning and monitoring actions at this site and at comparable monuments in similarly polluted urban environments”.

Published in the International Journal of Architectural Heritage, the study was carried out by Gaurav Kumar, Bhola Ram Gurjar and Chandra Shekhar Prasad Ojha from the Department of Civil Engineering at IIT Roorkee, along with Mukesh Sharma from IIT Kanpur.

How pollution affects the monument

To understand how pollution affects the monument, the researchers collected five small black crust samples from rain-sheltered rooftop locations of Humayun’s Tomb under the supervision of a conservator from the Archaeological Survey of India.

No sandstone was removed from the monument because of conservation restrictions. Instead, only the thin black deposits that had accumulated on the stone surface were carefully collected using a scalpel, avoiding mortar joints and repaired areas to ensure that no damage was caused to the structure. The samples were collected from different orientations of the rooftop to capture how prevailing winds and environmental exposure influence pollutant deposition.

The sampling locations were chosen based on Delhi’s long-term weather patterns, explains

Disaster Management Act, 2005, and their responsibilities include preparing district-level disaster plans, conducting risk assessments, and coordinating with the National Disaster Response Force, the State Disaster Response Force, Delhi Fire Services, Police and Health departments during emergencies, besides running training programmes and mock drills.

Gupta noted that people holding such post in states like Karnataka, Maharashtra and Uttar Pradesh draw remuneration of around Rs 45,000 to Rs 50,000, calling the disparity inappropriate for “a high-risk metropolitan city like the national capital”. The government said it would also consider future welfare measures, including performance-based annual increments and medical coverage for the officials and their families.

According to the Chief Minister’s Office, the posts of project officers, district project officers and project coordinators were created with support from the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP). However, these posts were never linked to any regular government pay structure or equivalent pay category, and thus the monthly remuneration stayed fixed at Rs 25,000 for project officers and district project officers, and at Rs 20,000 for project coordinators. These officials neither benefited from periodic pay revisions nor received any Dearness Allowance.

The staff discharge statutory functions under the

AHEAD OF INDEPENDENCE DAY

Delhi Police intensifies checks on second-hand car dealers

Car allegedly used in 2025 blast near Red Fort had changed hands multiple times

Alok Singh
New Delhi, August 2

THE DELHI Police, a couple of weeks ahead of the Independence Day, has directed officers to keep a close watch on these second-hand car businesses being run in the city.

The directive came during a meeting chaired by Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar on Saturday wherein Special Commissioner of Police (Special Cell) Anil Shukla briefed officers on the security arrangements.

During the briefing, Station House Officers were instructed to conduct special drives to verify the documentation of second-hand vehicles being sold by dealers of used cars,

The blast in November 2025 had claimed 13 lives. FILE

sources said.

An official source said that verification involving the second-hand car trade is not a new exercise, but special emphasis has been placed on it following a blast near the Red Fort in November 2025.

The blast had claimed at least 13 lives.

The alleged use of a second-hand car in the incident was specifically mentioned during the briefing, and officers were

instructed to ensure the documentation of such vehicles is in order. A Hyundai i20 allegedly used in last year’s attack had changed hands multiple times without the ownership being officially transferred.

Officers were also directed to ensure that stolen vehicles are not being sold through second-hand car dealers.

Delhi has hundreds of second-hand car dealers, many of whom are yet to be regularised

To boost transparency, govt to compensate kin of prisoners who die unnatural death

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 2

FAMILIES OF prisoners who die an unnatural death in Delhi’s jails will now be eligible for compensation ranging from Rs 5 lakh to Rs 7.5 lakh, depending on the circumstances of death, officials said on Sunday. The Delhi government has notified the Scheme for Payment of Compensation on Account of Death of Prisoners in Delhi Prison, 2025, which will apply only to unnatural deaths in the Capital’s prisons.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the scheme, notified in accordance with National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) guidelines, would ensure timely relief to affected families while strengthening administrative accountability.

In a post on X, the CMO wrote, “Under the scheme notified by the Delhi government, Rs 7.5 lakh will be given as assistance in cases of death due to conflicts among prisoners or alleged beatings by jail staff, and Rs 5 lakh in cases of negligence or suicide. Deaths due to natu-

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta

ral causes or illness will not be covered under this scheme.”

The statement quoted Gupta as saying, “This scheme will further strengthen transparency, accountability, human dignity, and the rule of law in the jail administration.”

Any unnatural death, she added, in custody is an extremely serious matter requiring transparency, accountability and due process.

Negligence by prison authorities or staff or medical or paramedical personnel will be accounted for under the scheme. Deaths occurring during an escape from prison or lawful custody, and deaths

The families will now be eligible for compensation ranging from Rs 5 lakh to Rs 7.5 lakh, depending on the circumstances of death

caused by disasters or calamities will also not be covered.

In every case, officials said, the Jail Superintendent concerned will be required to submit the magisterial inquiry report, post-mortem report, final

‘Piecemeal evidence’: Court discharges AAP’s Naresh Balyan in 2023 extortion case

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, August 2

Former Uttam Nagar MLA Naresh Balyan

A DELHI court has discharged former Uttam Nagar MLA and Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) leader Naresh Balyan in a 2023 extortion case as it flagged several lapses in the investigation.

In his order dated July 31, Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate (ACJM) Paras Dalal of the Rouse Avenue Court said, “...the (Delhi) Police report — without explanation — relies heavily upon secondary evidence, and there is also no explanation why primary evidence have not been seized or produced... When the complainant’s phone was available, why was not the same seized and sent for analyses? Why was secondary evidence in the form of a pen drive seized, which was never compared with original recordings in the mobile?”

The extortion case against Balyan stems from a police complaint filed by Gurcharan, a businessman and a resident of Mohan Garden in West Delhi, alleging that in July 2023, he had received an extortion call from gangster Kapil Sangwan demanding Rs 1 crore. Balyan was arrested on November 30, 2024, in the case, hours after the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) released an audio clip of what it claimed was a conversation between him and Sangwan. The same evening, the AAP leader was granted bail in this case. But he was arrested again on December 4, 2024, in another case lodged under the stringent Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act (MCOCA). While Balyan has been discharged in the extortion case, Balyan will continue to remain in jail due to the MCOCA case that claims his alleged involvement in organised crime.

“An investigation registered in July 2023 reached its conclusion only in June 2026. The evidence collected was in piecemeal and in about 36 months, there were bursts of in-

vestigation for a couple of days followed by weeks and months of silence. Certainly, the accused no.1 (Sangwan) is absconding. However, it was only in January 2026 that coercive steps were taken against the said accused, and ultimately he was declared proclaimed person by this Court vide Order dated 06.06.2026,” ACJM Dalal said in his order as he also referred to gangster Sangwan, who is believed to be in the UK.

He added, “Between July 2023 to August 2023, the audio recordings were seized, however, the originals were never traced i.e., complainant’s mobile or the source from where the audio surfaced online on Facebook or reached the news channel. Until November 2024, there is little to no progress to the investigation...there is no explanation as to what hindered police to launch the investigation as soon as FIR was registered in July 2023.”

MCOCA was invoked against gangster Sangwan in 2024 in connection with the extortion case. Police officers said Balyan’s name cropped up in the case as an alleged facilitator to settle the extortion demand made by Sangwan to a businessman. They also claimed they had two statements of witnesses against Balyan.

However, while discharging Balyan in the case, the court also noted that no notice was given to Facebook or the user who had uploaded the recording of the alleged conversation between Balyan and Sangwan.

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Interested agencies are requested to visit the website, www.csma.aadaniairports.com and obtain the EOI documents. EOI documents shall be available for download till 5:00 pm IST on 10th August 2026.

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Website : www.ircon.org, CIN - L45203DL1976GO008171

e-Tender No.: IRCON/2046/NFR-SRRP/Teesta-Station/263

Dated: 03.08.2026

"Construction of Station Buildings, Staff Quarters, Ventilation Buildings, USS, DG Shed and Pump House at the Access Tunnel Portal, including Flooring and Finishing Works of the Access Tunnel and Station Platform, and Strengthening & Improvement of Existing Approach Roads to the T-7 Portals in connection with construction of Sivok - Rangpo new BG Railway Line Project, Northeast Frontier Railway."

Estimated Cost of the work

Rs. 6067.87 Lakhs

Last Date & Time of e-Bid Submission

24.08.2026 up to 3:00 PM

For further details, visit website <https://etenders.gov.in/procure/app>. Corrigendum, if any, would be hosted only on the website.

Executive Director/Projects,

C-4 District Centre, Saket, New Delhi-110017



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ADMISSION NOTICE (2026-27)

Bilaspur, Date- 31.07.2026

Guru Ghasidas Vishwavidyalaya, Bilaspur invites online applications from **eligible candidates** for admission to **various Ph. D. programmes** for the Academic Session 2026-27.

Any eligible candidate may take admission through Vishwavidyalaya Research Entrance Test (VRET). Eligible NET/GATE etc. qualified candidates/ working professionals/staff/international students may apply under VRET Exempted category for direct interview.

Details of subjects available for admission, admission procedure, eligibility criteria, number of seats, reservation policy, fees, fellowship, entrance test date & time, etc. are available on university website www.ggu.ac.in

1. Starting date of submission of Online Application Form : 31.07.2026 (<https://ggvadm.samarth.edu.in/>)

2. Closing date of submission of Online Application forms : 25.08.2026

3. Date of Entrance Test : 20.09.2026 (11.00AM)

4. Declaration of Results : 30.09.2026

Help line: 07752-260342, 9406430720

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epaper.indianexpress.com

New Delhi

2.2 cr DELHI'S POPULATION

1.4 cr TOTAL ELECTORS

13,000+ POLLING STATIONS AND BLOs*
*BOOTH LEVEL OFFICERS32,429 BLAs** APPOINTED BY POLITICAL PARTIES
** BOOTH LEVEL AGENTS

Counting Delhi's Electors

As Delhi revises its electoral rolls, more than 13,000 booth level officers are going door to door ahead of the August 8 deadline.
DEVANSH MITTAL reports on the challenges the ground workers and the electors are facing.

Geeta Devi had climbed the stairs twice before the booth level officer (BLO) told her the documents weren't enough.

The 65-year-old widow disappeared into her one-room home in South Delhi's Sangam Vihar and returned moments later with her voter identity card. Clutching it tightly, she hurried down the stairs, out of breath by the time she reached the two BLOs waiting a few metres away.

Mukesh Chand Meena, the 36-year-old Assistant BLO assigned to Sangam Vihar – one of Asia's largest unauthorised colonies – glanced at the card for barely a moment before handing it back. "I need your voter ID from 2002," he said.

Geeta, who lives alone in Block A of Sangam Vihar, looked at him blankly. She began voting only in 2009 when, she recalled, a local BJP worker had helped many residents in the neighbourhood obtain voter identity cards. Before that, she had never appeared on Delhi's electoral rolls.

"No problem," Mukesh said, pulling out his phone and opening the Election Commission of India's ECINET application. "We'll link it to your parents. Where did you come to Delhi from?"

"Kanpur," Geeta replied.

His thumb scrolled across the screen as he began reading out constituency names. "Govind Nagar. Kanpur Cantonment. General Ganj. Sisamau..."

She frowned. "I came here in 2002," she said. "I don't remember where I lived back then."

"Do you have any relatives there?" Mukesh asked.

"No."

By now, a handful of neighbours had wandered over, listening quietly as the conversation unfolded.

Mukesh explained that he would accept her enumeration form but place it in the category of electors who could not establish a link to the 2002 electoral rolls. After the draft electoral roll is published, she would receive a notice asking her to produce a government document establishing her date and place of birth. The explanation only deepened her confusion. "I've been voting for so long. Why are you troubling me now?" she said.

The exchange is becoming a familiar across the Capital. As BLOs fan out through Delhi for the ECI's Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral rolls, thousands of electors who enrolled after 2002 are being asked to establish a link with the electoral rolls as they existed on January 1, 2002.

For many, especially migrants and older residents who no longer possess decades-old records, the request has triggered confusion and anxiety.

"*Mataji*," Mukesh replied gently. "We

We know you're a genuine voter. But now the government wants documentary proof for everything."

MUKESH CHAND MEENA, ASST BLO, SANGAM VIHAR

When we set up camps here, only two or three people show up in four hours... Everybody wants us to come to their homes and collect the forms."

AMIT KUMAR, BLO, KAILASH COLONY

know you're a genuine voter. But now the government wants documentary proof for everything."

Someone in the crowd offered a suggestion. "You receive a widow's pension.. show that document." Geeta shook her head. "Our legs are giving way. At this age, they'll make us run from one government office to another," she said.

The South district, where Sangam Vihar is located, has till last week recorded the highest number of exclusions during the exercise – more than 1.5 lakh. Officials in the Chief Electoral Officer's office earlier told *The Indian Express* that they expect around 30% to 40% of names across Delhi to be deleted from the electoral rolls. "Delhi has a large population of migrant labourers, government employees and private-sector professionals, all of whom move frequently and often do not update their addresses," one official said. "This is why the deletions may exceed 30%." Officials say urban areas typically see more deletions than rural areas because of their larger floating populations.

On ground

More than 13,000 BLOs are racing to complete Delhi's voter-roll revision before the August 8 deadline. Around noon, Mukesh and Shakuntala walk Sangam Vihar's broken lanes with jute bags full of enumer-



Assistant block level officer Mukesh Chandra Meena interacts with residents in Sangam Vihar; (below) BLO Amit Kumar at a house in Kailash Colony. GAJENDRA YADAV



ation forms, knocking on doors before time runs out. At House No. 210, the two school-teachers ring all eight doorbells of a four-storey building.

"The new owner has rented out all eight rooms to labourers. They're all out at work," a neighbour tells them.

Mukesh pulls out the enumeration forms of 10 members of one family and slips them into a folder marked "Shifted".

"Since a lot of labourers live here, people move frequently and don't update their addresses," he says. "Some have even completed the SIR in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar because they need address proof in their villages."

Under ECI guidelines, BLOs are expected to visit every household at least three times before marking it "Uncollectible" — a category that includes electors who are absent, have shifted, have died, have duplicate entries, or fall under "other" reasons.

By Wednesday, Shakuntala had digitised 558 of the 1,497 electors assigned to her. Digitisation involves collecting completed enumeration forms and uploading their details to the ECI's portal.

But, she says, three visits are rarely enough. "We visit houses five or six times," she says. "If I start showing too many people as shifted, our superiors will question whether they have actually shifted. We also wait until the end because someone may still return and submit the form later. We don't want any genuine elector to be left out."

Mukesh says another reason the work takes time is that many electors, including literate ones, struggle to fill out the forms on their own. "We end up filling most of the forms ourselves," he says.

Together, they estimate that around 40% of the names on their lists belong to people who have shifted since the last SIR.

A few lanes away, they stop outside another house they have already visited several times. After the third visit, they pasted a notice informing the residents that failure to submit the forms could result in their names being struck off the electoral roll. The notice, they say, was later torn down by a

resident. This time, the family's eldest son hands over the completed forms and tells them that two members of the household have moved away. As Shakuntala checks the paperwork, she spots an error. "You have to fill in the details of your wife's parents or grandparents in the 2002 electoral rolls," she tells him. "You can't link it to yourself."

The family goes back inside to look for the information while Mukesh and Shakuntala wait outside for nearly an hour. Eventually, they pick up their jute bags and bundles of forms and decide to return later. Their next destination is House No. 307.

There is only one problem. "There are four houses numbered 307," someone in the neighbourhood tells them. "All of them have four storeys." The two officers nod to each other and begin ringing doorbells again.

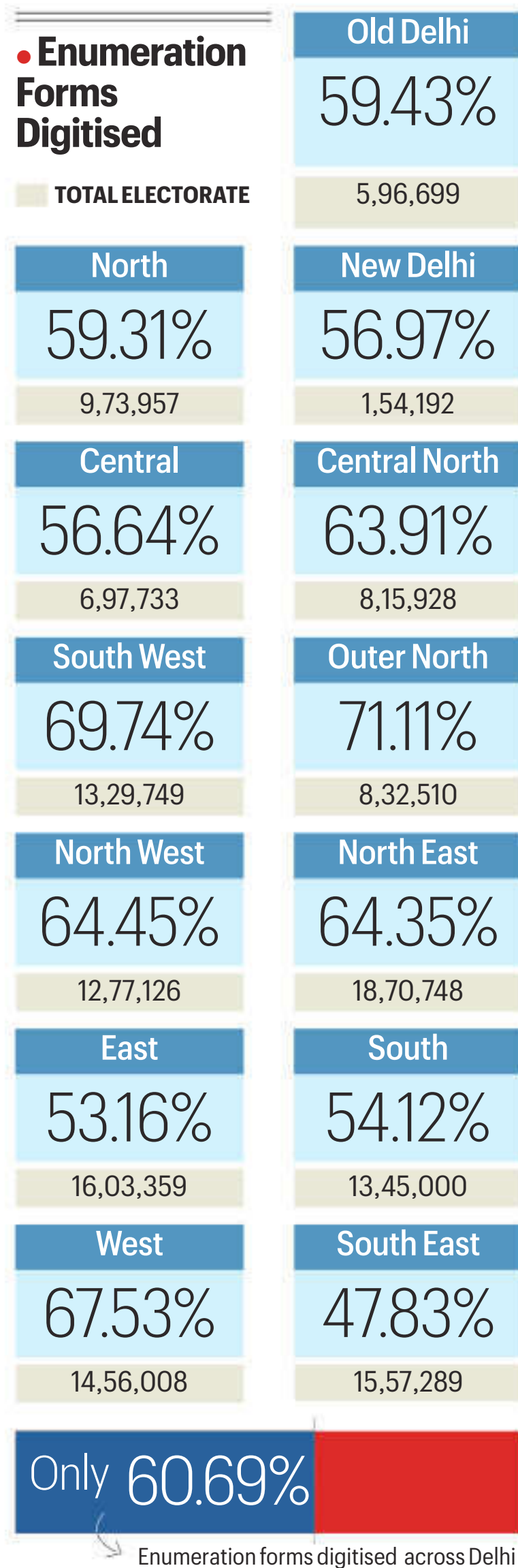
An official from the Chief Electoral Officer's office claimed that while digitisation in the city is currently at 60%, forms have been collected for closer to 80% of the population, and the rates will go up significantly over the next few days. "We will not extend the deadline once more as the exercise is under control," the official said. The Delhi Chief Electoral Officer did not respond to queries sent by *The Indian Express*.

The exercise has also become a political flashpoint.

The Aam Aadmi Party has questioned the manner in which the SIR is being carried out. "The BJP government's claims that 99% of the forms have been distributed, which is entirely wrong," Delhi AAP chief Saurabh Bharadwaj alleged at a press conference last week. He claimed that nearly 50% of residents in unauthorised colonies said they had not received the SIR forms.

A BJP source, however, said a large number of people were expected to submit their forms in the final days before the deadline. The source added that many electors in Delhi had become accustomed to remaining on the electoral rolls both in the capital and in their hometowns.

"During elections, you will see many lower-income electors returning to their villages to vote. They want to remain registered there because they receive government



SOURCE: DELHI CEO OFFICE DATA AS OF 8 PM ON AUGUST 2

● Top 5 states in deletions at draft stage

STATES	DELETIONS
Arunachal Pradesh	19.09%
Uttar Pradesh	18.07%
Haryana	16.39%
Tamil Nadu	15.19%
Gujarat	14.50%

benefits, such as financial assistance to build a toilet or a house, which they do not get in Delhi. Many people, especially those living in slums and low-income colonies, have their names on the electoral rolls in both places. One of those registrations will now be deleted," a senior BJP functionary said.

A different Delhi, different challenges

About 10 km from Sangam Vihar, the challenge looks very different. In the affluent neighbourhood of Kailash Colony, BLO Amit Kumar expects that 20% to 30% of the names on his electoral roll could eventually be deleted. But unlike in Sangam Vihar, where migration, missing documents and decades-old electoral records dominate the exercise, Kumar spends much of his time persuading residents to participate at all.

With a blue bag of enumeration forms strapped to his scooter, the 33-year-old government school special educator rides through the tree-lined lanes of L Block, pointing out homes whose residents have moved away. An elderly couple now lives with their son in Noida, a family of five has shifted to another block, and one house has given way to a four-storey apartment building. He has been the area's BLO for the past three years. "Most of these families also got voter IDs made for their house helps," Kumar says. "And many of them employ several house helps. So when they move, those names also have to be deleted."

On the fourth floor of one building, Kumar rings a doorbell for the fourth time in as many visits. Weeks earlier, he had left the family's enumeration forms with their house help. A young man opens the door. "Who are you?" he asks. "I'm from the ECI," Kumar replies. "I came regarding the SIR. I had left the enumeration forms with your house help a few weeks ago. Have you filled them?"

"There are guests at home. Come back tomorrow and I'll get your work done," the man says.

"This is not my work," Kumar replies, his voice tightening. "I'm making this effort to keep your name on the voter list. I won't come again. The deadline is very close now. If you want to submit the forms, you'll have to bring them to me. And if there are mistakes, I may not have time to point them out." He turns and walks away.

Residents sometimes refuse to believe Kumar is on SIR duty and ask him to leave. Once, he says, a resident let a dog loose on him. Because his phone number is printed on every enumeration form, calls come early in the morning and late into the night.

Till Wednesday, Kumar has digitised 611 of the 1,035 electors assigned to him.

He believes many residents simply do not feel any urgency. "When we set up camps here, only two or three people show up in four hours," he says. "The whole day gets wasted. Everybody wants us to come to their homes and collect the forms."

"They're not afraid," he says. "Getting their names removed from the electoral roll means nothing to them."



Debut Dance

SEVERAL MPS from across party lines turned up to watch the debut solo Kuchi-pudi performance of Rash-triya Lok Dal leader and Union Minister Jayant Chaudhary's younger daughter Ilesha Singh on Saturday evening. Among the attendees were Anurag Thakur, Surendra Singh Nagar, Kartikeya Sharma, R P N Singh, Rajiv Shukla, Rajeev Rai, Mahima Kumari Mewar, Sangeeta Kumari Singh Deo, and Rajeev Rai. Chaudhary's ministerial colleague Anupriya Patel was also seated in the front row. MPs who otherwise leave for their respective constituencies on weekends stayed back to mark their presence. Ilesha's guru Raja Reddy had special words of praise for Chaudhary and his wife Charu for introducing both their daughters to the traditional dance form.

Humid, Humane

Former South Delhi BJP MP Ramesh Bidhuri cut short his speech at a "Gen Z sam-melan" due to inclement weather conditions on Sunday. Among the party's first offline events of its kind aimed at reaching out to the youth in the wake of violent clashes between protesters and security personnel in Delhi last month, Bidhuri cut short his address after observing that the young attendees were visibly uncomfortable due to high humidity, leaving the stage open to Delhi Minister Ashish Sood.

CJP protest anti-national, should be seen as case study, says RSS leader

Shubhangi Khapre
Mumbai, August 2

URGING RIGHT-WING organisations to view the recent CJP protests in Delhi as a crucial case study, RSS Sahsarkarya-vah (joint general secretary) Atul Limaye has termed the protest "anti-constitutional" and "anti-national".

Limaye was addressing ABVP activists in Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar earlier this week. He indicated that while the initial student expression over the NEET paper leak was spontaneous, the CJP-led protest was well-orchestrated with a larger political objective. He added that the Left's concept of "alternative politics" was successfully tested through the agitation.

Citing Dr B R Ambedkar's "Grammar of Anarchy" speech, Limaye said, "Dr Ambedkar had warned about anarchists long ago. Now is the time to decode this, understand it, and take precautions against such anarchist forces." "The student agitation originating from paper leak was meant to rectify a wrong in education system. However, it fell into hands of the wrong people," Limaye said. "CJP agitation should be seen as a case study and decoded. The chronology of the CJP, its methodology, support system, and ideological backing must be understood in detail."

He pointed out that CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke did not receive much initial support upon his return to India and subsequent nationwide tour. "After June 20, the protest grew significantly, drawing large crowds and support. What exactly happened between Dipke's arrival and June 20? What changed the course of this agitation, and which support systems joined it? These aspects must be unravelled."

'NASHA MukT YUVA FOR VIKSIT BHARAT SANKALP ABHIYAN' LAUNCH

PM: Youth who overcome addiction are real warriors

Says society must embrace them, give second chance

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 2

LAUNCHING THE 'Nasha MukT Yuva for Viksit Bharat Sankalp Abhiyan' on Sunday, Prime Minister Narendra Modi focused not only on keeping the youth away from drugs but also giving second chances to those who have been addicted. He said that facilities such as rehabilitation centres can help them. "Drugs give a temporary high, but they cause a long-term low in your career and family life. We must not give any form of acceptance to addiction," the PM said, urging parents to have open communication with their children to detect early signs of addiction. If a child gets addicted to



PM Narendra Modi during the launch of 'Nasha MukT Yuva for Viksit Bharat Sankalp Abhiyan' in New Delhi on Sunday. ANI
Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGF9mljMzgl
substances, he said, parents should not hide it under the guise of social prestige. "Seek necessary support, communicate openly with the child and enlist the help of experts. Make an effort to help your child overcome addiction through medical assistance," he said. "The youth who come out fighting addiction are not weak, they are real warriors whose incredible courage is their true identity," he added. "Society should respect them, embrace them and give them a second chance," he said.

tion has set the goal of a Viksit Bharat, it is imperative the country's youth remain physically and mentally fit, brimming with self-confidence, and permanently steer clear of destructive habits like drugs," he said. The PM also said that addiction not only harms the body, but "family members live with this pain every day, watching their children gradually lose themselves before their eyes". Modi also said the government stands firmly with the youth in this campaign against drugs. "Arrests have gone up several times as compared to before, and drugs worth thousands of crores of rupees have been seized." Outlining the campaign's 100-week roadmap, he detailed how the coming Sundays will feature dedicated activities spanning art, culture, sports, and meditation. "The coming 100 Sundays will absolutely become 100 strong steps in the direction of a completely drug-free India."

EXPRESS special

In Kishor's first election, real battle played out behind the scenes in Bankipur

Bypoll results out today; will determine whether JSP's 'professional' campaign can give BJP tough fight in its bastion

Sudhakar Singh
New Delhi, August 2

AT 7 AM, Pawan Yadav is already out on Bankipur streets. His day rarely ends before 2am, after the final booth reports are submitted and a review meeting usually chaired by JSP founder Prashant Kishor wraps up. A few kilometres away, BJP volunteer Rahul Pandey follows a different routine but works equally long hours. He spends his day organising meetings, coordinating with senior leaders, going door to door, and ensuring every assigned booth remains covered. Both camps approached the July 30 bypolls differently but left no stone unturned to ensure victory for their respective candidates — Kishor of the JSP, who made his electoral debut in the bypoll, and Neeraj Kumar Sinha of BJP.

The results will be announced on Monday along with Datia in MP and Manjalpur in Gujarat, but the real contest was not confined to campaign stages. It was fought by hundreds of political workers, consultants and volunteers who spent weeks trying to persuade, organise and mobilise voters. For Kishor, it was the first test of whether the organisation he built through his statewide padyatra could transform his outfit, launched in 2024, into

an electoral force. In 2025 Bihar polls, JSP fought in all 243 seats but failed to win a single seat. Its Bankipur candidate got less than 5% of the votes. For BJP, Bankipur has been its bastion since the constituency was created following the 2008 delimitation. BJP chief Nitin Nabin represented the seat for five consecutive terms before vacating it after being elected to RS. His father, Nabin Kishore Prasad Sinha, had represented the adjoining Patna West constituency before him. This is also the party's first electoral test after Samrat Choudhary became Bihar's first BJP CM in April. The party fielded grassroots leader Sinha and deployed around 40 star campaigners, along with more than a thousand workers from across the state. The campaign, however, boiled down to two very different political machineries. Pawan, a resident of Muzaffarpur, has worked with JSP's professional team for three years. Following the 2025 rout, the party downsized its campaign but he was among around 100 employees retained. He was sent to Bankipur the day the bypoll was announced. Pawan was assigned 4 booths and operated from what the party calls an "adda" — a neighbourhood-level campaign hub where booth strategy was planned and



Police outside a counting centre in Patna on Sunday. ANI

monitored. "There hasn't been a single Sunday off," he says. For nearly a month, the team worked into the night. In the campaign's final phase, most meals came from the party office. Before that, workers ate wherever they could find food. Around 250 professionals worked on the campaign. Separate teams handled women voters, caste outreach and booth management. The biggest challenge, Pawan says, converting supporters into workers. JSP wanted every booth committee to have around 20 volunteers. Most booths could gather only 7-10. "Many of them were ordinary people like shopkeepers, not political workers," he says. If JSP relied on professionals, BJP depended on an organisation built over decades. "Shayad hi koi zila hoga jaha se party ke log nhi aaye ho (There would hardly be any district of the state from where workers have not come)," a BJP worker says. "Everyone is in Bankipur."

BJP assigned MLAs responsibility of clusters of booths across the seat's more than 420 polling stations. During the final phase of campaigning, it also set up "booth sahayata kendras". Rahul Pandey was among those on the ground. Initially assigned to assist party's professional social media team, he was later shifted to fieldwork. His responsibilities included organising public meetings, going door to door, and assisting senior leaders during campaign. Was this election tougher than previous ones? Rahul says it was. "There was some dissatisfaction among people from my community over UGC issue," he says. "But a person may be upset with his own family. Where else will he go?" For election observers, Bankipur is a contest between two organisational models. JSP tried to run a tightly managed campaign driven by professionals. BJP leaned on its long-established cadre network and organisational depth.

Cauvery row: Vijay defers visit to Karnataka, his minister says

DKS 'listens to Stalin, not Cong'

Arun Janardhanan
& Akram M
Chennai, Bengaluru, August 2

BARELY DAYS after Tamil Nadu CM C. Joseph Vijay sought direct talks with Karnataka over the Cauvery dispute, one of his senior ministers on Sunday escalated the political confrontation, alleging that Karnataka CMD K Shivakumar takes instructions from the DMK leadership rather than his own party.

Tamil Nadu's Energy Resources and Law Minister, R Nirmalkumar, on Sunday alleged that Shivakumar was functioning less as a senior minister of Karnataka and more as a political ally of the DMK. "D K Shivakumar does not listen even to the Congress leadership. He listens only to (former TN CM and DMK chief) M K Stalin," Nirmalkumar told reporters. "If Stalin tells him, he will listen. If this family tells him, he will listen. That is how close the relationship between the two of them is."

Meanwhile, DK Shivakumar, who earlier in the day chaired an all-party meeting on the Cauvery water dispute following direction from the Cauvery Water Management Authority and the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee, told reporters that Vijay has agreed to defer his proposed visit to Bengaluru following a request from the Karnataka government.

"I have great respect for him. Though he may be new to politics, he is a courageous leader," said Shivakumar. "I congratulated him on his bold decision. Whatever our political differences may be, he wanted to come to Karnataka. I only requested that we meet in a better and more cordial atmosphere because I don't want anyone shouting against my friends."

On the contentious Meke-Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>



Karnataka CM D K Shivakumar, Union Minister H D Kumaraswamy, former CMs Siddaramaiah and B S Yediyurappa during an all-party meeting in Bengaluru on Sunday. ANI

datu Balancing Reservoir project, Shivakumar described it as a long-term solution to the Cauvery issue. "If the Mekedatu reservoir is built, nearly 90% of the benefit will go to Tamil Nadu, more than Karnataka. At no point can that water be diverted back to Bengaluru. Anyone can visit the project site and understand the facts."

The all-party meeting was attended by Union Ministers H D Kumaraswamy, Shobha Karandlaje, and former Karnataka CMs Siddaramaiah and B S Yediyurappa, among others.

In Tamil Nadu politics, ministers criticise opposition leaders, but publicly accusing the CM of a neighbouring state of taking political instructions from an opposition party in TN is considerably rarer. Coming from Nirmalkumar, the remarks also carry unusual weight.

Within TVK, he has increasingly emerged as one of the government's principal political communicators, articulating the administration's position on contentious issues — from corruption investigations to the Cauvery dispute.

The remarks on Sunday also reflect a stark shift in tone. Only

last week, Vijay had attempted to open a political channel with Karnataka by proposing a meeting with Shivakumar over the Cauvery water dispute. Inside the ruling party, some leaders now privately concede that the initiative yielded little. One senior TVK leader acknowledged that the proposed talks "neither materialised nor helped the process" and instead "put the government in a tight spot." Nirmalkumar's remarks suggest the government has now moved from outreach to confrontation.

He alleged that DMK has deliberately tried to create the impression that Vijay stood politically isolated after Stalin criticised the proposed Karnataka visit. He accused DMK of rushing independently to the Supreme Court on Cauvery issue after the government had already begun preparations to move the SC itself. "If multiple petitions are filed by the same state in such a matter, how much confusion would that create? To what extent would it push back the State's rights?"... What did they do over the past five years? Did DMK file even a single petition on this issue? No."

BJP: Shinde must act against 2 Sena leaders who met Dipke, kin

Manoj More
Pune, August 2

SIGNALLING A friction within the Mahayuti in Maharashtra, BJP has sought action from Deputy CM Eknath Shinde against the two Shiv Sena leaders who had met CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke and his parents in Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar.

"Eknath Shinde should take strict action against such individuals," Revenue Minister and senior BJP leader Chandrashekar Bawankule said on Sunday.

The two leaders, Sanjay Shirsat and Bachchu Kadu, visited Dipke and his parents at his residence in Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar last week. Shirsat is the District Guardian Minister of Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar, while Kadu is an MLC.

Bawankule said though it their party's internal matter, Eknath Shinde should decide how his party leaders ought to behave. "Such conduct while

working within the Mahayuti alliance is not appropriate," Bawankule said.

Similarly, another BJP leader Pravin Darekar said the meeting of two Shiv Sena leaders with Dipke has sent out a wrong signal. "While Opposition parties' behavior is understandable, it sends a wrong message when Sanjay Shirsat and Bachchu Kadu visit Abhijeet Dipke at his home. It is improper for leaders of a ruling coalition party to visit the leader of an agitation that attempted to tarnish the government's image," he said.

He alleged that Bachchu Kadu visited Dipke for publicity. Emphasising that the actions of Shirsat and Kadu could widen the rift between Shiv Sena and BJP within the Mahayuti, he demanded that party leadership should reprimand both of them.

On July 26, Shirsat met the parents of Dipke before he returned from New Delhi when their agitation was called off in

the wake of the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Shirsat had promised that their son would get official security cover. "I will personally make a special request to CM Devendra Fadnis to provide him with official security so that no threat is posed to his life," the Shiv Sena leader had said.

Shirsat was the first leader from Mahayuti government to communicate with Dipke's parents. Later, Kadu met Dipke after his return from New Delhi on July 30. Shirsat had said, "We have family relations with the Dipke family. I did not visit during the protests to ensure the matter was not given a political turn. Now, I have come to inquire about Abhijeet's health, and the government will take proper care of him."

Kadu had said, "If Dipke is going to agitate on behalf of farmers, showing a mirror to the government is not wrong."

SEVERAL EMPLOYEE UNIONS & YOUTH GROUPS IN PUNJAB HAVE INTENSIFIED AGITATIONS OVER VARIOUS ISSUES; AAP GOVT'S HANDLING OF SEVERAL PROTESTERS ALSO UNDER ATTACK FROM OPP

Streets a new headache for Mann govt: As polls approach, protests pile up

Raakhi Jagga
Ludhiana, August 2

MONTHS AHEAD of Punjab elections, the AAP government is facing mounting protests from multiple quarters, with employee unions, contractual workers, unemployed youth and pension-seekers stepping up agitations over wages, recruitment, job security and unfulfilled promises. Since early July, the Bhagwant Mann-led government has found itself firefighting one protest after another, as simultaneous strikes by sanitation workers, power employees, MGNREGA staff and Aam Aadmi Clinic employees have tested administration's ability to manage industrial unrest while containing the political fallout. While employee unions have routinely agitated over wages, service conditions and recruitment, the scale of demonstrations since July 8 has made this one of government's most challenging phases. The biggest challenge re-

mains the indefinite strike by municipal Safai Sewaks and sewer-men. It began on July 8 across around 120 urban local bodies and spread to more than 150 civic bodies after the July 22 police lathi charge on protesting sanitation workers in Barnala. The strike has disrupted the lifting of nearly 470 tonnes of garbage every day during peak monsoon season. Despite several rounds of talks, the strike has expanded to Ludhiana Municipal Corporation, the state's largest civic body. To break the deadlock, Minister Harjot Singh Bains last week announced that the salary of Safai Sewaks would be raised from Rs 14,000 to Rs 20,520 with effect from August 1, besides promising other reforms. The government also faced a major challenge in the power sector, where more than 19,000 Punjab State Power Corporation Limited (PSPCL) staff remained on strike from July 21-26. The agitation delayed restoration of power faults in rural and urban areas, putting AAP MLAs under



The government's biggest challenge remains the indefinite strike by municipal Safai Sewaks and sewer-men. EXPRESS FILE

pressure from constituents. AAP Punjab chief Aman Arora said the strike had affected electricity supply to more than 3 crore residents. A series of meetings between the government and employee representatives ended the impasse, with government assuring them their demands would be addressed by August 15. Punjab State Electricity Board Employees Federation leader Gurpreet Singh Mehodan said employees had raised

33 demands, including implementation of the Rs 35,400 pay scale, withdrawal of July 17, 2020 order reducing employees' pay scales, payment of the pending 18% DA, regular recruitment and restoration of OPS. The government also had to defuse another politically sensitive confrontation with MGNREGA employees, who had been on strike since June 1 demanding release of nearly five months' pending wages and regularisation. The agita-

tion forced government to postpone the launch of Centre's VB-GRAM-G scheme until July 30. The dispute escalated after the Rural Development and Panchayat Department warned employees that failure to sign fresh contracts under the new scheme by July 18 would lead to termination. The order was later withdrawn. Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema, who led negotiations, said issues relating to service conditions, contractual tenure, migration to the VB-GRAM-G framework, remuneration and administrative matters had been resolved, and that genuine demands of 2,000 employees had been accepted. The government continues to face protests by Berozgar Sanjha Morcha, whose members have been camping outside Sangrur DC's office since December 25 last year. Members of the organisation regularly attempt to protest during the CM's programmes in Sangrur and elsewhere. Ahead of Mann's programme Friday, several office-bea-

rs of the morcha were detained Thursday. State convener Sukhwinder Singh Dhillon alleged that police reached his residence in Barnala district to detain him, but he was not at home. The morcha is demanding a five-year age relaxation in recruitment, filling of vacant government posts and relaxation in eligibility criteria for Master Cadre teacher recruitment. On July 27, employees of all 880 Aam Aadmi Clinics observed a day-long strike seeking better wages and leave benefits. Doctors, clinical assistants and pharmacists, who are paid on the basis of patient footfall, alleged they were denied weekly offs and risked termination if absent for three consecutive days. Meanwhile, protests over alleged irregularities in pharmacist recruitment exams have continued across the state. Sangrur, the CM's home district, has emerged as a symbolic centre of protests, with employee and youth organisations frequently assembling there. Anganwadi workers also staged

a protest near the gated colony where Mann has official accommodation. The government's handling of protests has also come under scrutiny. Apprentice linemen seeking PSPCL jobs were lathi-charged on June 5, MGNREGA workers were cane-charged in Khanna on July 15, and sanitation workers were baton-charged in Barnala on July 22. "Action was taken only after the Barnala incident, when DSP Satvir Singh Bains and SHO Lakhwinder Singh were suspended. Otherwise, force is used against protesters almost everywhere," a BJP leader said on condition of anonymity. Punjab BJP chief Kewal Singh Dhillon alleged that the AAP government had failed to fulfil poll promises. "Those demanding their legitimate rights are facing lathi-charge. Punjab has been reduced to a dharna land," he said. "AAP made many promises before the 2022 elections, but could not fulfil most of them. So these protests were expected," he said.

Maya expels nephew Akash's father-in-law from BSP again

Lalmani Verma
Lucknow, August 2

BSP PRESIDENT Mayawati on Sunday expelled nephew Akash Anand's father-in-law Ashok Siddharth, whose expulsion was revoked in September last year, and another national coordinator Randhir Singh Benival from the party for indiscipline and violating party's directives.

A former Rajya Sabha member, Siddharth was the BSP's central coordinator with responsibilities of the party's Odisha, West Bengal and Karnataka units.

In a post in Hindi on X, Mayawati said he was stripped of his organisational roles in these states Saturday over reports of indiscipline and not adhering to the party's directives.

"But after this, reports of his return to UP are a deliberate conspiracy to create confusion within the party and affect the intensive campaign for the upcoming UP Assembly general elections. Therefore, in the interest of the party and the movement, Ashok Siddharth has been expelled from the party with immediate effect today, and he will not be taken back into the party under any circumstances," Mayawati said in the post. Siddharth's earlier ouster was on charges of groupism and alleged involvement in anti-party activities.



Police inspect the site of the incident. EXPRESS

Bihar officer killed over toilet stop, driver arrested; wife alleges 'political conspiracy'

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, August 2

A MAN has been arrested for allegedly killing Dehri-Dalmianagar Municipal Council Executive Officer Vimal Kumar after an argument that allegedly broke out during their drive home. The killing has led Kumar's family to allege a political conspiracy by a local MLA, which the latter has denied.

Vimal Kumar left Rohtas for the four-hour drive to Patna with his driver, Mithilesh Kumar, after an official programme on Saturday evening, police said. Mithilesh Kumar was arrested for allegedly killing Kumar after an argument during the journey. The incident has led to a political storm.

"The driver initially informed police that unidentified assailants had attacked the executive officer and that he died while being taken to hospital," said Aurangabad Superintendent of Police (SP) Upendra Nath Verma.

An FIR invokes murder charges under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). Police said inconsistencies in the driver's statements led to his arrest. "Later, he claimed there was only one. As the story kept changing, police became suspicious," Magadh Range IG Vikas

Taslima pitches for UCC in India, says Bangladesh, Pak need it too

Sweetie Kumari
Kolkata, August 2

EXILED BANGLADESHI author Taslima Nasrin on Sunday pitched for the implementation of Uniform Civil Code (UCC) in India, asserting that such a law was necessary to eliminate discrimination, especially against women. She also advocated for a similar law in neighbouring Bangladesh and Pakistan.

Addressing a press conference in Kolkata, Nasrin, who returned to the city after 19 years, said, "I have been fighting for UCC for the last 40 years. This is much needed in any civilised country. In Bangladesh, Hindu women have no rights. They cannot inherit their father's property. They do not even have the right to divorce. If Hindu women are to enjoy freedom and equal rights, a Uniform Civil Code is necessary. Due to religious laws, Hindus are being tortured in Bangladesh. Under the Muhammad Yunus-led interim government, Hindus were tortured even more. In several madrasas and mosques, there are teachings that foster anti-Hindu sentiments. Bangladesh, Pakistan and India need UCC. There should be equal laws for everyone."

Voicing concern over Bangladesh's political situation, Nasrin alleged that religious funda-



Bangladeshi author Taslima Nasrin in Kolkata, Sunday. PARTHA PAUL

mentalist forces were gaining ground in the country.

"Now we have Jamaat-e-Islami as an Opposition party. It is against women's equality, and they want Sharia rule. If that happens, no minority will survive. Bangladesh is moving towards darkness. No one is trying to civilise the country. The government is only trying to remain in power," she said.

Advocating for freedom of speech, Nasrin said, "Religion should be separate from the State. Religion and State have no relation."

Drawing a parallel between the recent demonstrations by the Cockroach Janta Party

(CJP) in Delhi to the July 2024 student uprisings that ousted former Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, Nasrin cautioned that public sentiment is easily manipulated.

"I felt what is happening in India is similar to what happened in Bangladesh during the July 2024 student movement. The student movement in Bangladesh fooled us. Because we thought the students wanted to abolish the quota system. Sheikh Hasina had also agreed to their demands, but ultimately the government fell. Later, we found that jihadist (Islamic fundamentalists) were behind that move-

ment," Nasrin said.

The author also strongly opposed the ban imposed on the Awami League, characterising it as an "anti-democratic" measure.

"No political party should be banned. The way Sheikh Hasina was forced to leave the country is questionable. It was not right to ban the Awami League. It was a move against democracy. I want the ban to be lifted as soon as possible. Many Awami League workers were tortured and murdered. Sheikh Hasina wants to go back, but I don't know whether that would be possible. But no one wants me to go back," she said.

Nasrin also called for replacing religious schools with secular institutions, alleging that parts of the system foster radicalisation and abuse.

"I feel madrasas shouldn't exist in Bangladesh. Because we see, though not always, jihadis are being produced in madrasas. Child abuse goes on there, rapes are happening, imams and madrasa teachers are sent to jail. But just punishment won't help. The education system needs a transformation. I don't think there is a need for madrasas. No one does anything after passing out of madrasas. They beg and survive on charity. Madrasas should be abolished and secular schools should come up in-

stead," she said.

Nasrin also addressed an incident from Saturday evening at Kolkata's Rabindra Sadan, where a felicitation ceremony for her was temporarily disrupted.

The controversy erupted when she invited poet Joy Goswami onto the stage and requested him to address the gathering. However, loud objections from a section of the audience forced the poet to step down without speaking.

"Of course I felt bad. It wasn't just an insult to Joy, I was insulted as well. It was I who called Joy. In my speech, I spoke about freedom of speech. We may have differing opinions, but everyone should be allowed to speak," she said.

"Were those who prevented Joy from taking the stage among the people who liked my speech? That would be double-standard. You support someone when they speak in favour of freedom of expression, but when that same person calls a poet to express his views, you don't want to hear him, she said.

"Kolkata is a city of progressives. People believe in freedom of speech and the right to express one's views. Political ideologies may differ, but everyone must be given the space to express one's opinions," Nasrin added.

• BRIEFLY



A search operation underway for a man who was swept away in the Kanjirappuzha river in Kannur, Kerala, on Sunday. PTI

Eight dead, eight missing, 13 injured in Kerala rain, says Satheesan

KERALA CHIEF Minister V D Satheesan on Sunday said eight people had died, eight remained missing, and 13 were injured after heavy rain triggered landslides, flooding and widespread damage across the state on Saturday. In a statement issued by his office, Satheesan said 27 houses had been destroyed, 196 partially damaged, and 5,792 people shifted to 209 relief camps across the state. He said the government would ensure assistance to the families of those who died and to people who had lost their homes and livelihoods. The IMD issued an 'orange alert' for 12 districts of Kerala and a 'yellow alert' for Thiruvananthapuram and Kollam districts. The IMD forecast heavy rainfall in the state on August 3 and 6, accompanied by strong winds with speeds of 40-50 kmph. PTI

TN: 5 killed after speeding car hits water tanker

FIVE PEOPLE were killed on the spot after their speeding car rammed into a stationary water tanker lorry on the Udumalaipettai — Pollachi NH near Coimbatore on Sunday, police said. They said the lorry was halted along the median on the highway to water roadside plants. Due to the impact of the high-speed collision, the car was completely crushed, resulting in the immediate death of the occupants. Four of the deceased have been identified as a couple and their daughters. The identity of the fifth victim is yet to be ascertained. Police have initiated an investigation. PTI

3 children drown in pond in UP's Maharajganj

THREE CHILDREN drowned in a pond in UP's Maharajganj on Sunday, while a fourth managed to swim to safety and alert villagers, police said. According to police, four friends—Rajbir Yadav, 13, Nitish Yadav, 12, Rohan, 13, and Krishna Rauniyar, 15, —had gone to the pond when three of them slipped into deep water and began drowning. Rajbir swam out and informed local residents. Police and local divers launched a rescue operation. After nearly 30 minutes, the three boys were pulled out and taken to the Community Health Centre, where doctors declared them dead. PTI

EXPRESS special

Translocate, keep in enclosures: Chhattisgarh bid to save its wild buffaloes from extinction

With only a handful of wild buffaloes left in Central India, Chhattisgarh is turning to Assam to save its state animal

Jayprakash S Naidu
Raipur, August 2

TRANSLLOCATION FROM Assam. That's what the Chhattisgarh Forest Department hopes will save the state wild buffalo — its state animal and the last surviving population in Central India.

With the wild buffalo population plummeting over the last few decades, the Chhattisgarh Forest Department is planning to translocate wild buffaloes from Assam and keep them in enclosures at the Pamed Wildlife Sanctuary, the Udanti Sitanadi Tiger Reserve (USTR) and the Indravati Tiger Reserve (ITR). Officials hope this will help boost their population naturally.

A proposal will soon be sent to the Centre, Chhattisgarh Principal Chief Conservator of Forests (PCCF) Arun Kumar Pandey said.

The Asiatic wild buffalo is the largest wild bovine in the world, weighing twice as much as its less muscular cousin. India is home to more than 90% of the global wild water buffalo population (3,500-3,700 individuals), with most found in Assam (3,000-3,500) and smaller populations in Meghalaya, Chhattisgarh and Maharashtra's Kolamarka forests.

The 2016 IUCN Red List for threatened species — a critical indicator of the health of the world's biodiversity — places it in the "endangered" category.

Once found in Chhattis-

E. EXPLAINED

Endangered

The 2016 IUCN Red List for threatened species has placed wild buffaloes in "endangered" category. Once found in Chhattisgarh, Maharashtra, MP, Odisha, Jharkhand and Telangana in central India, it is today confined to small herds in Chhattisgarh and Maharashtra. In India, the wild buffalo enjoys the highest protection under Schedule I of the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972.

garh, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Odisha, Jharkhand and Telangana in central India, it is today confined to small herds in Chhattisgarh and Maharashtra. In India, the wild buffalo enjoys the highest protection under Schedule I of the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972.

A 2005 Wildlife Trust of India (WTI) report showed there were 39-47 wild buffaloes across USTR, Indravati Tiger Reserve (ITR) and Pamed in Bijapur district, with officials estimating their numbers have declined to 12-16. For its part, the forest department has taken several measures to push up the population. In 2015, the Forest Department pinned its hopes on a cloned female wild buffalo, Deepasha. The effort has since

• ANIMAL ENJOYS HIGHEST PROTECTION

INDIA IS home to more than 90% of the global wild water buffalo population (3,500-3,700 individuals), with most found in Assam (3,000-3,500).

A 2005 Wildlife Trust of India report showed there were 39-47 wild buffaloes across Udanti Sitanadi Tiger Reserve, Indravati Tiger Reserve & Pamed in Bijapur district. Officials estimate their numbers have declined to 12-16.

POACHING, SHRINKING habitat, and retaliatory killings by villagers Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

been abandoned.

Officials said the latest plan involves bringing wild buffaloes from Assam and keeping them in enclosures at Pamed Wildlife Sanctuary, USTR and Indravati. This experiment has already been attempted successfully. "Over the past few years, six wild buffaloes were brought from Assam to Barnawapara Wildlife Sanctuary: a male and a female in 2020, and four females in 2023, taking the population to 11. A dedicated team of doctors and staff is required to monitor their diet and ensure minimum human interference," said Baloda Bazar DFO Ganveer Dhammashil.

In USTR, where there's already one male buffalo, Deputy Director Varun Jain said there are plans to translocate three females. But with the lone male getting older, officials admit this is a race against time.

"The animals will be radio-collared to track their movement, and 17 villages in the core area of USTR have agreed to



after wild buffaloes raid crops and mating with domestic buffaloes are the leading causes of death.

IN INDIA, the wild buffalo has the highest protection under Schedule I of Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972.

their release," one official said. "If the effort fails, we will turn to artificial insemination."

A forest official said poaching, shrinking habitat, and retaliatory killings by villagers after wild buffaloes raid crops and mating with domestic buffaloes are the leading causes of death.

Officials are also mooting a five-point action plan to adopt an integrated approach covering ITR, Pamed and Bhairamgarh Wildlife Sanctuary. The plan calls for urgent conservation through scientific monitoring, habitat improvement and restoration, grassland and waterhole development, stronger anti-poaching measures, disease surveillance, genetic management and, if needed, translocation.

"With technical expertise from Wildlife Institute of India, Dehradun, and subject experts, we have developed the action plan, which was recently approved by Ministry of Environment, Forest & Climate Change," said ITR Deputy Director Sundeep Balaga.



Resham Fatma was conferred the Bharat Award by then President Pranab Mukherjee in 2015. EXPRESS

Over the next few years, life oscillated between classes and the hospital. Surgeries and doctor visits mounted, social visits fell dramatically, and Resham

spent most of her time studying from home. "Still, I completed Class 12 with 87% marks in the science stream," she says.

Other milestones followed:

a BSc Physics (Honours) at Delhi's Jamia Millia Islamia in 2018, and the Bharat Award — the highest national bravery award for children — at the Republic Day celebrations in 2015.

Wedged between these milestones were the grimmer realities of everyday life: the stares, the uncomfortable questions, and, worst of all, pity. "I didn't want their pity," she says. "I wanted them to see me as someone capable."

Although she initially planned to take up the civil services, Resham switched to a master's degree in Politics and International Relations from Jawaharal Nehru University (JNU). In 2023, while still studying at JNU, she launched the Ebrah Foundation, an initiative

that mentors young Muslim women on education, careers and financial independence.

In 2024, she married her now-husband, Asghar, who encouraged her to apply for the Chevening Scholarship.

"Even after moving to London, work on the Ebrah Foundation will continue, with plans now afoot to introduce spoken English classes for girls back home," she says. "Muslim women often stand at 'the margins of the margins' -- facing discrimination as women as well as members of a minority community. If girls become financially independent, they become more confident in making their own decisions."

But while life moves on, memories of the trauma re-

main etched in the mind — and in her scars. In 2015, Resham heard that her uncle, Riyaz — the man allegedly responsible for the acid attack — died by suicide in jail awaiting trial. The death came months after she received the bravery award.

When she first heard the news, Resham's reaction surprised even herself. "I didn't want him to die," she says. "I wanted him to stay alive and see me succeed. I wanted him to see that he couldn't destroy my life."

Over the years, she has chosen to move on. But it's not easily forgotten. "This is not a kind of trauma you leave behind," she says. "You carry it every single day. The only way is to accept it and move forward."

Acid attack survivor at 17, Chevening scholar at 29: LSE calling for Reshma Fatma

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, August 2

RESHAM FATMA'S name means 'silk thread', and like it, she is remarkably resilient. In her 29 years, Resham has seen much: stalking and harassment from those closest to her, an acid attack at 17 that left her scarred for life, and public apathy that threatened to reduce her to the worst day of her life.

Today, this 29-year-old from Ranchi has become India's first acid attack survivor to receive the UK government's prestigious Chevening Scholarship, and will pursue an MSc in Gender, Development and Globalisation at the London School of Economics (LSE).

Born in Jamshedpur in 1997,

Resham was in Class 11 and living with her grandparents in Lucknow when her mother's cousin, Riyaz, a man two decades her senior, asked to marry her. He was allegedly rebuffed, but the consequences were grave.

In February 2014, Riyaz allegedly offered to drop her home from coaching classes.

"He told me he would drop me home after my coaching class. I trusted him because he was family. Instead, he drove towards the highway and poured an entire bottle of acid over my head. At first, I thought it was petrol, but it began to burn," she says.

Soon, he allegedly pulled a knife and held it to my throat. "I remember thinking, 'So this

is what death feels like'," she says. She gathered strength, allegedly pushed him away and began to run.

"The burning was unbearable. An autorickshaw driver stopped. I begged him to help me, saying my family would pay him anything. I had to remove my jeans inside the auto because it felt like my skin was on fire... the driver covered my legs with a cloth kept in the auto," she says.

At the nearest police station, crowds gathered, but nobody was willing to take her to the hospital, she says. "Not a single person came forward," she says. "Then, an elderly man took me to the hospital and let me rest my head on his shoulder."

Both Delhi and Islamabad must recognise that Kashmir is, above all, a human issue. It cannot be resolved through force, intimidation or guns. Governments must speak to their own people, listen to their aspirations and negotiate with empathy rather than coercion. Only through dialogue, dignity and reconciliation can a just and lasting peace be achieved for the people on both sides of Kashmir.

First, why did Kashmir, often described as paradise on earth, reject the two-nation theory and choose secular India over Pakistan? In 1947, our people fought the tribal invaders with sticks and even bare hands. Kashmiris wholeheartedly embraced Gandhi's vision of India while rejecting Muhammad Ali Jinnah's Pakistan. Besides Maharaja Hari Singh and Sheikh Mohammad Abdullah, Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru's deep emotional bond with Kashmir played a defining role. His promise that Kashmir would become a "show window" for the world resonated deeply with Kashmiris. He

Mufti *sahab* firmly believed that opening travel and trade across the LoC would resolve at least half of the Kashmir issue. Once people met each other, travelled freely and saw realities with their own eyes, much of the mistrust would disappear. It would

Kashmiris across the LoC increasingly feel disempowered because their representative institutions are being undermined through nominated members imposed by the Government of Pakistan

Next conservation challenge lies beyond protected areas

Pathways for upward mobility appear to be shrinking. The Indian IT sector — which has traditionally provided millions an opportunity to move up the ladder — is now facing the AI threat. And unlike in the development trajectory of China and other East Asian economies, manufacturing is not generating employment on the scale needed to absorb the millions entering the labour force. In recent years, some of the fastest-growing job avenues have been in low-productivity segments such as delivery riders and security guards. For instance, the total number of riders on the Zomato and Blinkit platforms has risen to 10 lakh. In the case of Zepto, they have gone up to 2.21 lakh in 2026, from 49,278 in 2024. The recent protests over exam leaks, agitations against the Railway recruitment process in the past, and the sheer numbers of those applying for government jobs every year reflect the underlying anxieties of millions over access to quality education and jobs. This comes at a time when India is in a unique demographic window. The government needs to facilitate the creation of more education and employment opportunities urgently.

The Saudi agreement contains no such renunciation. It leaves open, pending a two-year study, a black box enrichment facility on Saudi soil, run by American firms but built inside a kingdom whose crown prince has said he will pursue a weapon the moment Iran gets there first. In place of the Additional Protocol, the deal relies on a bilateral inspection framework devised by the two governments themselves, already a retreat from the standard Washington spent half a century asking the world to accept. Congress has 90 working days to review it and would need a veto-proof majority to block it, complicated by President Donald Trump's announcement, the morning after the signing, that the deal now hinges on Saudi accession to the Abraham Accords, a condition Riyadh has resisted.

The timing of this deal is not incidental. Since February, the US and Israel have waged a war against Iran that was supposed to leave the Arab monarchies of the Persian Gulf more secure than they had been in decades. Instead, the war exposed how little control these monarchies have over their own fate. The lesson has been unambiguous: American and Israeli calculations can diverge from their interests at any moment, and when they do, it is their security that bears the cost. Seen in that light, the nuclear deal looks less like strategy and more like compensation, an attempt to restore through reactors and enrichment options the confidence that the war itself has destroyed.

options the confidence that the war with Iran has destroyed

The deal also represents an unnecessary retreat from a nonproliferation order the US helped build and, for all its inconsistencies, took pride in upholding for decades. That order rested on the proposition that a great power bears particular responsibility not to seed the world with the means of building

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a bomb, however lucrative the contracts. An agreement that preserves the enrichment option, in a state whose leadership has openly conditioned its ambitions on Iran's, cannot be reconciled with that inheritance. What is being dismantled is not merely technical safeguards but the credibility of a framework whose authority depended on Washington applying its own rules to its own friends.

In Iran, a regime that has spent two decades absorbing sanctions, sabotage, and war for a programme it insisted was purely civilian has just watched Washington hand its rival an enrichment pathway as reward for a signature. Whatever argument remained in Tehran for staying short of a weapon has been weakened by a deal that treats Saudi proliferation as a matter for cooperation rather than refusal. A Gulf and a Persian plateau both edging toward weapons capability carries its own consequence for Israel, whose military advantage has rested for half a century on precisely the nuclear monopoly this deal begins to erode. An Israel that senses that advantage narrowing has every incentive to reach for the preventive strike, much as it did in February, raising the possibility that the war meant to settle Iran's nuclear question becomes the opening skirmish in a longer campaign it can no longer confine to one country.

There is, finally, the question Washington has declined to ask Riyadh with anything like the rigour it applied to Tehran. The claim that this programme answers genuine electricity shortfall sits uneasily with the fact that the country making it holds among the largest petroleum reserves on Earth and some of the finest solar resources anywhere — resources that could meet Saudi power needs for a generation without a gram of enrichment. These are the questions Washington put to Iran for 20 years. Applied to Riyadh, that scepticism collapses just as readily, yet nobody in this administration seems inclined to voice it. A nonproliferation policy that interrogates one capital's motives while waving another's through on a signing ceremony is a test of loyalty rather than of intent.

The writer is associate professor of International Studies at the Hamilton Lugar School of Global and International Studies, Indiana University

V B MATHUR

OVER THE past five decades, India has built one of the developing world's most representative protected-area (PA) networks. This achievement has provided a robust scientific foundation for conserving many of the country's most important species, habitats and ecological processes. However, the ecological realities of the 21st century demand changes in conservation paradigms. Wildlife moves across landscapes rather than administrative boundaries. Rivers connect forests, wetlands and farmlands. Climate change is altering habitats, while rapid infrastructure expansion is fragmenting them. Conserving biodiversity can therefore no longer rely solely on protecting isolated sites—it must also secure the landscapes that connect them.

The challenge is to complement national parks and wildlife sanctuaries by a more connected and inclusive conservation vision. The emergence of Other Effective Area-based Conservation Measures (OECMs) under the Convention on Biological Diversity offers such an opportunity. Rather than treating OECMs as another international reporting requirement, India should recognise them as a framework for acknowledging the many forests, wetlands, community-managed landscapes and other biodiversity-rich areas that already make substantial contributions to conservation beyond the formal PA network. The more important question, therefore, is not where the next PA should be notified. It is this: How do we recognise, connect and strengthen all the landscapes that collectively sustain India's biodiversity?

The answer lies in reimagining the conservation landscape through a National Conservation Estate—an ecological network comprising PAs, OECMs and other biodiversity-rich landscapes that together safeguard the country's natural heritage, irrespective of ownership, legal designation or primary management objective. PAs and OECMs cannot function as isolated ecological islands if they are to sustain wildlife movement, genetic exchange and resilient ecosystems. Ecological corridors and connected landscapes are therefore not peripheral additions; they are the very foundation of a modern conservation strategy.

This imperative has become even more urgent as India undertakes one of the world's largest infrastructure expansion programmes. The wildlife overpasses and underpasses incorporated in the Delhi-Dehradun Economic Corridor, together with mitigation measures in the Pench-Seoni landscape, demonstrate that economic development and ecological connectivity need not be mutually exclusive. Roads, railways, transmission lines and canals can support development without severing ecological networks, provided connectivity is embedded in planning. This vision demands a wider partnership. Government must continue to provide leadership, but communities, corporations and civil society must become equal partners.

The next conservation revolution will be measured by our ability to recognise, connect and steward every landscape that sustains biodiversity. India's conservation future will be secured by weaving stronger ecological and institutional connections across landscapes and society.

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The writer is former chairperson, National Biodiversity Authority of India

Union Home Minister, Buta Singh. Nehru will now have 19 of the 52 portfolios held earlier by him.

OVER 100 MLAs and at least five MPs from Gujarat are allegedly involved in a land scandal in this state capital township. But for a chance scrutiny of land deals of about half a dozen politicians conducted by the district revenue officials, the scandal would have remained buried, for members of both the ruling party and the Opposition are involved in it. The district collectorate is now initiating actions to confiscate the prime land given to the legislators at throwaway prices in the heart of the township.

the British Government's failure to impose economic sanctions against racist South Africa and called upon the UK to help end apartheid. In an interview with the BBC on the eve of the mini-Commonwealth Summit, Gandhi said Britain had faced two world wars and made tremendous sacrifices for human dignity, pride and freedom. "Today we find that Britain was willing to give human rights and freedom a second place to material gains," he said.

Arun Nehru gets portfolios back

TWELVE PORTFOLIOS which had been taken away from the Union Minister of State for Internal Security, Arun Nehru, due to his ill health, were restored to him by the

to his in heart, were restored to him by the

heart of the township.

BY EP UNNY



Border security belt

THE CENTRE intends to go ahead with its plan to move a resolution in the Dáil on 6 July.

in Article 249 to create a security belt along the Indo-Pak border. This is in spite of concerted opposition from both factions of the Akali Dal. The draft of the resolution has already been approved by the Cabinet, but it will be moved in the Rajya Sabha only after the Prime Minister returns from his foreign tour on August 11. The Akali government in Punjab as well as the breakaway faction of the party are opposed to the plan.

PM slams UK over South Africa

THE PRIME MINISTER, Rajiv Gandhi, deplored



A new compact between AI & agriculture: An Andhra Pradesh opportunity



FROM PLATE TO PLOUGH

BY ASHOK GULATI, S BASKAR REDDY AND KALYAN CHAKRAVARTHY GUNTUBOYINA

ANDHRA PRADESH Chief Minister Chandrababu Naidu has proved to be a visionary and investment-friendly politician. He has secured one of India's largest technology investments in recent years. Google has committed \$15 billion to a one-gigawatt AI data centre in Visakhapatnam, expected to be the largest such centre in Asia when it becomes operational in 2028. Such a large data centre will require 24 GWh of power each day. Meeting this demand by diverting power from other consumers, particularly agriculture, could provoke social tensions, while expanding thermal generation would come at an unacceptable environmental cost. Andhra Pradesh will have to look for alternatives like nuclear energy or renewables like solar power. Herein lies an opportunity for agri-households to become participants in the emerging AI economy by generating clean electricity while continuing to cultivate their land. Agrivoltaics enables this dual use of farmland, allowing farmers to produce both food and power while multiplying their incomes.

Andhra Pradesh has already introduced a policy innovation that grants data centres a Deemed Distribution Licence (DDL), which allows hyperscale operators to procure and manage their own power rather than draw it as ordinary consumers. However, this innovation needs to be followed up by a series of complementary measures to avoid power cuts for other sectors.

We propose that Google devote a modest portion of its investment to developing captive solar generation on farmers' fields. Farmers would continue cultivating their land while also holding equity in the solar enterprise, becoming co-owners of the clean energy that powers the data centre. This agri-photovoltaic model is a tested one and can improve incomes many times. This way, Google will build enormous goodwill with farmers, and the Government of Andhra Pradesh, too, can reap political dividends.

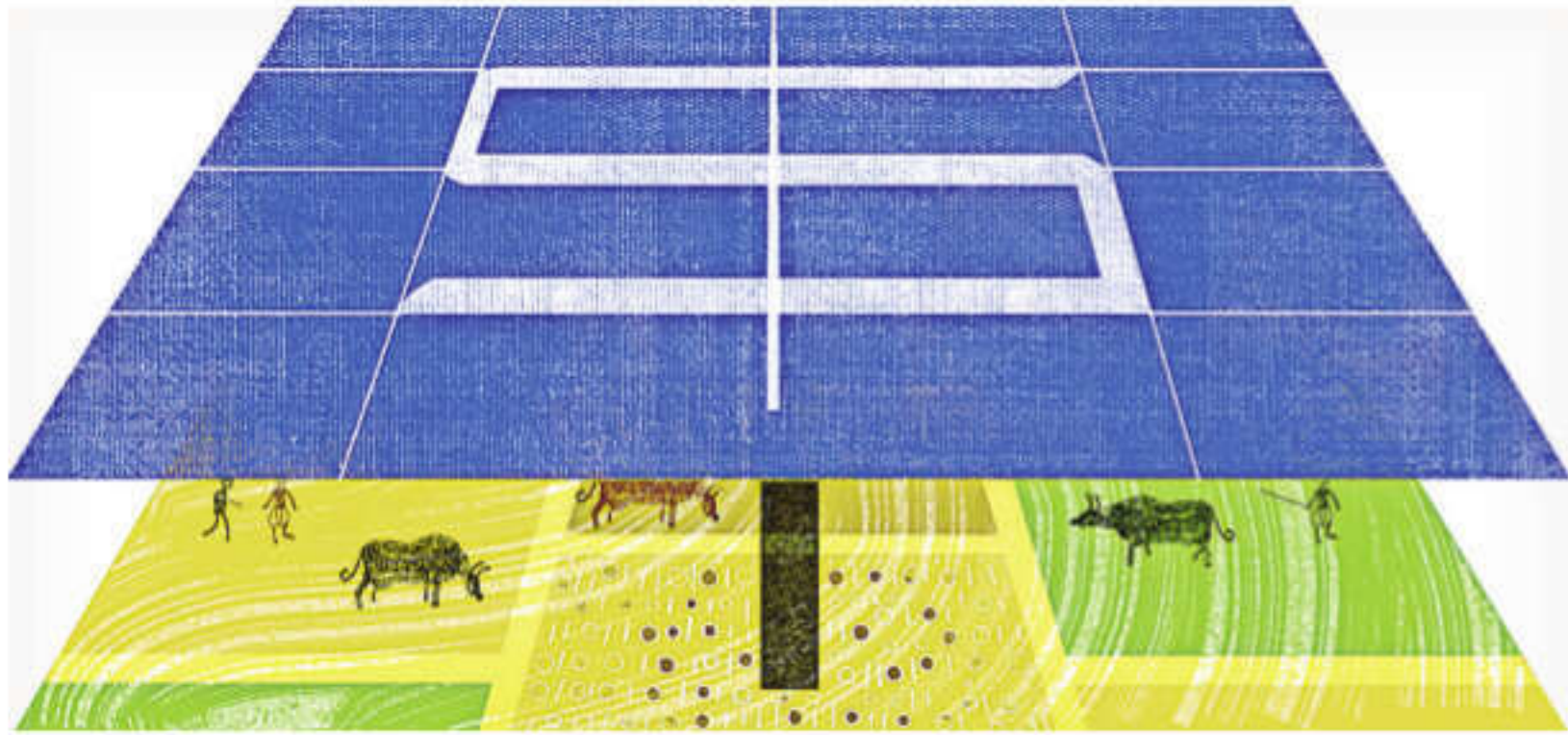


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

ICRIER has already established agri-photovoltaic pilot projects in Rajasthan, Odisha and Madhya Pradesh. This needs to be scaled up, and Naidu can take the lead here. But it would require an ecosystem to be created by organising farmers into a community-owned solar utility cluster (solar co-operatives on the lines of milk cooperatives) and creating a special-purpose vehicle (SPV) company in which farmers also hold some equity (borrowed from banks) but contribute mainly through utilisation of their land, while holding its title. In the agri-photovoltaics system, solar panels are mounted at about 10 to 12 feet to enable seamless cultivation of high-value crops beneath them. A blended stack of investment from Google and public finance will help in developing the requisite infrastructure. Google could provide zero- (or very low) interest long-term debt that could be adjusted against energy supplied by the SPV. The PM-KUSUM programme can

be tweaked to provide some capital subsidy. Commercial capital could also be leveraged through a credit guarantee from the Credit Guarantee Trust Fund for Small and Medium Enterprises. In such agri-photovoltaic systems, solar energy is virtually the third crop and augments farmers' incomes (eight to 10 times in ICRIER pilots). Beyond producing renewable energy, agrivoltaics would enable farmers to grow two irrigated crops beneath the panels, diversify into higher-value shade-loving crops, undertake value addition through processing, and earn recurring revenue from electricity sales to the Google data centre.

Under the new DDL licence, Google can contract that green generation through open-access and banking arrangements and stand behind it as a long-term off-taker. The farmers' solar utility gains a creditworthy, permanent customer. In one stroke, the data centre's load becomes the demand that finances rural electrification, not the demand that starves it.

This model can create an extraordinary win-win-win situation for farmers, Google and the government. Their land works twice over for farmers — it produces a high-value crop, and earns a dividend from the power company it part-owns. For Google, the difference is between merely buying electricity

We propose that Google devote a modest portion of its investment to developing captive solar generation on farmers' fields. Farmers would continue cultivating their land while also holding equity in the solar enterprise

in a competitive market and earning the lasting trust of farmers by helping them become producers of that electricity. A gigawatt or even a few hundred megawatts of it sourced from farmer-owned agri-photovoltaic systems is a legacy story the company can tell for decades to come. In a country where large projects live or die on social licence, that goodwill is not a soft sentiment. It is the cheapest insurance Google can ever buy. For the state government, the model could preempt a conflict that might otherwise have become the defining controversy surrounding its marquee investment. Instead of being forced to choose between the cloud and the cultivator, it can point to an arrangement in which the former pays for the latter.

It is now for Sundar Pichai and Naidu to work with farmer-producer companies, co-operatives and rural entrepreneurs to set up at least 5,000 agri-photovoltaic systems of 1 MW each across the state. Assuming each 1 MW agrivoltaics system costs about Rs 4 crore, we estimate an investment of Rs 2,00,000 crore (about \$2.2 billion) to ensure a self-sustaining captive energy requirement for Google. As mentioned earlier, innovative blended financing instruments and guaranteed buyback can ensure that funding does not become a stumbling block. More importantly, there will be minimal burden on the state or national budget as it would be a market-based mechanism.

The choice that Andhra Pradesh faces is not between development and farmers. It is between two kinds of development models. In one, land is acquired, power is drawn, and what is left behind is a one-time rent and long-lasting grievance. The other model treats farmers as co-owners, the agri-photovoltaics system as an asset, and the data centre as a customer. Being a proponent of the very licence (DDL) that makes it possible, Andhra Pradesh is uniquely placed to show the rest of the country how the cloud can shower prosperity on agri-households.

Gulati is distinguished professor at ICRIER, Reddy is executive director of Global Agri-Entrepreneurship Academy, and Guntuboyina is regional manager for International Cooperation (Asia) at Wageningen University, Netherlands. Views are personal

Privatisation and petroleum: Let's resurrect an old question



OVER THE BARREL

BY VIKRAM S MEHTA

SHOULD THE government privatise the petroleum exploration and production (EP) public enterprises, Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC) and Oil India Limited (OIL)? This question had been deemed too sensitive for serious discussion. I resurrect it not to make the case for privatisation but because the altered landscape of the international petroleum market warrants a discussion.

Last month, I started this column with the words, "the fog of war has lifted somewhat" (From the Iran conflict, four geopolitical shifts India cannot afford to miss; *IE*, July 6) and sketched the four systemic shifts the conflict in the Middle East has wrought on the petroleum market — faltering trust in the US security umbrella; the lever of maritime choke points to alter the balance of power; the emergence of a faction in Iran driven more by the goal of building back the Iranian economy than defending the principles of the 1979 revolution; and OPEC's weakening influence.

Since then, the fog of war has descended again. It is difficult to see where all this is headed. Several scenarios can be sketched. Diplomacy wins; President Donald Trump eats "a banquet of crow", to quote American commentator Thomas L Friedman; Iran conciliates; the Strait of Hormuz is re-opened, and the region returns to the new normal of "no war - no peace". Or madness continues. The US President makes real his threat to bomb Iran to rubble. Another possibility could be the Middle East conflict converging with the war in Ukraine. Iran has already warned Ukraine not to interfere with its ships crossing the Black Sea. China could use the turmoil to ratchet up temperatures around the South China Sea. Whatever the scenario, one thing is clear. The contours of the international petroleum market have been redrawn. It will not return to the status quo ante of February 28.

A wedge has been driven into the de jure principle of freedom of navigation. The Strait may reopen, and a compromise on levies may be agreed. But the shadow of kinetic impedance will not disappear, and will keep ship owners and crews on edge. The Houthis first attacked shipping in the Bab el-Mandeb on October 7, 2023. Two-and-a-half years on, commercial traffic through this strait is only 50 per cent of what it was before this attack.

A potentially positive flip is the evidence that the crude oil market is structurally oversupplied. Two factors support this evidence. One, even at the height of the conflict, crude prices did not stay elevated above \$100/bbl. Experts had projected prices would range between \$125 and \$150/bbl. Second, at every hint of a diplomatic breakthrough, prices have fallen as sharply as they rose. The current pause in the bombing has brought prices down from just above \$100/bbl to below \$90/barrel.

It is against this redrawn landscape that the question posed above bears relevance. For whilst at one level, India faces greater risk of a supply disruption, at another it can draw comfort from a fundamentally glutted crude oil market.

To answer this question, two facts need to be taken into account. One, ONGC/OIL have not had great success in locating and developing new reserves. Domestic crude production has dropped almost 20 per cent over the past decade. Second, most of India's hydrocarbon resources lie in complex geology and offshore areas. They are difficult and expensive to locate. Analysts estimate the finding cost of hydrocarbons in ONGC's current focus areas of the offshore Godavari/Mahanadi/Andaman basins could be between \$60-80/barrel. If this estimate bears out, then in a "low for longer" price scenario where the futures market price for the marker Brent crude is around \$70, it may not be commercially viable to bring a discovery into production.

The *raison d'être* for establishing state-owned EP companies has never been only economic. ONGC was created because energy security was (is) a matter of strategic significance. Cost comparisons should not, therefore, be the sole benchmark. That said, the question arises whether in a structurally oversupplied market confronted by the increasing probability of physical disruption, energy security is best achieved by allocating scarce public resources towards capital-intensive, high-risk and high-cost exploration or whether it would be better to deploy it towards the development of a "just for sure" strategy built around the expansion of India's strategic petroleum reserves and green energy.

Currently, India has six to seven days of crude oil import cover in strategic reserves. (This is not to be confused with commercial inventory.) The government has authorised the expansion of these reserves, but the pace of progress is slow because of delays in land acquisition for storage caverns and costs. I can appreciate the latter. A robust strategic buffer of, say, 60 days of imports (China has 120 days cover and the IEA member countries 90 days) at \$70/bbl would cost about \$2.2 billion for just the oil. To that should be added the cost of land and ancillary logistics and distribution infrastructure. This is not an insignificant investment, especially as it generates no return. Privatisation could provide the funding. Hence, the question.

The writer is distinguished fellow and chairman, Centre for Social and Economic Progress

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Gaza roadmap

NEARLY THREE years after the October 7 terror attack, it is clear that lasting peace in the region cannot be achieved through military measures alone (A tough road to Hamas disarmament; *IE*, August 1). Any disarmament process must be supported by credible diplomacy, humanitarian relief, and international cooperation. Civilian lives should remain the foremost priority throughout the negotiations. Durable peace will require political dialogue, mutual security guarantees, and sustained efforts to rebuild trust among all stakeholders while respecting international law.

SM Jeeva, Chennai

Booker list

LITERARY AWARDS shape reading habits and introduce important voices to a wider audience (Booker's timid long-list for turbulent times; *IE*, August 1). Selection committees should recognise originality, diversity, and artistic merit while remaining open to fresh perspectives from different cultures and languages. Healthy debate over such choices is welcome, as it encourages readers to engage critically with literature. Strong literary traditions grow through openness rather than through predictable preferences.

Prajesh Paramasivan, Neelambur

Agricultural policy

ENSURING STABLE incomes for farmers is more important than subsidies and minimum support prices (Farmers need income, not price support; *IE*, August 1). Small and marginal farmers need better irrigation, affordable credit, crop insurance, and easier market access. Investments in storage, food processing, and rural infrastructure can reduce post-harvest losses and improve earnings. Agricultural policy should encourage productivity and diversification while protecting farmers from sudden market shocks through balanced and sustainable reforms.

K Sakunthala, Coimbatore



DIPA SINHA AND RAJENDRAN NARAYANAN

THE LAST few years have seen debates on the nature of welfare interventions and their modes of delivery. The case for expanding unconditional cash transfers for women emerges before every state election. Much of the discourse revolves around resource allocation, state capacity and economic efficiency. Less attention is paid to the role of effective welfare measures that could improve the socio-economic conditions of the poor while contributing to growth. The discussion on welfare is often limited to its fiscal impact and framed as a "drain on resources", often blurring the lines between welfare as a right and welfare as "freebies". Replacing MGNREGA with the VB-G RAM G Act and an attempt to stop giving eggs in mid-day meals need to be seen in this context.

After much deliberation, socio-economic rights were codified in the Directive Principles of State Policy (DPSP) of the Constitution. The DPSP were meant to be guidelines for elected governments to realise a rights-based welfare regime. However, governments in the initial years after Independence were preoccupied with establishing basic structures of governance with an emphasis on achieving economic growth through industrialisation. Over the years, there was an expansion of direct delivery of welfare and social-sector spending. The decade of the 2000s saw an emphasis on converting many of the entitlements into legally enforceable rights.

Digitisation must be undertaken through consultation and accompanied by legal safeguards. Wider public consultation on how to arrive at estimates of savings due to technologies in welfare delivery is needed

My students proved me wrong. Completely

tell a story all shape the way young people understand the world. I have often found myself wondering what kind of adults these students will grow into when some histories are foregrounded, others pushed to the margins, and some made less visible or erased.

I studied at JNU, where I was involved in protests. I wondered whether my students would relate to that world. Would they care enough to step outside the classroom? Would they see the connection between the histories we study and the society they live in?

Then my students surprised me. They began talking about the protests. The day, they met me with happiness at the news of Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation, something shifted. It moved me to see them care. They did not participate in the ways I imagined young people participating. They sustained themselves through laughter,

made reels, had fun. They showed solidarity. They documented their experiences and, through those fragments, gave us a glimpse into the stories emerging from the protests.

When I began to think this was an increasingly individualistic generation, they proved me wrong. Completely. They reminded me that being connected through technology does not mean being disconnected from people.

I studied at JNU, where I was involved in protests. I wondered whether my students would relate to that world. Would they care enough to step outside the classroom?

versal, free public services does not absolve the state of accountability for the quality of those services or for the exclusions that persist within them. Ensuring that services build community solidarity and are delivered with dignity requires mechanisms for participation, public scrutiny, transparency, accountability and time-bound grievance redressal. Public audits and decentralised grievance mechanisms have been tried in various forms and need to be deepened and expanded. Local governments need to be empowered, allowing flexibility as well as decentralised decision-making. Digitisation must be undertaken through consultation and accompanied by legal safeguards. Wider public consultation on how to arrive at estimates of savings due to technologies in welfare delivery is needed. Grounding welfare in a rights-based framework requires reimagining citizens as rights-holders rather than as "beneficiaries" receiving largesse.

While outputs and outcomes are important to monitor, we risk disempowering millions of people unless we create an ecosystem where the assertion of rights is possible. The repeal of MGNREGA and the attempt to discontinue eggs in mid-day meals are a step back. A well-nourished, healthy, educated society with decent employment is not only a constitutional imperative but an engine for expanding human capabilities and economic growth.

The writers are affiliated with the Centre for the Study of the Indian Economy, APU. Views are personal



DOLAN SAMANTA

I TEACH young adults — the much-discussed Gen Z — and there have been moments when I have looked at them and wondered where we are headed. This generation is growing up with AI, social media, and an extraordinary amount of information. Sometimes, I worry independent thinking is losing its touch, and that an individualistic world might make it harder for young people to feel connected to something larger than themselves. The textbooks my students read have also gone through politicisation. As a history educator, this has troubled me deeply. History is an act of selection: What we preserve, what we leave out, and how we

NIFTY 50 COMPANIES REPORTED 11.2% AVERAGE YEAR-ON-YEAR NET PROFIT GROWTH IN Q1FY27

Q1 earnings beat Street estimates, upgrade outlook remains cautious

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, August 2

CORPORATE EARNINGS for the first quarter of the ongoing financial year (Q1FY27) have surpassed Street expectations, with most companies across the board delivering double-digit earnings growth on an average despite higher crude prices and supply chain disruptions caused by the war in West Asia.

Large-caps have logged double-digit earnings growth on an average so far, while mid-and small-cap companies are seeing even higher growth.

This is also in contrast to the sluggish broader market performance, as the benchmark Nifty 50 has declined by roughly 6.7% so far in 2026. While BSE Sensex has crashed over 8% year-to-date.

While the markets have picked up over the last month, with the Nifty 50 gaining over 2% in July, most market participants feel it's too early to upgrade earnings estimates based on better-than-expected earnings of a single quarter.

Surpassing Street expectations

Companies in the Nifty 50 index saw their net profits grow by 11.2% year-on-year on average in Q1FY27, 3.5% higher than expectations, according to a report by Kotak Institutional Equities. This is based on 25 of the Nifty 50 firms that have so far announced their results.

Profits across the approximately 250 companies covered by the firm grew by nearly 16%, the report showed. This excludes oil and gas companies, which depend on volatile conditions and can skew earnings.

"On the earnings side, when we look at the 32 companies that have come out with their results, both top-line and bottom-line growth have been better than the Street's expectations. The expectation was high single-digit kind of growth, and what has come out is 17% kind of top-line growth and 12% kind of bottom-line growth," according to Pankaj Pandey, head of research at ICICI Securities.

Earnings for the quarter were expected to be weighed down by the ongoing West Asia war. However, adequate inven-

• Most major sectors have beaten Street's expectations on net profit so far in Q1

Sector	YoY PAT growth	Actual vs estimated PAT growth
Banks	15%	10%
IT Services	11%	1%
Diversified financials	57%	2%
Healthcare	33%	18%
Pharma	-39%	-1%
Consumer staples	-12%	3%
Auto & ancillaries	36%	3%
Kotak universe*	15.7%	5.9%

*EX-OIL COMPANIES; SOURCE: KOTAK INSTITUTIONAL EQUITIES

tory levels and calibrated pricing measures by many shielded most companies during the quarter, according to experts.

Too early to upgrade

Most market participants expect earnings to grow in the low to mid teens in the coming quarters, compared to the single-digit growth seen over the past couple of quarters. However, they still believe it is too early for earnings upgrades. "It is too early. See, what we

are pencilling in is a 16% CAGR kind of a growth (in earnings) over the next 2 years. But at least we see that earnings are tracking ahead of our expectation, so we don't see any material risk to our expectations," said Pandey of ICICI Securities.

This is despite many global firms trimming their earnings expectations for a majority of Indian companies over 2025 and early due to factors like slowing earnings growth, elevated valuations, sluggish domestic con-

sumption, persistent foreign investor outflows, and risks posed by the West Asia war.

For example, Goldman Sachs had halved its earnings growth expectations for Nifty 50 companies to 8% for 2026. Other global players like HSBC, Jelferies, and Morgan Stanley had also undertaken similar cuts.

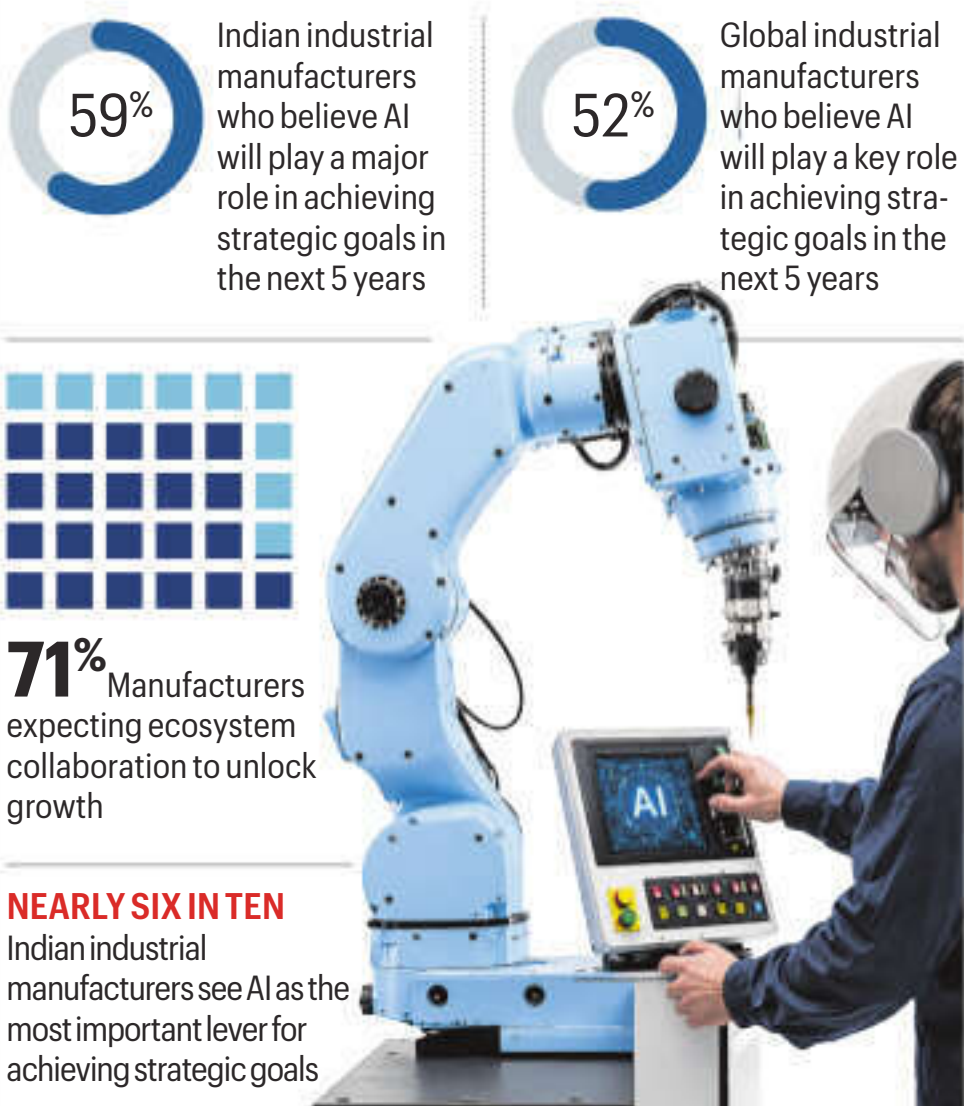
Earnings expectations are the basis of a market's valuation. A cut in earnings expectations means market participants value a market lower than they previously did. Thus, with Q1 earnings exceeding expectations, the argument is for experts to upgrade the earnings expectations for Indian markets.

"The earnings downgrades were mainly because the earnings growth projected by companies was very high previously. We need to wait and watch before upgrades. In the next few quarters, I don't expect earnings to grow very rapidly, but I think an 11-12% growth is decent considering the global scenario remains uncertain," said Pravin Bokade, research head at IDBI Capital.

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• MANUFACTURING ENTERS AI ERA

India's manufacturing competitiveness will depend on how seamlessly companies embed AI across strategies, operations and business models, said a report by PwC India.



RBI policy panel likely to keep interest rates unchanged on August 5

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, August 2

THE MONETARY Policy Committee (MPC) of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is widely expected to leave the key policy repo rate unchanged at its forthcoming meeting on August 5, amid the continuing conflict in West Asia and elevated global crude oil prices, experts said.

Although the resulting inflationary pressures and uncertainties have heightened risks, they remain manageable for now, with the domestic economy continuing to display resilience. However, inflation continues to face upside risks from elevated global oil prices, a weak monsoon and lower water reservoir levels. "We expect MPC members will remain watchful of the progress of the monsoon and its impact on food inflation. We expect RBI to remain on hold for now and also keep the stance unchanged," said Sonal Badhan, Economist, Bank of Baroda (BoB).

"Present growth-inflation dynamics is pointing towards risks to growth with a manageable inflation trajectory in the immediate future. This, coupled with elevated global uncertainties, may result in MPC not considering the "rate hike" option in a hurry during the forthcoming MPC meeting in August," said Mandar Pitale, Head, Financial Markets, SBM Bank (India).

According to a CareEdge report, the central bank is expected to keep rates unchanged in August, with any potential rate hikes later in FY27 contingent on a material rise in inflation or renewed geopolitical risks, although the base-case scenario remains for no further

• STATUS QUO

THE CENTRAL bank is expected to keep rates unchanged in August, with any potential rate hikes later in FY27 contingent on a material rise in inflation or renewed geopolitical risks, says a CareEdge report

BANK OF Baroda expects MPC members to remain watchful of monsoon progress and its impact on food inflation. It also expects the RBI to remain on hold and keep its policy stance unchanged

ON JUNE 5, MPC had kept the



interest rates unchanged at 5.25% despite mounting inflationary pressures from rising crude oil prices and supply-side pressures triggered by the West Asia conflict

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1 hikes this fiscal year.

On June 5, MPC had kept the interest rates unchanged at 5.25% despite mounting inflationary pressures from rising crude oil prices and supply-side pressures triggered by the West Asia conflict.

However, the RBI policy panel re-assessed both its growth and inflation projections, with risks emanating from elevated oil prices, uncertainty in global trade, adverse weather conditions and geopolitical tensions clouding the economic outlook.

It lowered the growth projection from 6.9% to 6.6% and hiked the inflation forecast from 4.6% to 5.1% in the June policy review.

Pitale said MPC is expected to deliver cautionary guidance with global oil prices and monsoon remaining key monitorable for future policy actions. Oil prices moving up in the \$90 to \$100 range per barrel for the foreseeable future due to sustained tension will once again bring forward a strong case for generalised increase in price pressures ultimately percolat-

ing to the demand side. This will create a strong skewness towards rate hikes in the second half of FY26-27.

"However, this is also the right opportunity for the central bank to signal the markets that RBI may hike rates in future, by taking a cautious tone. We expect at least one rate hike in H2FY27 depending on the inflation trajectory," Badhan said.

Retail inflation breached the RBI's target for the first time in 17 months in June, setting the stage for interest rate hikes in an economy at risk from a prolonged West Asia conflict. Retail inflation rose to 4.38% year-on-year in June crossing the central bank's 4% target.

Between June 17 (when the peace deal was signed) and now, oil prices have risen by 11% as of July 31, 2026. US 10-year treasury yield has risen by 16 basis points. "The rupee has depreciated by 0.8% in this period and is currently trading at 95.34. The impact on currency and equity markets can be explained by foreign fund outflows, which exacerbate during times of stress," BoB said.

• BRIEFLY

Chinese FDI down to just Rs 1 cr in FY26

New Delhi: India's strict regulatory firewall on investments from neighbouring nations has reduced Chinese Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) in the country to a trickle, with just a single proposal worth Rs 1 crore (\$0.11 million) receiving government approval in 2025-26. This signals how important the recent relaxations in FDI approval policy for countries sharing land borders with India are to boost FDI inflows into the country and capital formation. FE

SBI mops up \$7.5 bn under RBI swap window

Mumbai: State Bank of India (SBI) has garnered \$7.5 billion under the Reserve Bank of India's three concessional swap schemes, accounting for almost 20% of the total mop-up by banks until July 31. SBI has mobilised \$6 billion via FCNR(B) deposits

while \$1.5 billion has come in through foreign currency bonds, a source said. Some of the public sector banks, including Indian Bank, Canara Bank and Bank of Baroda, have hit the \$1-billion mark in FCNR(B) deposits during this period, according to sources. FE

India proposes relief for delayed green projects

New Delhi: Power regulator, the Central Electricity Regulatory Commission, has proposed waiving transmission charges for clean energy projects delayed due to the non-availability of transmission lines, according to draft regulations. Several clean energy projects have been stalled in India because of a lack of transmission infrastructure. The move would mark a policy roll-back. India had begun phasing out interstate transmission charge waivers for new solar, wind and hybrid projects from July 2025. The relief would be available for projects that signed at least seven-year-long power sale contracts by December 31, 2026. REUTERS

• WHILE BIG PLAYERS TURN TO PREMIUMISATION AND DIVERSIFICATION, UNORGANISED RETAILERS GAIN GROUND AMID CHEAP IMPORTS AND WEATHER DISRUPTIONS

Why India's tea majors are facing rising competition from cheaper alternatives

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, August 2

TEA, OR 'chai', may continue to be one of the most popular beverages for Indians, but the market is seeing a shift in where consumers buy it, as a surge in cheap imports and lower prices are prompting many to switch to lower sub-brands or purchase from the unorganised sector.

Suyash Patel, a 21-year-old college student based in Mumbai, recounts a similar experience. "I was used to drinking Wagh Bakri chai at home, consuming maybe around three to four cups a day. But now that I have shifted to college, I started buying Society tea for home because it costs me a bit less, but

also mostly have chai from outside," said Patel, who is originally from Gujarat.

This shift has made the past four to five quarters challenging for listed companies and larger players, pushing them to focus on premiumisation and diversify into other product categories to offset weak performance in the tea segment.

The tea business remained weak for listed players in the April-June quarter, with modest volume growth and lower revenues. Tata Consumer Products Ltd, which owns brands such as Tata Tea and Tetley, reported just 2% volume growth in its tea and coffee segment during the quarter,

while revenue declined 4%.

While the company does not disclose the individual contribution of tea and coffee within the segment, tea operations weighed heavily on the overall performance, even as coffee grew 24%. The company attributed the decline in segment revenue to passing on lower tea costs to consumers.

Hindustan Unilever Ltd (HUL), which has brands such as Lipton and Brooke Bond, reported a low single-digit underlying volume growth in its premium tea segment.

Goodricke, a Kolkata-based tea producer with plantations across Darjeeling and Assam,



An increase in cheaper tea imports from other markets such as Nepal and Kenya has led to prices falling in the Indian market. REUTERS

has not yet disclosed its Q1 earnings. However, the company's revenues dropped by nearly 14% in 2025-26 due to higher operating costs and the downturn in the overall tea market.

Tea market slowdown

The overall tea market has been in a deflationary phase over the past four to five quarters, driven by a combination of factors, including ad-

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> tea is grown. This lowered the yield of high-quality tea, reducing its cost in auction houses where major companies such as HUL and Tata Consumer source the leaf. An increase in cheaper tea imports from other markets such as Nepal and Kenya has also led to prices falling in the Indian market.

With tea essentially being a commodity business, where brand loyalty is relatively low compared to other businesses, falling prices have fuelled growth in the unorganised sector. This has forced larger companies to cut prices to remain competitive, resulting in lower realisations.

Tea retailers also faced a temporary setback from a shortage of

liquefied petroleum gas linked to the West Asia conflict. Fuel shortages in households led many consumers to avoid tea purchases, Tata Consumer's management said during its post-Q1 earnings conference call.

With the tea market becoming increasingly concentrated, and most Indians already consuming the beverage, these additional challenges have led larger players such as Tata Consumer and HUL to focus on premiumisation. This includes premium offerings such as Tetley Premium and Tata Tea Gold from Tata Consumer, and premium variants under HUL's Brooke Bond portfolio.

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• SCI-TECH

When machines do math: The promise & limits of AI



EXPERT EXPLAINS

RAJEEVA LAXMAN KARANDIKAR

PROFESSOR EMERITUS, CHENNAI MATHEMATICAL INSTITUTE

RECENTLY, MATHEMATICIAN Levent Alpöge announced on X that he had found a counterexample to the Jacobian conjecture — a problem posed by Ott-Heinrich Keller in 1939. He credited his collaborator on the discovery: Claude Fable 5, Anthropic’s latest AI model.

The Jacobian conjecture is probably too technical to explain in a newspaper column (an interested reader can readily find a precise statement on the internet). For Indians, it is worth knowing that Prof Shreeram Abhyankar, founder of the Bhaskaracharya Pratishthana in Pune, was interested in this question and popularised it in his lectures.

Mathematics has a long history of such bold claims eventually being overturned. There are a great many examples of very hardened problems, some centuries old, giving in to human tenacity.

A conjecture made in 1782 by Leonhard Euler, one of the all-time great mathematicians, stood unchallenged for nearly 180 years until R C Bose, S S Shrikhande and E T Parker disproved it, earning themselves the nickname “Euler’s Spoilers” in a prominent New York Times article. Fermat’s Last Theorem, proposed without proof in 1637, took 350 years to prove, finally falling in 1994-95. The Riemann Hypothesis, on the other hand, has resisted resolution for over 160 years and remains one of the seven Millennium Prize Problems — solve it and the Clay Institute owes you a million dollars.

Why do mathematicians keep making these bets? Because the search itself tends to pay off even when the original question doesn’t get solved. George Boole’s 19th-century proposal for a symbolic calculus — now called Boolean Algebra — went on to become the backbone of computer science. Making bold assertions and waiting decades, or centuries, to see themselves vindicated or de-

• THE CENTURY-OLD IDEA UNDERPINNING LARGE LANGUAGE MODELS

• A large language model (LLM), like ChatGPT or Claude, doesn’t ‘memorise’ the vast amounts of content it is trained on. Rather, it builds an intricate statistical map of language by observing how words and ideas co-occur across countless contexts.

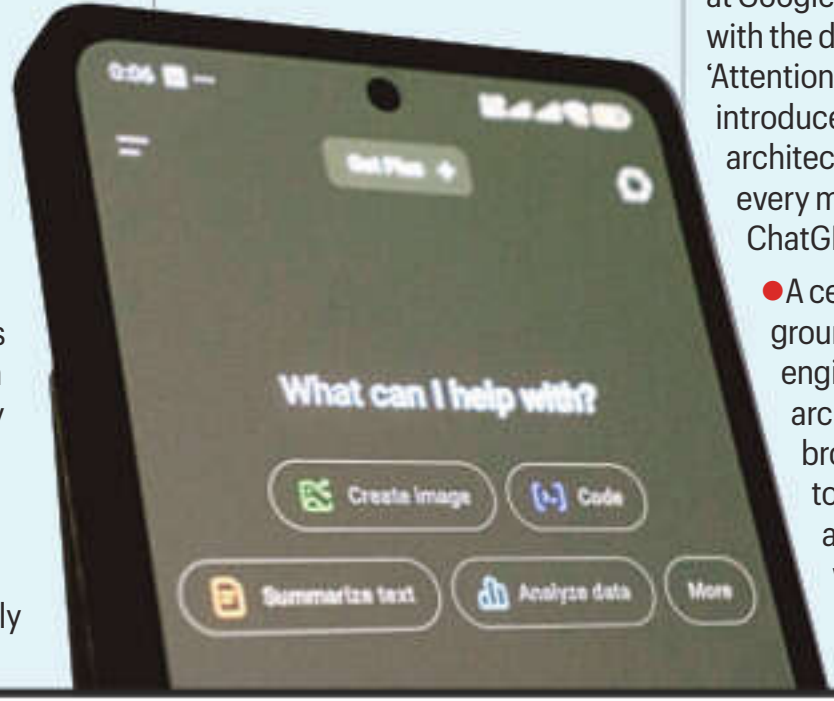
• But the idea of treating language statistically goes back at least to 1913, when the mathematician Andrey Markov analysed the sequence of vowels and consonants in Alexander Pushkin’s novel-in-verse ‘Eugene Onegin’, effectively

inventing what is now called the Markov chain.

• That thread — modelling

language as a chain of probabilities — ran through a century of research until 2017, when eight researchers at Google Brain published a paper with the deceptively modest title ‘Attention Is All You Need’. It introduced the Transformer, the architecture underlying essentially every major LLM since, including ChatGPT.

• A century of statistical groundwork, years of relentless engineering and one architectural breakthrough brought language modelling to a place none of us, staring at early search engines, would have believed possible.



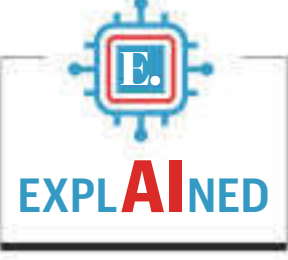
molished is simply how the field works.

AI enters the arena

So, the Jacobian conjecture’s fate is interesting on its own terms. But the more striking story may be the growing role AI models — particularly Large Language Models (LLMs) — are playing in advanced mathematics.

The Jacobian result wasn’t a one-off. In May 2026, OpenAI announced that one of its internal reasoning models had produced a counterexample to a 1946 conjecture by Paul Erdős concerning unit distances between points in the plane — a problem that had resisted specialists for 80 years. The construction put forward by AI was subsequently verified and written up by nine outside mathematicians, including Fields medalist Tim Gowers. Will Sawin of Princeton went on to sharpen the result further.

Three years ago, when ChatGPT was new, I suspect many mathematicians — myself included — assumed LLMs were good for retrieving information already sitting in documents, but incapable of original mathematical thinking. That assumption has not aged well. At the 2024 International Mathematical Olympiad (IMO), Google DeepMind’s AlphaProof and AlphaGeometry 2 — specialised theorem-proving systems, not general LLMs — solved four of six problems



A weekly column decoding AI’s new frontiers, how they shape the world and our place in it

Leveraging LLMs

LLMs are exceptional partners for brainstorming, drafting and accelerating research.

• But like any knowledgeable collaborator, they work best when their most important claims are checked against reliable, independent sources.

AI will likely transform how research in the field is conducted. But it would be premature to conclude that it can solve every mathematical problem

tial and which can be weakened or dropped.

This typically means exploring many possibilities, testing examples, and hunting for patterns. This is exactly the kind of work AI excels at. It can rapidly sift through a vast space of possibilities, surface promising directions, and — when guided by well-formulated prompts and given the relevant mathematical context — even generate proofs. For problems of this type, AI can dramatically accelerate research.

But not every mathematical breakthrough follows this pattern. Some of the deepest advances come from entirely new concepts, unexpected insights or radically different ways of framing a problem — not from searching more efficiently within an existing framework.

Whether AI can reliably produce that kind of conceptual leap is still an open question. So the honest answer is: yes, AI can already help solve many important problems in mathematics, and it will likely transform how mathematical research is done. But it would be premature to conclude that AI can solve every mathematical problem.

The catch

Here is the crucial limitation: an LLM has no built-in guarantee that what it says is true. It generates text that is statistically plausible, not necessarily correct — it is built to produce the most probable answer to your prompt, not a certified one.

There’s a pleasing echo of this, two centuries early, in Boole himself. Soon after proposing his symbolic calculus, he wrote a book with the sprawling title *An Investigation of the Laws of Thought, on Which Are Founded the Mathematical Theories of Logic and Probabilities* (1854). Boole was already trying to formalise reasoning as something you could compute — logic on one hand, probability on the other. Today’s LLMs are, in a sense, living proof of the second half of that title: engines of probability rather than certainty.

But users must remember that LLMs have no innate fact-checker and no direct access to the world beyond its training. It can occasionally produce convincing but entirely wrong statements — the phenomenon now widely called hallucination. It is built to generate the most probable continuation of a conversation, not to certify the truth of every sentence. That combination — extraordinary linguistic and mathematical fluency alongside occasional factual unreliability — defines both the power and the limits of today’s LLMs.

for a silver-medal score of 28/42. By IMO 2025, Google’s Gemini Deep Think worked entirely in natural language, was officially graded by IMO coordinators under contest conditions and solved five of six problems (35/42) — a gold-medal score. OpenAI’s own model reached an identical 35/42 the same year, graded independently by three former IMO medalists.

At IMO 2026 in Shanghai, OpenAI’s GPT-5.6 reportedly solved all six problems on a single unsteered attempt. Independent testing by researchers including SignalPilot Labs suggests several frontier models — GPT-5.6 Sol, Anthropic’s Claude Fable 5, and others — reached a perfect 42/42 score, with Fable reportedly the fastest to finish. These results are self-reported or independently reproduced rather than certified by IMO coordinators. Even with that caveat, the trajectory from silver to gold to a plausible perfect score in three years is a genuine step change from what reasoning models could do at the start of this decade.

Solving critical problems

Much of mathematical research begins with a question — either posed by another mathematician or arising from a real-world application. Often the real challenge is figuring out under what assumptions the question has an answer. If a theorem is already known under stronger assumptions, a great deal of research consists of finding which of those assumptions are truly essen-

• CLIMATE

What makes Kerala particularly vulnerable to landslides

Anagha Jayakumar

New Delhi, August 2

TWO YEARS after the devastating Wayanad landslides, exceptionally heavy rain triggered fresh landslides, mudslides and flooding across parts of Kerala on Saturday, killing at least six people and leaving several others feared missing.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) said that widespread rainfall was likely over Kerala on Sunday and Monday, with heavy rainfall in isolated places and strong winds with 40 to 50 kmph speeds.

Neetha K Gopal, head of the IMD’s Meteorological Centre in Thiruvananthapuram, told The Indian Express that the intense spell was being driven by an offshore trough extending from the south Gujarat coast to Kerala, strong southwesterly winds across the Arabian Sea, and a strong north-south pressure gradient along the west coast. Together, these conditions had strengthened the monsoon flow and produced widespread rainfall across Kerala.

“This was not rainfall confined to one or two places. It was a widespread heavy rainfall event,” Gopal said. She added that

a large quantity of rain had fallen within a short period, leaving little time for the water to drain away.

“It was the cumulative effect of the preceding rainfall, combined with today’s intense and widespread rainfall activity,” Gopal said, underscoring that the landslides were not triggered by a single burst of rain alone.

Why landslides occur

Landslides are natural disasters that occur mainly in mountainous terrains with conducive soil, rock, geology and slope conditions. A sudden movement of rock, boulders, earth or debris down a slope is called a landslide.

While they are fairly common, landslides are extremely hazardous and pose a threat to human and animal lives, damaging property, roads and bridges, disrupting communication lines and snapping power lines.

Landslides generally result from a combination of two sets of factors:

• Conditioning factors, such as soil topography, rocks, geomorphology, and slope angles, among others, make some parts of

Landslide atlas

• In 2023, ISRO’s National Remote Sensing Centre, Hyderabad, released a ‘landslide atlas’ based on landslide events recorded from 1998 to 2022.

• The database showed that while the Western Ghats recorded fewer landslide events than the Himalayan region, Kerala accounted for a disproportionately high share of landslide fatalities.



Rescue operations in Kottayam after a landslide on Saturday. PTI

the country more vulnerable to landslides.

• Triggering factors, which include intense rainfall and anthropogenic activities such as haphazard land use, unscientific construction, and large-scale destruction of forests.

Most landslides in India are rain-induced events. Other natural causes include earthquakes, snow-melting and undercutting of slopes due to flooding. They may also be caused by anthropogenic activities such as excavation, cutting of hills and

trees, excessive infrastructure development, and overgrazing by cattle.

How human intervention increases risk

Kerala’s landslide risk is largely concentrated along the Western Ghats, especially in central and northern districts such as Idukki, Pathanamthitta, Kottayam, Wayanad, Kozhikode and Malappuram. The region’s steep slopes, geology and changing land use make it inherently susceptible to landslides.

During spells of intense or prolonged rainfall, water infiltrates the loose soil and reaches the interface between the soil and the underlying rock, weakening the bond between the two. This is significant because preceding rainfall can progressively saturate slopes, while a subsequent burst of heavy rain can add large quantities of water over a short period, increasing runoff and the likelihood of slope failure.

Land-use changes and human interventions have also contributed to the region’s fragility, with quarrying, road laying, and the expansion of plantations altering the stability of slopes and natural drainage.

• ECONOMICS

Tamil Nadu’s economy is growing rapidly; why are its revenues not keeping pace

Arun Janardhanan

Chennai, August 2

FOR DECADES, Tamil Nadu has been among India’s most diversified and industrialised economies. It manufactures automobiles and electronics, exports textiles, attracts investment, builds highways and industrial parks, and has steadily expanded its services sector.

Yet, the government’s latest White Paper on the state’s finances shows that even as the economy expanded in the post-pandemic years, the government’s own finances weakened. Revenue has failed to keep pace with economic growth and debt has continued to rise.

It is against this backdrop that the Tamil Nadu government has now constituted the Revenue Augmentation Committee under former Planning Commission deputy chairman Montek Singh Ahluwalia.

On paper, the committee’s mandate is straightforward: improve tax administration, plug leakages, identify new tax and

non-tax revenues, recommend reforms, and suggest ways to increase revenue from liquor and public assets.

But viewed through the White Paper, the committee is really being asked to answer a much larger question. Why has the state’s revenue stopped reflecting the growth of its economy?

Growth, revenue: Out of step

The White Paper shows that Tamil Nadu’s own-tax effort (revenue from taxes the state levied) weakened even during the post-Covid economic recovery. The White Paper characterises this deterioration as structural rather than cyclical. It points to administrative shortcomings, leakages and corruption as major reasons for declining revenue effort. But identifying leakages is only one part of the exercise.

“Fast-growing sectors may not be adequately captured. Some activities may be lightly taxed relative to their economic value. In other areas, taxes may exist but enforcement may remain weak. Adminis-

• Tamil Nadu’s revenues	
YEAR	OWN TAX REVENUE AS % OF GSDP
2021-22	5.93%
2022-23	6.63%
2023-24	6.22%
2024-25	5.78%
2025-26 (RE)	5.45%

SOURCE: STATE BUDGETS, RBI, ‘WHITE PAPER ON THE FISCAL MANAGEMENT OF TAMIL NADU’

trative inefficiency, evasion and exemptions together may prevent the state from collecting what the economy is already generating,” a senior official with the state finance department told The Indian Express.

Revenue not only factor

The committee’s title focuses on rev-

enue augmentation, but there is another equally important question: how efficiently is public money being spent?

“Public finance does not improve only by collecting more. It also improves when leakages on the expenditure side are reduced,” said a senior consultant attached to the state finance and expenditure domains. “Procurement systems, project implementation, subsidies, contracting and delivery mechanisms all become part of the conversation about fiscal sustainability. The White Paper itself notes that committed expenditure — including salaries, pensions and interest — has steadily consumed a larger share of revenue receipts, leaving progressively less fiscal space for development expenditure and capital investment,” he said.

Rebuilding non-tax revenues

The committee has also been asked to examine non-tax revenues — from dividends of public sector undertakings and land monetisation to user charges and public utilities.

Experts point out that the quality of public services influences the willingness of citizens to pay fees, charges and tariffs. Fiscal reform, therefore, is inseparable from administrative reform. Technology occupies a central place in the committee’s terms of reference. Digital systems can simplify compliance, reduce discretion and improve monitoring. Yet experience across departments suggests that technology alone rarely eliminates corruption.

“Many departments including the Road Transport department have already undergone substantial digitisation. Yet corruption and commission practices often survive because institutions gradually adapt around technological safeguards. The challenge therefore lies not merely in introducing digital systems but in strengthening governance itself — aligning incentives, increasing accountability, improving supervision and ensuring that institutions cannot simply discover new ways to bypass technological controls,” said the expert advising several government plans in association

with the state finance department.

Difficult choices

If improving compliance appears politically straightforward, other recommendations may prove considerably more contentious. The committee has been asked to examine user charges, liquor policy, asset monetisation and other non-tax revenues.

Each involves trade-offs. Higher registration fees may affect property markets. Changes in utility charges may influence affordability. Altering liquor policy raises questions extending well beyond revenue alone.

Also, multiple experts known to the new committee formation and its purpose said the expenditure reforms may require uncomfortable assessments of whether every programme is delivering outcomes proportionate to its fiscal cost.

The committee’s challenge is therefore also political.

FULL REPORT ON INDIANEXPRESS.COM/EXPLAINED

Idea Exchange

MONDAY, AUGUST 3, 2026

NEW S M A K E R S I N T H E N E W S R O O M

WHY KT RAMA RAO

The Working President of Bharat Rashtra Samiti (BRS), KT Rama Rao, is working overtime to revive his party in Telangana after facing back to back electoral setbacks and rift in the KCR family. At a time when regional forces are struggling to stay afloat in many states, the suave and articulate KTR is up against both the Congress and the BJP in his state while battling cases and fending off charges of a tacit understanding with the ruling party at the Centre. The near absence of his father and BRS supremo K Chandrasekhar Rao (KCR) from the political scene continues to be a challenge but KTR is confident of an electoral come back

Manoj C G: The Kaleshwaram Lift Irrigation Project was one of the major reasons for the BRS defeat in the 2023 assembly elections, which the Congress said is a structural failure of the K Chandrashekar Rao (KCR) government. They have also accused the government of corruption and technical irregularities. The state government has already recommended a CBI probe. But the Congress says there is some sort of understanding between you and the BJP and that's why a CBI probe has not even started.

First, despite what my opponents in the Congress and the BJP would like to believe, let me tell you, it's been 12 years since the BJP has been in power in Delhi. It's been almost 32 months since the Congress has come to office in Hyderabad. If any of these allegations have a shred of evidence in them, then they would have taken us out clean. The Kaleshwaram project brings drinking water to Hyderabad, gives water to industries, irrigates over 40 lakh acres of land in dry, arid Telangana. So, we are open to investigation. But, I would like to ask: After the Congress government resumed office in Telangana, the Srisailem Left Bank Canal (SLBC) project had a tunnel collapse, where eight people died. Neither the BJP nor the National Dam Safety Authority (NDSA) have said a word. Other than us, nobody else is speaking about it. In the country today, agencies like ED, CBI, IT have been weaponised and used as instruments to coerce and bulldoze people into submission. Two years ago, a Congress minister's house and about 15 premises were raided by the ED. Three note counting machines were taken in. Guess how many cases have been filed since then? Neither has the minister said anything nor has the ED. Two days after the raid, a minister goes and meets a big industrialist at a hotel in Hyderabad and everything is hushed up. Then, the Hyderabad Central University, controlled by HRD ministry, is pledged to ICICI bank, and takes a loan of Rs 10,000 crore. The whole agenda was to bring Rs 30,000 crore by either selling it or mortgaging it. The students began protesting, attracting national attention and eventually the state government had to retreat because the Supreme Court Green Bench had intervened and constituted a centrally empowered committee. It's been two years and no action has been taken yet. There is an unholy nexus of the Congress and the BJP in Telangana. Chief Minister Revanth Reddy's brother-in-law gets contracts in Central government schemes and BJP MPs get contracts in Telangana. *Dono ka itna zabardast Fevicol ka jodd hai* (The two are so closely knit) that we find it difficult to fight both at the same time.

Manoj CG: There's been a continued absence of KCR (K Chandrashekar Rao) from the political scene. Is it not hampering your revival efforts?

He's been active but not in the public eye. He's been dealing with organisational matters and whenever the situation demanded he has come forward, spoke on how the state government was capitulating to the Krishna River Management Board and how it was meek to not stand up to the Union government. He has spoken on a number of issues that have mattered to the state. He believes in democracy and believes in giving time to the incumbent government. We are all trained by KCR, so whatever we say, whatever we speak, is basically his line and the party line.

Manoj C G: During the CJP protest, you also addressed meetings in Hyderabad. Do you think it was a setback for the BJP government? And is there a message in this for the Opposition as well?

The protest was an inflection point. It is definitely a sign because it wasn't just about NEET or CBSE or an exam paper leak. All the pent-up angst needed a trigger. So, should the BJP be worried? Absolutely, because Gen Z is the biggest voting bloc in the 2029 election.

The incumbent government should be worried. And should the Opposition be ashamed? Yes, we all should be, including Rahul Gandhi. We were not able to inspire confidence among the youth to rally with us. KCR very famously predicted this in 2020. He said India will react and it will rise to the occasion. This generation has shown spine. ED, CBI, IT *bacchon pe kaam nahi karta* (doesn't work on the kids).

Liz Mathew: We have seen what happened to BRS sometime ago and in West Bengal too. Do you think there is a deliberate attempt from so-called national parties to finish off regional parties?

In India, there are regional parties and then there are bigger regional parties there are no truly national parties which have presence in 28 different states. Yes, the BJP and the Congress are far bigger than us but the hypocrisy of these two parties stand out. If your party has the strength and there is strength in your fight, then no one can finish anyone. Even now, I don't think TMC is finished. Because regional parties have their ear to the ground. So, they are here to stay. Give somebody unbridled power, things can go wrong. In two-and-a-half

ON THE DELIMITATION BILL

If it's for public good, then increase the MLA seat in each state. That won't alter the geography of the state or the boundaries of Parliament. India has more than 4,000 MLA seats, make it 6,000, like you did in J&K



ON THE RECENT YOUTH PROTESTS

From the perspective of the Opposition, we need to understand that the angst of the youth is real and we need to evolve and quickly come out with some solutions and a roadmap ahead. Else, we will be confined to history

Manoj C G: The Telangana Rashtra Samithi became Bharat Rashtra Samithi (in 2022) with a national ambition. At some point, you wanted to forge the third front. What is happening to that ambition now?

If Telugu movies can become pan-India movies, why should Telugu parties not become pan-India parties? Having ambition is not such a bad thing. We tried to dabble in national politics but now our priority is clear. We want to win back, at home first. We have to win back Telangana, only then the rest. Right now, we want to remove the BJP-Congress joint venture government from the state.

Sandeep Singh: You've been listing all the achievements under your government. From agriculture to infrastructure. So, how did you lose the plot?

See, people in India are economically bankrupt. Politicians and the political system are intellectually bankrupt. It's a deadly cocktail. That's exactly what happened when KCR was giving Rs 10,000 to farmers under the Rythu Bandhu scheme. Congress came and said, 'We will give Rs 15,000'. And when KCR was giving Rs 1 lakh as a gift to any young girl getting married so as to avoid underage marriages, Congress came and said, 'We will give 10 grams of gold also', under the Kalyana Lakshmi scheme.

This was our third term of fighting elections. In 2014 and 2018, we won on our own. In 2023 also we fought alone. What was the gap? Four lakh. The difference was just 1.8 per cent. Even for the third time Modi ji stopped at 240 (seats). We had no allies, that's why we didn't come to power.

Politics is cyclical. Sometimes we lose, sometimes we win. The simple fact is that because of unrealistic things that were said (by the Congress) and promises made, showing people false dreams, is why we lost.

Pushkar Banakar: What do you think is missing with the Congress's approach in Telangana?

I think probably the passion, love for Telangana and basically administration is missing. They are busy looting and sending money bags to Delhi.

Manoj CG: You said that the BRS will return to power in 2028. You're very confident of it. What would you do differently from what it was from 2014 to 2023.

We did well, we didn't lose the plot. Just because we lost in one election, it doesn't mean we have to change everything. We will make sure we go back to people and tell them what we have done. We will bounce back and we will bounce back strong.

Liz Mathew: What is the biggest criticism you have against this particular NDA government?

Well, delivery. They have not delivered. By 2022, Indian farmers' income was supposed to be doubled, it is 2026. By 2022, India was supposed to be a five-trillion economy, but it is still at 4.15 trillion. By 2022, every poor person in India was supposed to have a home, I don't know if that has been delivered. That's why you see the protest spilling onto the streets. You promised two crore jobs and Rs 15 lakh in everybody's account. None of this happened.

What did happen is that now I know Liz Mathew is Christian, I'm Hindu. I know another person's religion and what he does. That has taken centre stage. That has become the discussion point, unfortunately. What else have we achieved in this country?

We are happy comparing ourselves to Pakistan and Bangladesh. China is already a 20 trillion economy. In the mid-1980s, we were a bigger economy than China. 45 years later, what did we deliver? A prime minister, a government with absolute mandate, a non-Gandhi family for the first time who squandered a brilliant opportunity. That's the biggest disappointment as an Indian.

Apurva Vishwanath: Telangana has led with high-intensity surveillance for a long time. It is surveillance without consent. What inbuilt safety modules do we have for this mass surveillance?

You call it mass surveillance, I call it law and order. The primary responsibility of every single government is the well-being of its citizens. In Hyderabad, when we launched this initiative of Safe Smart Hyderabad, we envisioned a situation where an integrated command control centre would come to the rescue in the event of a disaster, or a law and order issue so that we can collate all the information and address the issue swiftly.

Now, have we infringed on the citizens' privacy? No. These are public areas which are being surveilled. They are not intruding into any individual's home.

I can tell you that in limited areas where known rowdy sheeters reside, those places are cordoned and searches done, to serve as a deterrent. But, I don't think any normal citizen has been stopped randomly and questioned. These are all backed by legislation, where we ensure that our cities, our streets, are kept safe. That is the intent.

'People are economically bankrupt and politicians are intellectually bankrupt. It's a deadly cocktail'

KT Rama Rao on Bharat Rashtra Samithi's time for revival in Telangana, breaking the BJP-Congress partnership in the state, why the delimitation bill is unfair to the south and political parties are disconnected from the youth. The session was moderated by Manoj CG, Chief of National Political Bureau, *The Indian Express*



KT Rama Rao (right), Working President, Bharat Rashtra Samithi, with Manoj CG, Chief of National Political Bureau, *The Indian Express*, at the Noida office. RENUKA PURI

years, we are coming back in Telangana and will also be an important force in Delhi.

Liz Mathew: Your sister has gone out of the party and created a new one.

No individual is above the institution, be it my sister, myself or anybody. The institution is TRS and the leader is KCR. So, if individual ambitions or individual desires overpower what the collective of the state wants, then so be it. I think it is for the people to decide our fate.

Vandita Mishra: You said the CJP protests were an inflection point. What are the two or three things that you need to learn from what has happened, going forward?

We can all unanimously agree that we have not been able to inspire these kids to work, rather sail with us. We need to figure out why we are not able to inspire confidence in them. So, that's the first thing we need to do, introspect. Second, look at what happened in Tamil Nadu recently. The two Dravidian parties were set aside and the new entrant was given an opportunity. So sometimes, anything new seems attractive. But more importantly, from the perspective of the Opposition, we need to understand that the angst of the youth is real and we need to evolve and quickly come out with some solutions and a roadmap ahead. Otherwise we will also be confined to history.

Vandita Mishra: Why do you think political parties have not been able to connect with the young?

To a large extent, the aspirations of the youngsters are not being understood. What have we not done? I'd say probably even the good work that we've done, we've not been able to communicate it properly. Maybe we are not engaging enough on the mediums that they are relying on, be it Instagram, Reddit or Discord. So yes, maybe there's a communication issue and not so much as

alignment in terms of what we want for the country.

Sandeep Singh: On the Women's Reservation Bill and the Delimitation Bill, are you ok with the increase of the existing number of seats in the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies by 50 per cent?

Well, let me put it this way, why is delimitation needed? Primarily because we believe decentralisation is important. It's written in the Constitution that every 10 years there will be a census and, with it, delimitation shall happen. The whole premise of delimitation, the whole premise of freezing the number of seats at 543 in 1971 was to control population. Those who controlled their population, like the states in south India, Punjab and

Odisha, they are being punished. *Unka aap gala ghoti ge* (You tighten the noose for them) and tell them their seats will decrease, and those who haven't controlled their population, like Uttar Pradesh, Bihar or Madhya Pradesh, you will increase their seats?

If they want to do the delimitation for public good, then increase the MLA seat in each state. That won't alter the geography of the state or the boundaries of Parliament. India has more than 4,000 MLA seats, make it 6,000. Do it like you did in J&K. But when it comes to Parliament, today, there is a 24 per cent representation of southern states in Parliament. Our population today stands at about 19 per cent. If you are going to tell me that in 1971, my population and my number of seats were proportionately decided at 24. Today, it has to



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ON HIS CRITICISM OF THE NDA GOVT

In the mid-1980s, we were a bigger economy than China. 45 years later, what did we deliver? A prime minister, a government with absolute mandate, a non-Gandhi family for the first time who squandered a brilliant opportunity



{ WEEKLY CAPSULE }

Best way to lower oil in French fries

A NEW COOKING method could make French fries crispier in less time while significantly limiting how much oil they absorb. Researchers at the University of Illinois have proposed combining microwave heating, which keeps oil out. The researchers found that as much as 90 per cent of frying occurs while the food is under negative pressure. That creates a suction effect, allowing oil to move into the newly-opened pores. A more effective frying process would keep pressure inside the potato positive for a longer period and reduce the amount of time spent under negative pressure.



Metformin’s hidden brain impact

A DECADES-OLD diabetes drug just got a surprising twist. Scientists have discovered that metformin doesn’t just work in the liver and gut — it also acts directly in the brain, where it taps into a hidden control centre for blood sugar. By switching off a protein called Rap1 in a key brain region, the drug activates specific neurons that help lower glucose levels, even at tiny doses, found researchers at Baylor College of Medicine. The findings point to new opportunities for developing therapies that directly target this brain pathway. While the liver and intestines need high concentrations of the drug to respond, the brain reacts to much lower levels.



Natural molecule for weight loss

STANFORD MEDICINE researchers have identified a naturally occurring molecule that may suppress appetite and reduce body weight in a way that resembles semaglutide, the active ingredient in Ozempic. In animal studies, the molecule also appeared to avoid several problems associated with the drug, including nausea, constipation and substantial muscle loss. The molecule, known as BRP, works through a different but related metabolic pathway and activates a separate group of neurons in the brain. That distinction could make it a more precise tool for controlling appetite and body weight.



Rice bran may tame IBS

A COMPOUND in rice bran may help calm an over-active gut by reducing the calcium signals that cause intestinal muscles to contract. Ferulic acid suppressed contractions triggered by several chemical messengers in laboratory experiments. The discovery could eventually support new dietary approaches for diarrhoea-related digestive disorders, although it may make constipation worse, according to new research from Toho University. Ferulic acid is a polyphenol found in many plant-based foods, especially whole grains and rice bran. It is already known for its antioxidant and neuroprotective effects.



Toddler foods are ultra-processed

A GROCERY-STORE audit found that many foods marketed for toddlers may be far less healthy than parents expect. Of nearly 2,800 products examined in Texas, 81 per cent were ultra-processed, and almost half failed at least one World Health Organization (WHO) nutrient standard, often because they contained too much sugar, sodium, fat or too many calories. The audit was done by the American Society for Nutrition. What children eat during their toddler years can influence the flavours they prefer and the dietary patterns they follow later in childhood, with consequences for long-term health.





SUGAR-FREE LIFE

DR MOHAN

CHAIRMAN, DR MOHAN'S DIABETES SPECIALITIES CENTRE, CHENNAI

Why your blood sugar is linked to fatty liver, hepatitis

High blood sugar doesn’t just affect your heart, kidneys and eyes. Get screened

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

WHEN 58-YEAR-OLD Ramesh (name changed), who had been living with Type 2 diabetes for over a decade, came for his routine diabetes review, he expected the conversation to revolve around his blood sugar levels, medication and HbA1c or the three-month average sugar count. Instead, I suggested a liver function test and asked if he had been vaccinated against Hepatitis B. He looked puzzled. “Doctor,” he asked, “I have diabetes. Why are we talking about my liver?”

Most people think of diabetes as a disease that affects the heart, kidneys, eyes and nerves. Very few realise that the liver plays an equally important role in diabetes, and that looking after liver health is an essential part of managing the condition. My patient had silently developed fatty liver. People with Type 2 diabetes have a higher risk of developing liver disease, particularly fatty liver disease. If they also develop viral hepatitis, they are more likely to experience complications. Yet the liver is often overlooked during discussions about diabetes, even though it is central to the body’s metabolism and blood sugar regulation. The liver stores glucose and releases it whenever the body needs energy. In people with Type 2 diabetes, insulin resistance causes extra fat to accumulate in the liver over time. Doctors now refer to this condition as metabolic dysfunction-associated steatotic liver disease (MASLD), and it is extremely common among people with diabetes.

The concern is that MASLD is usually silent in its early stages. Left unchecked, it can gradually progress to liver

inflammation, scarring, cirrhosis and, in some cases, even liver cancer. This is why liver health deserves far more attention in people living with diabetes.



People with diabetes have a higher risk of Hepatitis B. Hepatitis C worsens insulin resistance and increases the chance of diabetes

Hepatitis B and C are the two viral infections we watch most closely. People with diabetes have a somewhat higher risk of Hepatitis B, particularly in settings where infection control during medical procedures or routine glucose monitoring is inadequate. Hepatitis C has a different relationship with diabetes. It actually worsens insulin resistance and can increase the likelihood of developing Type 2 diabetes. In many ways, the relationship between diabetes and hepatitis is a two-way street, with each condition influencing the other.

A damaged liver struggles to regulate blood sugar effectively, causing glucose levels

to fluctuate unpredictably. In advanced liver disease, doctors may also need to adjust the doses of diabetes medications because the liver is responsible for processing many of these drugs. That is why diabetes and liver disease should never be managed in isolation. They need to be addressed together to achieve the best outcomes.

Unfortunately, fatty liver disease and chronic hepatitis rarely cause symptoms in their early stages. Most people feel perfectly well until significant liver damage has already occurred. Rather than waiting for symptoms to appear, regular check-ups and appropriate screening are the best ways to detect liver problems early, when they are most treatable.

So should you get your liver tested as part of routine diabetes care? In many cases, yes. As part of comprehensive diabetes care, your doctor may recommend liver function tests, an ultrasound examination or other specialised investigations if anything appears abnormal. If you have received blood transfusions in the past, have been exposed to unsafe injections or have a family history of hepatitis, it is also worth discussing screening specifically for hepatitis B and C with your healthcare provider.

If you have not already received the hepatitis B vaccine, I would strongly recommend discussing it with your doctor. Vaccination is one of the simplest and most effective ways to protect yourself against hepatitis B infection and the long-term liver damage it can cause. The encouraging news is that the same healthy habits that help control diabetes also protect the liver. Keeping your blood sugar under good control, staying physically active and maintaining a healthy weight all reduce stress on the liver. A balanced diet rich in vegetables, fruits, whole grains, pulses and healthy fats, while limiting sugary foods, refined carbohydrates and saturated fats, benefits both conditions. Equally important is avoiding alcohol and refraining from taking medications or herbal supplements without medical advice, as some of these can be harmful to the liver.

‘His guitar still waits’

How a NEET aspirant’s family is learning to heal

Kahaan Patel’s suicide at 17 changed his family forever. Psychologists explain why parental grief doesn’t end but how remembrance can become part of healing

Reva Thakkar

THE BOOKS are gone. The biology notes, mock test papers and dog-eared textbooks that had once taken over Kahaan Patel’s room now sit inside a cupboard, packed away one-and-a-half months after his death. But the guitar remains where he left it. His father, Advocate Prashant Patel, has discovered that grief follows no logic. Some things it asks you to put away. Others, it refuses to let you touch. Like the guitar.

“I was going to buy him a car when he turned 18”, the 45-year-old says of his son, who took his own life at 17, unable to cope with the pressure of a re-test following a paper leak and cancellation of the NEET exam. “I had even planned a guitar stand in the car trunk so he could carry it everywhere,” says Prashant. After the NEET results, he had promised himself, he would get Kahaan a customised stethoscope.

Before medicine became his singular ambition, Kahaan was simply a curious child. He built Lego models, dismantled toy aeroplanes to understand how they worked and loved trekking with his family. Later came football, the ukulele and heavy metal music. He wanted an electric guitar, but postponed buying one because the entrance examinations were too close. By Class XI, Kahaan had changed schools to prepare for the NEET exams better. For the next two years, life revolved around studies as holidays disappeared. Hobbies became rewards for a future yet to arrive.

When he finally walked out of the examination hall on May 3, that future finally seemed within reach. His friend Dhruvi says Kahaan was confident of scoring around 650 out of 720 marks and securing a seat in a government medical college. For the first time in months, he allowed himself a holiday with friends at a farmhouse near Surat. The news of the NEET paper leak broke him. Kahaan became far less certain and anxious, worried if he could get top notch scores yet again. That performance anxiety pushed him over the edge.

Naina Shahri, a psychologist who has spent over a year working on a suicide helpline and now provides trauma support to students, says overwhelming stress often changes the way people experience possibility itself. “When someone has invested years into one goal and suddenly experiences something that feels deeply unfair or beyond their control, it can create profound helplessness. Instead of believing the system has failed them, they begin believing they themselves have failed,” she says. This



PHOTOS: PRASHANT PATEL



summarises what could have been Kahaan’s last straw.

The questions that never stop

In the weeks after Kahaan’s death, Prashant’s grief settled into details as he replayed conversations that had once seemed ordinary. He wondered if he should have called his son more often during the weeks leading up to the re-examination instead of worrying that he might disturb his revision. He thought about a family holiday the previous year that Kahaan had later joked had cost him valuable study time.

“The grief of losing a child can be unbearable,” says Shahri. “Parents often revisit conversations again and again, wondering if something could have changed. They search for signs they may have missed and go on a guilt-trip. But grief doesn’t move in a straight line. It returns to the same questions because the mind is trying to make sense of something that feels impossible to understand,” she adds.

Psychologists describe this as one of the most common responses to traumatic loss. The brain keeps reconstructing the past, hoping to find a version of events in which the ending is different and comforting. It is less about finding answers than about trying to regain a sense of control after an event that shattered it. For Prashant, speaking about his son has become part of a survival strategy. “I want to remember him. I want to talk about him,” he says. Silence to him is far more frightening.

Dealing with grief

Grief, in most cases, resolves gradually without professional help. “The support

Kahaan Patel’s guitar still stands in his room; Prashant Patel with his sons in happier days



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from family, social network and sometimes religious practices and reassurance usually suffice. If there is lack of social support, short-term help from a counsellor is needed,” says Dr Mamta Sood, professor of psychiatry, All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), Delhi.

Resolution, she argues, is a process that comes in waves where one confronts the reality of the loss and simultaneously pursues ongoing activities of life. “It is important to acknowledge the sadness and other symptoms a person is experiencing. There is need for professional help for prolonged grief disorder which involves psychotherapy and medications. For depressive disorder, professional help is needed,” says Dr Sood. She cautions against chinks in the family unit itself. “Family members could express anger toward each other over perceived failure to save the deceased. Scapegoating of one or more family members is common,” she says.

Grief did not arrive the same way for everyone in the Patel family. Veena, Kahaan’s mother, withdrew into herself. Friends describe her as trying to stay strong for their younger son, Rihaan. Yet even in the middle of her own grief, she began asking whether there were places where she could volunteer with children struggling under academic pressure. For psychologists, that instinct reflects something important. “People often think healing means forgetting or moving on,” says Dr Mimansa Singh Tanwar, clinical psychologist and head of the School Mental Health Programme at Fortis Adayu. “It doesn’t. Over time, many bereaved parents begin looking for ways to create meaning. For one parent, it may be

advocacy. For another, it may be supporting other children or simply finding ways to keep their child’s memory alive.” The hardest part, she says, is allowing grief to exist without trying to rush it away.

Families often tell bereaved parents that time will heal everything. Those reassurances, however well intentioned, can leave people feeling lonely. “What they need most is space to express what they are experiencing. To have someone simply listen without judgement, without trying to fix it or explain it,” adds Tanwar.

There is another grief that goes unseen. Rihaan, Kahaan’s 13-year-old brother, has heard adults tell him, in different ways, “Don’t do what your brother did.” Children who lose siblings are frequently overlooked, psychologists say, because so much attention is focused on grieving parents. Yet they are grieving, too, while navigating fear and expectations that others may now place upon them. “Let children talk freely about the dead,” advises Dr Sood.

For Dhruvi, trauma processing is going over Kahaan’s voice notes, old messages and photos. Kahaan had saved her from school bullies. “Since then he became a friend I could trust,” she says. A month after Kahaan’s death, she called a friend and stayed on the phone until morning. Divya, a psychotherapist who works with people navigating grief and loss, says moments like these underline why connection matters after suicide. “Grief can become isolating,” she says. “Naming emotions, talking about them and allowing someone else to sit with that pain reduces the intensity of what they’re experiencing. It doesn’t erase grief, but it helps make it survivable.”

She also challenges one of the oldest assumptions about bereavement — that healing requires letting go. Many people continue speaking to loved ones who have died, listening to their voice notes, celebrating birthdays or holding onto photographs. Rather than preventing healing, these continuing bonds often become part of it. “We don’t ask people to stop loving someone simply because they died,” says Divya. “The relationship changes, it doesn’t disappear.”

Learning to carry absence

The guitar remains. It is still difficult for Prashant to imagine giving it to someone else. “Healing is not about returning to the person you were before loss. It is about slowly building a life around an absence that will always remain,” says Tanwar. For Prashant, it means speaking publicly about his son because silence feels more stifling than remembrance. For Veena, it is searching for ways to help other children facing pressures like the ones Kahaan carried. “I now work extra hours so that I can spend more time with my family without regret and cherish Kahaan’s memory,” says Prashant.

With inputs by Rinku Ghosh

● POLICY MATTERS

Why school junk food ban alone won’t curb childhood obesity

Experts debate Maharashtra move, say lasting change will need healthier eating at home and physical activity

Purnima Sah

THE MAHARASHTRA Food and Drug Administration’s (FDA’s) decision to ban the sale of chocolates, chips, sugary drinks, deep-fried snacks and other foods high in fat, salt and sugar (HFSS) in schools and within a 50-metre radius of campuses has been welcomed by doctors as an important step towards tackling childhood obesity. However, health experts say the measure will have a meaningful impact only if it is backed by healthier food choices at home, nutrition education in the community and regular physical activity.

The move comes amid growing concern

over childhood obesity in India. The World Obesity Atlas 2026 estimates that around 41 million Indian children aged 5-19 years are overweight or living with obesity. In Maharashtra, the National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5) found that 4.3 per cent of children under five were overweight, compared with the national average of 3.4 per cent, although the survey does not capture obesity among older school-going children.

Dr Tushar Palve, medical superintendent at Cama and Albless Hospital, Mumbai, says the ban directly targets the three biggest dietary contributors to childhood obesity — excess fat, salt and sugar. “Foods high in fat contribute to weight gain and fatty liver dis-

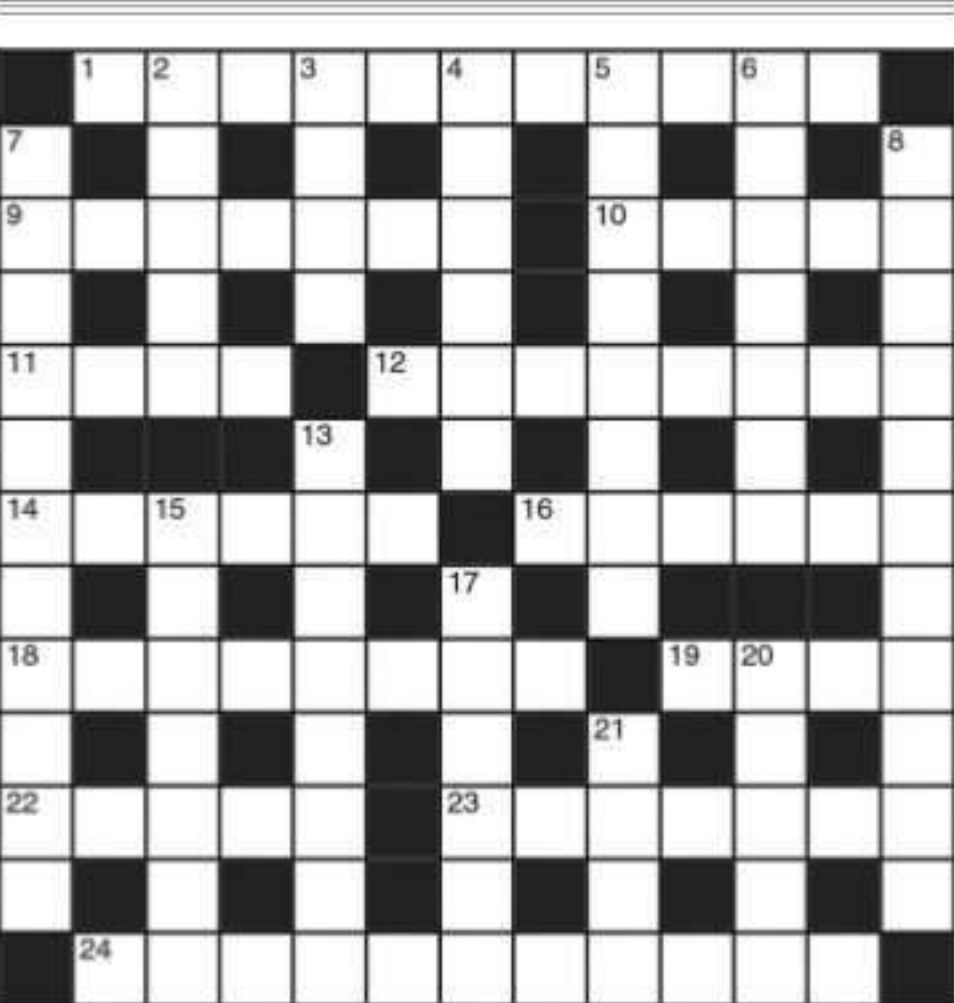


GETTYIMAGES

Children continue to be exposed to unhealthy foods outside school through neighbourhood shops, food delivery platforms and advertising

ease in children. High salt intake increases the risk of hypertension, which we are now increasingly seeing even in children. Sugary beverages such as soft drinks cause sharp insulin spikes, promote fat storage and increase the risk of diabetes. Banning these foods from schools removes the biggest source of all three during the six to seven hours children spend on campus.”

• CROSSWORD



ACROSS
1 Clever Diane comes to the rescue (11)
9 She plays with the electricity switch (7)
10 Weapon for a knight who's lost a lot (5)
11 A noble brew of ale that's about right (4)
12 A title to own empty cargo space (8)
14 In a gem blemishes affect the standard (6)
16 Upper class taken in by government figure (6)
18 Dies of cold (3,5)
19 Shad in which all the players appear (4)
22 The leading spirit in Russia (5)
23 It's about being relevant (7)
24 It's shaped to last (4,7)

DOWN
2 Stop being an outsider (5)
3 One to be crossed with a goat (4)
4 Possibly run and see to make certain (6)
5 Mail sent astray results in complaints (8)
6 Associate with a swindling type? (7)
7 Persuade it's fantasy (4,7)
8 Tease driver wickedly to seek more publicity (11)
13 Control a toboggan rising in speed (8)
15 The scope of the Bard? (7)
17 Worker about to fight - watch out (6)
20 Quite enough; in fact ideal without former wife (5)
21 Pace of progress from the start to decay (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6056 ACROSS: 1 Ashore, 4 Astonish, 9 Tussle, 10 Habitual, 12 Coin, 13 Evils, 14 Were, 17 Exaggerating, 20 Entomologist, 23 Inns, 24 Rival, 25 Etna, 28 Intimate, 29 Spring, 30 Deployed, 31 Extent **DOWN:** Articles, 2 Hospital, 3 Rule, 5 Scarlet woman, 6 Odin, 7 Inures, 8 Holder, 11 Ever so little, 15 Aging, 16 Annoy, 18 Diatribe, 19 Straight, 21 Pitted, 22 Instep, 26 Ammo, 27 Apex

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Our ____ are our gardens to which our ____ are gardeners (6,...,5)
EOSIN EWYDLL
ENIIS AMNOBW
ANSWER: Our bodies are our gardens to which our wills are gardeners

• OVER THE HEDGE



• CALVIN & HOBBS



• MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s INSTRUCTIONS
To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.
DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius
SUDOKU 6399
SOLUTION SUDOKU 6398

BY MICHAEL FRY & T LEWIS

• ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): This is a lovely day for you! You will feel empathetic and tuned in to your surroundings. You feel warm and friendly to everyone and concerned for their welfare. Tonight: You're powerful.
TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): This is a feel-good day! You'll enjoy time spent alone in private moments or solitude because you're sensitive to the problems of others today. This will heighten your feelings of compassion. Enjoy relaxing at home. Tonight: Solitude.
GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): You're interested in the world today! You might feel sympathetic about a friend or a group, which, might prompt you to become involved in a charitable organisation. Tonight: Be friendly.
CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): People notice you today. You can use this to your advantage if you want to set an example, especially an example that is caring, compassionate and generous to others. You also feel confident about your finances today. Tonight: Be modest.
LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Your desire to expand your world is strong today. Not only are you interested in travel, you're also interested in big ideas. Because your idealism is aroused, you want to help people in need. Tonight: Explore.
VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): You're happy to work alone or behind the scenes today. You might do fundraising or use the wealth and resources of someone else to benefit others. Your ambition is aroused. You're interested in talking to younger people. Tonight: Check your finances.
LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): This is a popular day, and you're eager to chat, especially with members of the general public. You might have a strong connection with a partner, spouse or close friend. Your sympathies are aroused, perhaps for someone close to you. Tonight: Be cooperative.
SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): You make a fabulous impression on others today, which is something you can use if you want to persuade someone about something that is dear to your heart. This could be about a charitable cause, or it might be something that is work-related or even related to your health. Tonight: Get organised.
SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Do something different today. You're keen for adventure! Accept invitations to socialise. Romantic interests as well as playful times with kids will delight you. Tonight: Relax and socialise.
CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Today you might want to help a family member. You're certainly sensitive to the needs of family members right now. You might research ways to get funding or help for someone who needs assistance. Tonight: Home and family.
AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): You're an idealist who is concerned about the welfare of society. Today you might be out there with petitions because you care about a cause. Your imagination is heightened today, which promotes artistic fantasies. Tonight: A lively discussion.
PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): If you can do something to help others, especially related to your job, you will. You feel sensitive to the concerns and problems of someone. You might be personally generous with your own funds. Tonight: Check your belongings.

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, Mohan Ram S/o Sh. Chanar Ram R/O CRD-II/7, Pandara Park, New Delhi-110003 have changed my name from MOHAN RAM to MOHAN KUMAR for all future purposes.
0071051554-1
I, Neeraj kumar, inform that my surname name is wrongly recorded as "Neeraj Kumar Yadav" instead of "Neeraj Kumar" in my 10th, Intermediate memos. Both name are one and the same person vide affidavit dt. 30-06-2026.
0050294260-1
I, Rukhsana, W/o Mohd Aslam, R/o B-18, Gali No. 4, Brahampuri, Seelampur, Delhi-110053, have changed my name to Ruksana and shall hereafter be known as Ruksana.
0040869268-4
I, SURESH DHINGRA S/O RAM JI DASS DHINGRA, R/O 63-A, BLOCK-C-5, KESHAV PURAM, DELHI-110035, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO SURESH KUMAR DHINGRA FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSES.
0071051533-1
I, Rekha Kumari wife of Pradeep Kumar R/O RZF-13B, Gali No.4 Veer Nagar West Sagarpur, New Delhi-46 have changed my name to Namrata Devi following my marriage, in accordance with Affidavit No. IN-DL64377408218160V dated 29/07/2026
0050294259-1
I, Aslam, S/o Abdul Karim, R/o B-18, Gali No. 4, Brahampuri, Seelampur, Delhi -110053, have changed my name to Mohd Aslam and shall hereafter be known as Mohd Aslam.
0040869268-5

LOST & FOUND

I Akanksha Sagar have lost my 3rd Year B. tech (CSE) marksheet year 2015 roll no. 1322210010 APIAKTU
0040869532-1

COURT NOTICE

Public Notice
It is hereby informed to the general public that my client, Mrs. Sharda Devi, W/o Late Shri Mahender Prakash Sharma, R/o WZ-1628A, Nangal Raya, New Delhi-110046, has disowned / debarred her son Mr. Krishan Kumar Sharma, his wife Mrs. Vandana Sharma, and their daughter Ms. Mokshi from all her movable and immovable properties with immediate effect. They have been living separately from my client since 2009, and all family relations with them stand severed. They shall have no right, title, claim or interest in any of my client's properties. My client shall not be responsible or liable for their any act, transaction, liability, loan, agreement etc with the public in future.
Sd. R.M. Tiwari (Advocate)
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Tis Haskari Courts Delhi-54

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वेबसाइट: www.greaternoidaauthority.in, ई-मेल: authority@gnida.in
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महाप्रबन्धक (अभियन्त्रण), ग्रेटर नौएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण द्वारा मुख्य कार्यपालक अधिकारी, ग्रेटर नौएडा की ओर से ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या-बंरि० प्र० / (ई-निविदा सेल) / २०२६ / ७८४ दिनांक ३१/०७/२०२६ के माध्यम से उल्लिखित क्रम संख्या-०१ से १३ तक के कार्यों की ई-निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती हैं। समस्त नियम व शर्तें ग्रेटर नौएडा प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट www.greaternoidaauthority.in पर ई-निविदा लिंक एवं ई-पोर्टल <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर उपलब्ध हैं। किसी परिवर्तन, संशोधन व अतिरिक्त सूचनाओं के लिए उक्त वेबसाइट देखते रहें।

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6.	ग्रेटर नौएडा के ग्राम रामपुर बांगर में ६ प्रतिशत आबादी मुखब्डी हेतु (जंगल सफाई, पटरी ड्रेजिंग, नाली सफाई एवं अन्य विविध कार्यों) का तीन वर्ष तक रख-रखाव/अनुसूचन कार्य। (वर्क सॉर्किल-६)	₹० १३६.२३ लाख
विद्युतीकरण के कार्य		
7.	ग्रेटर नौएडा के ग्राम पोवारी में गौशाला के विद्युतीकरण का कार्य (फैस-१) (वर्क सॉर्किल-ई एण्ड एम-२)	₹० ६७.३६ लाख
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AUCTION FOR SALE OF SUN FLOWER PROCURED BY TG MARKFED DURING YASANGI 2025-26
Tender notification for online e-Auction on disposal of Sun Flower Yasangi (Rabi) 2025-26 procured by TG MARKFED auction for the quantity and lots as mentioned in the e-auction portal through <https://auction.telangana.gov.in/> i.e. Telangana e-procurement portal (Applications in e-procurement portal will be available from 11:30 AM on 03.08.2026).
1. E-auction bidding will commence on 11.08.2026 from 10:00 AM to 05:00 PM
2. Last date for submission of EMD: 07.08.2026 upto 05:00 PM.
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I/c Chief Engineer (Project and R & C)

STPL's NOTICE FOR INVITING TENDER No. N-09/2026-27
MAHAGENCO
Maharashtra State Power Generation Co. Ltd.
Sinnar Thermal Power Limited (STPL)- A Joint Venture Company of MAHAGENCO and NTPC Ltd., invites offline bid offers from reputed and experienced bidders to participate in the competitive bidding process for the following tender.

SR. TENDER No.	TENDER NO.	TENDER SPECIFICATION	COST OF TENDER RS.	EMD RS.	SALE PERIOD FROM	SUBMISSION & OPENING DATE
1	T-15/ 2026-27	Replacement of Existing GRP Make-up Water Pipeline with Mild Steel (MS) Pipeline from Odha Pump House to STPL for Sinnar Thermal Power Ltd.	Rs.26,550/-	Rs. 5,00,00,000/-	03/08/2026 To 20/08/2026	21/08/2026 & 21/08/2026

Sealed offline tender bids are hereby invited from eligible and interested bidders for the above mentioned work. The tender documents will be available in offline mode during office hours. Interested bidders may collect the documents from STPL office Add.- Plot No.-A-1/1, Musalgaon and Gulwancha village, IIIL, SEZ, Taluka Sinnar, Dist. Nashik-422112
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Email: cnmdept@sinnartpl.in / ceo@sinnartpl.in
Sd/- Chief Executive Officer, STPL, Sinnar.
New Delhi

MEDAL Tally					
	Country	G	S	B	Total
1	AUS	70	45	56	171
2	ENG	29	45	36	110
3	CAN	19	20	23	62
4	IND	13	17	9	39
5	SCO	13	9	17	39

Glasgow eatery to change logo after Lovlina flags incorrect India map



Lovlina Borgohain. PTI

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 2

A GLASGOW-based restaurant said that it will change its logo after a video of boxer Lovlina Borgohain pointing out that it depicted an incorrect map of India went viral. Minutes after putting the statement out on its Instagram handle, the outlet deleted its account on the social media platform. The Indian boxing contingent had a celebratory dinner at 'Mister Singh's India, The Home of Curry' in Glasgow on Saturday following India's historic haul of 10 boxing medals — seven gold and three silver — at the 2026 Commonwealth Games. Olympic medallist Lovlina had won silver in the women's 75kg category.

"Mr Singh's India is very proud of our Indian heritage and ancestry, for almost 32 years we have served, for India and around the world," the restaurant had said in a statement. "First and foremost, we would like to unequivocally apologise for the depiction of the wrong map of India. We will take immediate steps to correct this. Once again our sincere apologies, we never wanted to offend anyone rather wanted to serve with pride to Indian contingent." "We will change the logo with proper map. It was our humble privilege and honour, that we served team India, after their fantastic, achievements in the Commonwealth Games. All athletes and guests thoroughly enjoyed their evening, these memories will last with us for India. Team Mr Singh India"

In the video that went viral, Lovlina can be seen holding up the restaurant's napkin that had the logo, which she said depicted an Indian map without the North Eastern part of the country. "Please don't take this the wrong way. I felt a little hurt by this. In the map of India, our North East is missing, yes, even outside, the map that's displayed has cut off the North East. As someone from the North East, that really hurts us. That's all I wanted to say. Please keep this in mind next time. Thank you so much," Lovlina can be heard saying in the video.

ON THE CHARGE

Gulveer's Glasgow double signals India's arrival in distance running

After two CWG medals, the 27-year-old has shown India can challenge the best long-distance runners in the world

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, August 2

DAYS AFTER dazzling the Scotstoun Stadium in Glasgow with a silver medal in 10000m, Indian ace runner Gulveer Singh produced another stellar show in the men's 5000m to win the bronze medal and became the first Indian to do so.

With two medals in track events, Gulveer has etched his name in history by becoming the first-ever Indian to achieve this feat in the history of the Commonwealth Games. Gulveer clocked 13:24.95s to finish third ahead of Cornelius Kemboi of Kenya in a photo finish. "I am happy with the bronze medal. But I want to win more medals. My hunger is still not quenched," Gulveer said in the mixed zone. In both his events, Gulveer faced intense competition from African athletes and that is what makes the medal more special.

In the 5000m, he was 2024 U20 World Champion Andrew Alamisi of Kenya, Tokyo Olympic medallist Mohammed Ahmed of Canada, and 10000m champion Ky Robinson of Australia. Similar to his 10000m race, Gulveer stuck to his strategy of staying in the inside rails with the leading pack, accelerating when needed and producing a thrilling last kick to finish.

"We followed the same strategy as the 10k to run the shortest distance by staying inside, keep in touch with the front pack and position well for the last 400m to finish strongly," his coach Simmons told *The Indian Express* from Glasgow. However, his performance is not flash in the pan, given the Army man from Sirsa, Aligarh has been India's best long distance track

• The breakdown

1000m: Gulveer was placed fourth behind Kamohelo Mofolo, Ky Robinson, and Md Ahmed.

2000m: Gulveer fell back twice but covered two positions to end 2000m at 5th place.

3000m: Steady run from the Indian and he finished the split at 5th place.

4000m: Gained one place to enter the last 1000m at fourth place

4600m: He was fifth entering the last lap.

4800m: Produced a brilliant kick to enter medal position.

5000m: Maintained his position and dipped ahead of Cornelius Kemboi in a photo finish.

runner in the past three years. What changed in him in the past two years has been his transformation from just another runner in the pack to a genuine medal contender.

While he has been dominant at the Asian level, his two medals at Commonwealth in presence of African runners has established his claim as a medal contender.

Making of Gulveer

When Gulveer started training under Scott Simmons, he would struggle to catch up with the likes of multiple Olympic medallist Paul Chelimo in training. But during his CWG campaign, he defeated different World and Olympic medallists. The journey from there has been focussed on making him a world beater.

"The biggest key behind Gulveer's transformation to a medal winner has been consist-



Gulveer Singh became the first Indian to win two track medals in the same CWG edition. PTI

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> in different tough positions which eventually helps me later," Gulveer had told this paper once.

The finishing kick

The last kick in distance running is equally important for both athletes and viewers. While viewers enjoy the thrill of a close finish, athletes rely on it to etch their name in history books.

In the both 10000m and 5000m events, Gulveer produced a kick that earned him the admiration of the fans. But Simmons believes that there is a lot more work to be done. "We have been working to improve his finishing speed for four years. And we still have some to improve," said Simmons.

Gulveer had a learning moment at the 2025 World Championships in men's 5000m heats where he was fourth by 4000m but faded away and fin-

ished ninth missing the historic qualification for final. "The World Championships were a disappointment but also a great learning experience. It's important to note that he was pipped at the line by World & Olympic Champion Jakob Ingebrigsten, so you can't fault him for that," said Simmons. "However, you can see what he is capable of."

When asked what next for Gulveer, Simmons said more and more training. "We have a few things to work on. He didn't win gold in 5000m, that is something we want to change," concluded Simmons. When Avinash Sable broke the Kenyan domination in men's Steeplechase in 2022, it gave India a hope of getting medals in track events. Gulveer's medal has confirmed that there is an Indian track athlete who can take on the world. For Indian athletics, that may be the most important takeaway of all.

Giant-slayer Sakshi makes her left jab count

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, August 2

THAT WOMEN'S boxing weight category is stacked. It's where MC Marykom won her Olympic medal and twice World champ Nikhat Zareen was most dominant in the past few years. England's Ruby White came in with an undefeated streak of 70 wins. Then at Glasgow, she ran into Sakshi Chaudhary's left jab as the Bhiwani boxer was crowned the Commonwealth Games 51kg champion.

Her immediate moments after the 5-0 win for one of India's seven golds in India's historic campaign, were spent consoling White, empathizing with her opponent, recalling her own barren run in 54kg. It had been a long wait since the last CWG at Birmingham.

"Itni bhookh thi iss gold medal ki. Bohot lamba intezaar tha. (I was hungry for this gold after waiting so much.) I didn't think about Ruby's history or what she's done in the past. I wanted to take home the gold

and that's what I did", Sakshi told *The Indian Express*. "She (White) was crying till the medal ceremony and I was consoling her that all has not ended. Having seen highs and lows in my career too, I could feel her disappointment. With this gold, I can say Sakshi has arrived," she added.

The Dhanana village pugilist belongs to the Bhiwani Boxing Club, and started boxing with Vijender Singh as her role model. She dominated the world junior boxing circuit alongside her friend and team-mate Nitu Ghanghas who had two world youth titles. Sakshi won the World junior title in 2016 followed by her two youth titles in 2017 (54kg) and 2018 (57kg). A bronze in Asian Championships in 2021 and her maiden national title followed the next year. The 2022 CWG beckoned.

But a shoulder injury set her back by a whole 18 months. The comeback, as she spent time at her village with parents, training occasionally under coach Jagdish Singh, went south.



Sakshi Chaudhary. PTI

"Any junior who wants to make the transition to senior would want to win titles. And I tried that. During the injury, I thought practice would help me avoid negative thoughts. But it worsened," she recalls. "When it healed, I knew I had to make a fresh start," says the army boxer.

Her elder brother Aman Chaudhary, who is now a captain in the Indian Army, too remembers the tough times. "There were days Sakshi would feel dejected sitting at home. I

would remind her of how our father Manoj Kumar left all of his farm work to support her training as well as how she started boxing seeing Vijender Singh and how she would also win medals like him," he says.

Sakshi also talks about support from her long-time friend Nitu. "Me and Nitu started boxing on the same day. When she won the title in Birmingham, I saw it as my medal. I know she too would have felt the same when I won the medal last night," says Sakshi.

After her title at the World Boxing Cup in Astana in 54kg, Sakshi appeared in assessments for the Asian Championships, where Preeti Pawar made the cut. Sakshi decided to step down to the 51kg division, where Nikhat Zareen ruled.

With 48kg world champion Minakshi Hooda too moving to 51kg for the trials, Sakshi would defeat both booking her ticket to Glasgow as well Asian Games. "I have been a coach since 1984 and in my coaching career, I have never seen a left jab as good

as Sakshi's," coach Jagdish says. 51kg boxers all have speed, but longer levers mattered. "Sakshi utilised her long range well. Nikhat and Ruby White are close range and mid range fighters but Sakshi did not let them come close and also used her right straight and left hook in counters well," he adds.

Indian women's head coach Santiago Nieva too believes Sakshi has the game to dominate 51kg, though making weight will remain a challenge. "Sakshi used her jab well and showed discipline. She has one of the strongest punches in 51kg and her long range as well as footwork helps her well," says Nieva.

With the Asian Games next and challenges pouring in from Uzbekistan, Kazakhstan as well as China, Japan and Thailand, Jagdish knows his ward needs to work harder. "All these boxers are hard-hitters and mostly rely on close range. Sakshi has to utilise her speed as well as long range against such boxers and all will depend on her timing of punches," said Singh.

Kerr wins chaotic men's Mile on event's return after 60 years



World record holder Josh Kerr enthralled his home crowd. AP

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 2

JOSH KERR blazed down the final lap as the partisan crowd in Glasgow's Scotstoun Stadium rose to its feet and applauded. Their star runner had just clinched the gold medal in men's One Mile at the Commonwealth Games (CWG) 2026 with a timing of three minutes 54.12 seconds.

At one moment, it looked like it might be a Scottish one-two on the podium but Jake Wightman faded away in the last 100m, as Australia's Cameron Myers took silver and Kenya's Timothy Cheruiyot bagged bronze. "It means everything — this was the championship of my season. With the World Indoors and going after that record in London, this was the one I had circled in the calendar before any of that," Kerr told TNT Sports.

Coming into the CWG, Kerr was the outright favourite after breaking Hicham El Guerrouj's 27-year-old record in London last month.

The race was a fitting tribute to the return of the famous event to the CWG programme after a 60-year absence. Kenyan great Kip Keino won the last men's Mile race at the Games, clocking a Games-record time of three minutes 55.34 seconds in Kingston, Jamaica, in 1966.

Men's Mile was one of the blue-riband events of CWG before the metric era took over and 1500m was included into the program. The race was immortalized in 1954 when the two athletes who breached the four-minute barrier, Roger Bannister and John Landy, ran in the race dubbed as 'The Miracle Mile'.

While it lost relevance due to the metric system, the race was resurrected in the 1980s with a series of epic battles between Britons Steve Ovett, Sebastian Coe and Steve Cram, who swapped the world record six times between them.

One of those men from the 1980s, World Athletics president Sebastian Coe, was responsible for getting the event back to the CWG programme. "The One Mile is the quintessential Commonwealth athletics event whose return to the Games in Glasgow 2026 I very much welcome," Coe had said. "The event's place in international sporting lore was secured when Sir Roger Bannister broke the four-minute barrier in May

1954. Ever since, the world has enjoyed the Miracle Mile, the Golden Mile, the Dream Mile and countless other similarly dubbed races over the distance."

Kerr's dominance

The 2023 world champion in 1500m, Kerr announced two weeks before the London Diamond League that he would break El Guerrouj's world record. Staying true to his word, Kerr clocked 3:42.66, obliterating Guerrouj's record.

On Saturday night, he again produced an audacious performance. At the 1100m mark, Kerr was placed ninth. As the last lap started, he elbowed and barged his way to the front before producing a devastating kick, leaving everyone chasing him behind and crossing the finish line comfortably.

"London was a big stress, pushing my body to the absolute extreme limit. Doing a championship race is a nice clean palate, really using your brain instead of your body, and it's how I love to race. It doesn't get any better than this — this is absolutely incredible. To do it in front of a Scottish crowd where I learned to race — I came here week after week growing up as a kid," Kerr said.

Aus's podium sweep

The return of One Mile marked another historic moment as for the first time, women athletes participated in the famous race. While the men's final was chaotic, the women's final was lopsided with Australia sweeping the podium.

As Abbey Caldwell, Jess Hull and Claudia Hollingsworth went around the track four times, there was no one who could better them.

Lining up alongside each other, Caldwell burst off the line while Hull held back as Hollingsworth settled into the pack ahead of her. It was a slow race but with 200m to go, Caldwell burst clear and Hull joined her. While Hull couldn't match Caldwell, she won her second silver medal after finishing behind Rose Davies in the 5000m.

As these two Aussies finished the race, Hollingsworth found the space and energy to burst past Naomi Korir and claim bronze.

With no clarity over the future of event in the CWG programme, the return of the once fabled event was suitably chaotic and colourful.

• COACHING YOUNGER ONES

Mirabai, the mentor: When not lifting weights, India's golden girl is lifting morale

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, August 2

THERE IS barely any podium Saikhom Mirabai Chanu has yet to step onto. The Commonwealth Games has long ceased to be one of those pursuits. In 2014, an unassuming teenager arrived in Glasgow under the watchful eye of the legendary Kunjarani Devi and left with a silver medal. Twelve years later, she returned to the same city as one of India's most decorated athletes, with Olympic, World Championships and Commonwealth Games medals already in her cabinet.

That she won her third successive CWG gold medal was par for the course. Even when not at her best, she lifted 190 kg, finishing 22kg clear of the silver medallist. Yet, beyond the

numbers, she revealed a side seldom explored — where she was not lifting weights, but lifting her compatriots' morale with her words. Alongside head coach Vijay Sharma, Mirabai emerged as an integral part of India's support system.

Second nature

After returning to India on Sunday, she explained why that mentoring role has become second nature to her.

"Vijay sir has been our guide throughout the competition. I tried to support him. At times, my school of thought might differ from that of sir, so we would discuss things and develop strategies. At times, our Manipuri weightlifters also struggle with the language barrier. Because I speak the language, I help communicate the

coach's messages to them. Basically, I try to contribute wherever I can to make the job easier for our coach," Mirabai told *The Indian Express*.

Five of India's 11-strong weightlifting contingent were from Manipur — a state that continues to cement its status as the country's weightlifting powerhouse.

"I like helping others. This is not something new — I have always tried to help other lifters after my events are over, because seeing them do well brings me joy. I think it is very important that I extend help — and not just to increase our medal tally. I also want my fellow Indian lifters to perform to their fullest potential. If my cheering and guidance helps them do that, I am happy. At this Commonwealth Games, I tried



Mirabai Chanu was the only weightlifter to win gold in Glasgow. AP

motivating multiple lifters. It feels good when I can help them, because it gives me confidence as well," the silver medal-

list at the Tokyo Olympics said. Coach Sharma believes Mirabai's presence alone boosts the contingent's morale, given

Five of India's 11-strong weightlifting contingent were from Manipur — a state that continues to cement its status as the country's weightlifting powerhouse.

her stature. "Mirabai Chanu is an icon of the country. We all know that, and so do the lifters. They are all inspired by her. So, when someone like Mirabai is trying to motivate them, it really helps because it means a lot to the lifters that a legend like her is actively trying to contribute to their medals. Moreover, she

also helps in communication. The Manipuri athletes find it a bit difficult to understand instructions at times — so, if not for Mirabai, my task would be a lot more difficult," he told this newspaper. The pair worked together at the Weightlifting Warriors academy as well. "It was Vijay sir's and my dream to have an academy where we would train only female lifters, because this is a sport that women seldom pick. So, we started that academy. When I train them, I reminisce about my childhood days. I share my experiences with them."

Focus on Asian Games

Despite completing a hat-trick of Commonwealth Games gold medals, one prize still eludes Mirabai: an Asian Games medal. She finished

fourth in Hangzhou three years ago. In a couple of months' time, she will have another chance to set the record straight. "I have won every medal that I wanted to win, save for one — an Asian Games medal. I am completely focused on that," said Mirabai.

Sharma also sounded confident when he said, "Our main worry at the Commonwealth Games was making the weight division. It was 48kg this time, whereas in the previous edition, it was 49 kg. That drop does make a difference. Despite competing in 48kg, she did an incredible job. At the Asian Games, the field will indeed be very competitive, but she will get to compete at 49 kg. Given how she competed at the Commonwealth Games, I am really confident about the Asian Games."

Fleming a 'big reason' for Root's return as Eng captain



Joe Root. AP

Express News Service
Chennai, August 2

JOE ROOT said Stephen Fleming's appointment as England's test coach was a "big reason" he agreed to return as captain of the squad. Root replaced Ben Stokes after the all-rounder retired following the home series against New Zealand.

Fleming succeeds compatriot Brendon McCullum, whose four-year test tenure ended last month, though he remains England's white-ball coach.

"If I'm being brutally honest, it was a big reason why I wanted to do it," Root told the England and Wales Cricket Board.

"I'm very excited by the way he sees the game, where he sees us sit as a team, and the work that we have to do to get to where we want to get to. All of that got me very excited about taking this role on."

Years of practice

"He's obviously got a wealth of experience and done some amazing things within the game as a player and as a coach, and I'm very much looking forward to the next little while, and us trying to build something pretty special together." Former New Zealand captain Fleming coached Chennai Super Kings for 17 years in the Indian Premier League before leaving last month. Root led England as their full-time test captain between 2017 and 2022 before he was replaced by Stokes.

Stokes and McCullum championed a take-no-prisoners approach, which endeared them to the fans and Root hinted he and Fleming would like to retain that attacking mindset.

"The last four years have been the most fun I've had in professional cricket...", said the 35-year-old. "Clearly, the last little while is probably what's fresh in everyone's mind, but you're looking at a four-year period where we did a lot of amazing things." I've taken a lot from that, and I feel it will be a big part of how I want to approach things moving forward as a leader of this team."

England host Pakistan for a three-test series beginning in Leeds on August 19.

“If I'm being brutally honest, it was a big reason why I wanted to do it. I'm very excited by the way he sees the game, where he sees us sit as a team, and the work that we have to do to get to where we want to get to”

JOE ROOT,
ON WHY HE RETURNED AS CAPTAIN AFTER FLEMING'S APPOINTMENT

Without Bumrah, India face fresh bowling dilemma in Sri Lanka

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, August 2

INDIA ARE yet to board the flight to Sri Lanka for a crucial two-Test series, but even before they land on the Emerald Isle, they have suffered a massive setback. The surfaces are likely to assist spin, but even in those conditions, Jasprit Bumrah's importance could not be understated. On Sunday, the 32-year-old was ruled out of the series after failing to recover in time from the knee injury he suffered in England.

India are fifth on the World Test Championship (WTC) table and the two Tests in Sri Lanka are crucial to keep their WTC final qualification hopes alive. A fragile batting unit on turning tracks notwithstanding, India will have to take on Sri Lanka without their pace spearhead. Ever since Bumrah injured his left knee (via impact in the game), the expectation was that he would be available

for the series starting in Galle on August 15. When the BCCI named the squad for the series, they added an asterisk to say that Bumrah's availability was subject to fitness.

The hope that the 32-year-old would play at least one of the Tests has also evaporated. The Indian Express understands that the impact injury he sustained at Cardiff has only aggravated the knee issue that has been persisting since the T20 World Cup.

While Bumrah did recover from that injury and was cleared to feature in the IPL without any trouble, the blow he suffered in England aggravated the underlying issue.

The Indian Express understands that as per the rehab programme, after taking an injection, Bumrah was expected to resume bowling over the weekend and gradually build his workload ahead of the Tests. But that is unlikely to happen any time soon with the pacer



Jasprit Bumrah will not be available for the two-Test series. AP

advised to rest.

Given his importance, India were even ready to wait for a week and fly him to Sri Lanka, where they will first play a three-day warm-up fixture from August 7 at Colombo. If not, the idea of training and recovering with the team was also explored, but the medical team

at the Centre of Excellence has preferred to tread cautiously, keeping the long-term future in mind.

New plan

Instead, the focus has shifted towards finding a long-term solution rather than merely managing the injury.

• Bumrah's workload*

Format	Played	Missed
Tests	22	5
ODIs	2	28
T20Is	33	45

*SINCE 2023 ODI WORLD CUP

"The solution is not a stop-gap. If we rush him now, then there is a strong chance he could break down again," sources in the know revealed.

The 50-over World Cup next year, along with the New Zealand tour in October and the Border-Gavaskar Trophy in January, remains top priority.

India are hesitant to take any risks with Bumrah by hurrying him up. Since suffering a career-threatening back injury, he has managed his workload with utmost care, preferring not to rush. Bumrah remains firm on playing all three formats, and the decision not to hasten his return has

been taken with an eye on future challenges.

Search for Plan B

Bumrah's absence means India will have to alter their plans significantly in the bowling department. With Washington Sundar already ruled out of the first Test and doubtful for the second, they will no longer enjoy the luxury of batting depth. The question that confronts them is, in case Sri Lanka opt for flat decks that start turning later on in the Test, who will partner Mohammed Siraj? Beyond him, the other options available in the squad are Prasidh Krishna and Gurnoor Brar, with Jammu and Kashmir's Auzib Nabi being the front-runner to replace Bumrah.

While Prasidh's natural length may not be suited to the conditions in Sri Lanka, he has worked, off late, to rectify the issue. If India prefer to go with a pacer who takes conditions

out of the equation, then they might turn to Brar, as his raw pace can be a factor across conditions. Nabi, if he joins the team, offers something unique, but whether they play him straightaway remains the question.

Though Bumrah featured in all four Tests at home last year against West Indies and South Africa, he played in only three out of the five Tests in England last year.

Given his back trouble, he didn't play successive Tests and in Sri Lanka, there is only a three-day gap between the two matches that will be played in Galle and Colombo's SSC.

India leave for Sri Lanka on Tuesday, having not played Test cricket since the home series against South Africa in November. A short camp and a three-day warm-up fixture in Colombo will precede the opening Test in Galle, where they will have to adapt quickly to life without Bumrah.

TRIUMPHANT TEEN

Tanvi wins first big title, is the youngest Taipei Open champ

17-year-old Indian defeated her opponent on the back of exquisite timing on smashes

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, August 2

INDIA HAS watched the sting smash of Saina Nehwal and boasted the steep expansive crosscourt smash of PV Sindhu. Now, welcome the Tanvi Sharma smash with timing and titanic theatre embedded in it.

Trapezing on that super shot, Tanvi repeated Nehwal's title heroics from 2008. The 17-year-old from Hoshiarpur in Punjab became the youngest Taipei Open champion. Tai Tzu-ying won it at 18 years, 85 days. "Really very, very happy. I didn't expect to win a title but I thought I'll give my best here. I was going step by step, match by match. Every match I played really well even though I was quite nervous. I thought I will give my 100 percent. What I have, my game, I will play that. I played my game," she said after the win.

Tanvi defeated Vietnamese Thuy Linh Nguyen to win her maiden Super 300 at the Taipei Open where her propensity to squander advantages lent some additional drama to proceedings, apart from her shot-making that included quality straight smashes.

Coached by her badminton-loving mother in her early years, the younger of two daughters had literally cornered her mother's attention with the timing on her smashes and drops. She strikes the shuttle from the sweet spot of the racquet head, hits it at a precise stage of its flight and transfers power into the shoulder and snappiness into the wrist to make it a terrifically-timed hit. Hers is a game that will impress neutral fans by its sheer silk. In Tai Tzu-ying territory of the Taipei Arena, India's youngest Nationals finalist added many fans. But the

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+42RvD_RG9fmljMzgj



Tanvi Sharma won her first Super 300 title, defeating Thuy Linh Nguyen in straight games. BADMINTON PHOTO Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

It was apt somehow that Tanvi won her first senior title of this level in Taipei – there are shades of Tai Tzu-ying and Saina Nehwal in her, and the amalgam of those two games can only point to success

ception to get to 12-9.

Pristine skill

Those slashed smashes found a variation at 17-9 when one was slightly angled, not cross, just crooked. But always deep into the backcourt. The shot variety compared not just to Tai Tzu-ying's, but also to the other Taiwanese great who was in attendance: two-time Olympic champion in men's doubles and now the country's Sports Minister, Lee Yang.

Wrapping up the first game, however, was made entertaining by the Indian. From 19-12 up, Tanvi continued to wrack up errors with her drops straying wide, the pushes heading long as Nguyen came to 15-19. But the smash was back - a reboot, a confidence-boost, a supercharger to her game that somehow brings her back on track. She would take the opener 21-16.

The Indian started the second game 0-3 down, but was quickly back in possession of the lead at 8-4 and 15-8 on the back of all-court roundedness and her pet stroke. But a moment of magic that got Tai Tzu-ying land in a tizzy was to come at 12-9. Tanvi had sent a backhand from close to the backline, and stuck out the racquet to her right and flicked the wrist for a forehand push on the next return that was reminiscent of a viral Shoibul Fikri-stroke. At 17, it was a pristine skill.

The 15-8 lead was too much

for the Vietnamese 28-year-old, 11 years older. And the Indian marched to the title gloriously, urging coach Park to join her on the podium for the medal ceremony. It was apt somehow that Tanvi won her first senior title of this level in Taipei - there are shades of Tai Tzu-ying and Saina Nehwal in her, and the amalgam of those two games can only point to success. The final might well heal her heartbreak from losing the World Junior final, and the long illness effects from dengue - which she played through.

"It was hard playing five matches. I needed to be consistent. I have to work harder to play Super 500 and Super 750s," she said. India now has a fourth title winner at \$300 level after Saina, Sindhu and Devika Sihag. She even donned a winning yellow.

Tanvi Sharma has arrived. And the timing on the smash and overhead deception is impeccable as ever.

• BRIEFLY



Yashaswini Ghorpade beat Sreeja Akula in the final. PTI

HOSTS DOMINATE

Ankur, Yashaswini clinch Commonwealth TT singles titles

ANKUR BHATTACHARJEE and Yashaswini Ghorpade clinched the men's and women's singles titles with contrasting wins at the 22nd Commonwealth Table Tennis Championships in New Delhi. Bhattacharjee emerged a deserving 4-3 winner over Payas Jain after a hard-fought match. Payas looked set for victory after opening a 7-4 lead in the deciding game. However, Ankur called a timeout that disrupted his opponent's rhythm, and fought back to level at 8-8. He eventually sealed the title 11-9. In the women's final, Ghorpade delivered a commanding performance to defeat Sreeja Akula 4-1. India dominated the championships, winning all but one of the gold medals on offer.

PTI

Jamshedpur FC exit a 'punch in the gut': Chhetri

INDIAN FOOTBALL legend Sunil Chhetri has expressed his anguish over Indian Super League side Jamshedpur FC's decision to pull out of the upcoming season, describing the development as "a punch in the gut" and urging the club's management to reconsider. "To know that Jamshedpur has folded first team operations is a punch to the gut. The players and staff will be without clubs, and they might find one by the end of it all. The League will have a team less, but the season will go on," wrote Chhetri, India's all-time top goalscorer. "It takes a lot to be a stakeholder in Indian football. It has been like that for some time now. But when everything around looks like it will crumble, you bank on family to hold on to each other. And more often than not, it is the elders in the house that you turn to for assurance," Chhetri wrote. PTI

Juventus sign Kolo Muani from PSG for €38 mn

JUVENTUS HAVE signed Randal Kolo Muani from Paris St Germain, the two clubs announced on Sunday as the France forward returns to the Serie A side where he spent half a season on loan last year. Juve said they had paid 38 million euros (\$43.80 million) for Kolo Muani's services along with performance-related bonuses of up to 12 million euros, with the 27-year-old signing a contract until 2031. In his first stint at Juve, Kolo Muani scored 10 times in 22 matches before he was loaned to Tottenham Hotspur for the 2025-26 season. Kolo Muani has 32 caps for France, scoring nine goals, but he did not make the squad for the 2026 World Cup where the team reached the semi-finals. Earlier, Juventus announced that they had signed winger Kerim Alajbegovic from Bayer Leverkusen. REUTERS

• TROUBLE AT THE TOP

Infantino's position looks unacceptable: Head of Euro leagues

Reuters
Zurich, August 2

GIANNI INFANTINO'S position as FIFA president looks untenable following his failed plan to sell a stake in the World Cup's commercial rights, the head of Europe's professional football leagues said on Sunday.

Claudius Schaefer, whose organisation represents 53 professional men's and women's football leagues, said there could be "only one consequence" for Infantino after his plan triggered a storm of protest from regional associations.

"When I saw how this whole thing unfolded and that FIFA's

key bodies weren't involved, then there's essentially only one consequence in any company or association," Schaefer told Swiss newspaper *SonntagsZeitung*.

Asked if this meant that Infantino was now unacceptable as FIFA president, Schaefer said: "This is usually the consequence when someone in a company pushes such a business deal forward without anyone knowing about it."

Infantino said on Friday that FIFA had scrapped the plan after a widespread backlash. Confederations UEFA and CONCACAF said on Saturday they had lost confidence in his leadership. Schaefer, also



Infantino had proposed a plan to sell stakes in the World Cup. AP

“Nobody knew about the plans, not even the FIFA Council, the governing body of FIFA. I was very surprised that the president was acting completely alone in this matter”

CLAUDIUS SCHAEFER,
REPRESENTS 53 PRO LEAGUES

chief executive of the Swiss Football League, said the proposal suggested that FIFA's

main goal was to maximise profits for third parties by having more and bigger competitions in future.

"It's solely about the financial advantages, everything else is completely ignored," he said.

The European Leagues opposed this because it would add more matches to an already packed international calendar to the detriment of national championships, Schaefer said.

"Nobody knew about the plans, not even the FIFA Council, the governing body of FIFA. I was very surprised that the president was acting completely alone in this matter."

Arteta expects more reinforcements to arrive

Reuters
August 2

ARSENAL WILL splash more cash before the summer transfer window closes, manager Mikel Arteta said, insisting the Premier League champions will not "sit still" while they prepare to defend their first English top-flight title in 22 years.

Arsenal have been relatively quiet in the market compared to big-spending rivals Tottenham Hotspur, Manchester City and Chelsea, but the north London side have been linked with moves for Newcastle United midfielder Bruno Guimaraes and Real Madrid winger Vinicius Jr.

While Arteta would not be drawn on Arsenal's reported pursuit of the pair, he told reporters on Saturday that the club were determined to "improve and evolve" the squad.

"We expect to have movements in the next few weeks, obviously," the Spaniard added, speaking after a 4-1 pre-season win over Girona. "We want to get better like anybody else, and you just can see the transfer market and our opponents, what we are doing."

"We won't sit still and we are very ambitious with what we are doing". Arsenal have so far signed goalkeeper Illan Meslier and forward Christos Tzolis.